

Fate's Edge: Comprehensive Resource Guide

Comprehensive Reference Document

Risk, consequence, and sharp choices at the table.

Version v0.9

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0.1 Reviewer's Guide: Understanding Fate's Edge

This will be removed in Production

0.1.1 Reframing the Evaluation

Fate's Edge is not a traditional tabletop RPG to be evaluated by comprehensive rule mastery. Instead, it is a **narrative partnership** designed to evolve with your table's storytelling sophistication. Approach this review through the lens of **progressive storytelling enhancement** rather than static mechanical complexity.

0.1.2 Key Evaluation Framework

Start Simple, Discover Naturally

- **Session 1:** Core mechanic + 1-2 regional generators = complete playable experience
- **Session 5:** Comfortable integration of multiple subsystems
- **Session 20:** Intuitive mastery where mechanics become invisible

The Partnership Model

Rather than "learning a game," players develop a "storytelling partnership" where:

- Rules serve narrative consequences, not simulation accuracy
- Complexity emerges from interaction, not individual component sophistication
- Prep burden shifts from authoring content to facilitating discovery

0.1.3 Common Misunderstandings to Address

Content Volume vs. Discovery Process

Misconception: "Too much content to master" **Reality:** Content is designed for gradual discovery through play

Reviewer Guidance:

"Imagine a library where you only need to know about the books relevant to today's story. The rest exist to be discovered when narrative ambition demands them."

Prep-Light vs. Prep-Free

Misconception: "No prep means unstructured play" **Reality:** Prep is embedded in the constraint lattice

Reviewer Guidance:

"The system replaces authored prep with guided storytelling. Every card draw is improvisation with guardrails."

Mechanical Simplicity vs. Narrative Sophistication

Misconception: "Simple mechanics = shallow stories" **Reality:** Sophistication emerges from constraint interaction

Reviewer Guidance:

"Like jazz with a vast repertoire, the same simple rules that handle Session 1 magic effortlessly scale to manage Session 50 world-changing consequences."

0.1.4 Evaluation Methodology

Progressive Complexity Assessment

1. **Tier I Play** (30-40 XP): Evaluate session-to-session narrative flow with minimal subsystems
2. **Tier III Play** (90-150 XP): Assess how character growth naturally expands storytelling scope
3. **Tier V Play** (220+ XP): Examine how simple rules handle complex, multi-threaded narratives

Mastery Curve Analysis

Key Metric: Mastery effort should decrease as narrative complexity increases

Success Indicators:

- Session 1: Clear, engaging storytelling with minimal reference
- Session 10: Comfortable integration of multiple subsystems
- Session 30: Mechanics become invisible; focus entirely on narrative

0.1.5 What to Look For

Narrative-First Design

- Every mechanical element should serve story consequences
- Player agency should manifest through narrative choices, not optimization
- GM authority should prioritize "what happens" over "what are the rules"

Constraint-Based Creativity

- Random elements should create coherent, not chaotic, storytelling
- Regional generators should maintain thematic consistency while enabling variety
- Mechanical constraints should inspire creativity, not limit options

Scalable Sophistication

- Same core mechanics should handle intimate scenes and epic narratives
- Character progression should expand narrative possibilities, not mechanical options
- World complexity should emerge from player actions, not pre-authored content

0.1.6 Red Flags vs. Design Features**Actual Red Flags**

- Mechanics that require constant reference during play
- Subsystems that don't integrate naturally with core philosophy
- Progression that adds mechanical burden rather than narrative freedom

Misinterpreted Design Features

- **High content volume** = Creative resource library, not mastery burden
- **Multiple magic paths** = Narrative vocabulary expansion, not mechanical complexity
- **Regional generators** = Inspiration engines, not reference requirements

0.1.7 Recommended Review Approach**Session 1-3 Evaluation**

Focus on:

- How quickly engaging stories emerge
- Clarity of core mechanical principles
- Integration of generated content into coherent narratives

Session 10+ Evaluation

Assess:

- How naturally complexity emerges from player choices
- Integration of multiple subsystems without mechanical overhead
- Evolution from "using rules" to "telling stories"

Long-term Assessment

Consider:

- Whether the system grows with narrative ambition
- If mastery effort genuinely decreases over time
- How world complexity emerges organically from play

0.1.8 The Core Truth

Fate's Edge succeeds not by being simple, but by being **designed for simplicity to emerge naturally from complex storytelling**. Evaluate it not as a comprehensive system to master, but as a storytelling partnership that grows in sophistication at exactly the same rate your table develops narrative ambition.

This isn't a game you learn - it's a storytelling evolution you grow into.

Chapter 1

Core Principles

1.1 Safety Tools

Fate's Edge explores mature themes—conflict, loss, horror, betrayal. The table should always feel safe. Use these tools to keep the game enjoyable for everyone.

Safety Tools: Lines

X-Card Any player (including the GM) can draw an “X” on a card or simply say “X” when a moment makes them uncomfortable. When the X-Card is shown, the described content is removed from the fiction—no questions, no explanations, no judgments. The scene is retconned or redirected immediately.

Lines A hard boundary: content that will not appear in the game at all. Examples: “No sexual violence,” “No harm to children,” “No body horror.” Establish during Session Zero.

Veils A soft boundary: content that can happen “off screen” or fade to black. Example: “A romantic scene can happen, but fade to black before it becomes explicit.”

Always keep an X-Card visible. When used, pause, rewind if needed, and move on. Do not interrogate the player. The GM may also use the X-Card for their own comfort.

1.2 The Central Question

At its heart, Fate's Edge asks:

What are you willing to risk, and what are you willing to pay, to reshape the world around you?

This question is both philosophical and mechanical. Players gamble with fate every time they act, and the consequences—good or ill—become the foundation of their legend.

1.3 Core Principles

The game is built on four key ideas:

Narrative First Mechanics serve the story. Rules reward descriptive play and creative problem-solving.

Risk Creates Drama Every roll carries tension. Even success may come at a cost.

Meaningful Growth Experience is a currency of choice. Invest in yourself or in your influence on the world.

Consequences Matter No action is free. Every choice changes the fiction.

1.4 Key Concepts

1.4.1 Narrative Time

Time in Fate’s Edge is measured by story weight, not by clocks. Use these four scales:

Table 1.1: Narrative Time Scales

Scale	Description
A Moment	A heartbeat, a glance, a single strike or word.
Some Time	A few minutes: a skirmish, a careful lockpick, a short negotiation.
Significant Time	Hours: travel, a ritual, a siege.
Days	Large-scale endeavors: marches, training, recovery.

1.4.2 Story Beats (SB)

Whenever a player rolls dice, each result of **1** generates one Story Beat (SB) for the GM. Re-rolling a 1 does *not* erase its SB; if the re-rolled die also shows 1, it generates additional SB.

SB are not penalties—they are narrative fuel. The GM spends SB to introduce twists:

- **Escalation** – drawing more enemies, raising the stakes.
- **Exhaustion** – draining time, resources, or positioning.
- **Exposure** – revealing hidden actions, alerting foes.
- **Collateral** – harm or danger spilling over onto allies, innocents, or surroundings.

For a full SB Spend Menu, see [2.1.8](#).

1.4.3 Affinity

Each people (culture or heritage) provides an **Affinity**: a narrative edge or metaphysical bond. Affinities make certain actions more reliable or grant unique permissions, weaving identity into mechanics. Examples include the Aeler stone-sense or the Aelaerem hearth-luck.

1.4.4 Prestige Abilities

High-level talents unlocked by mastering cultural arts, Patron bonds, or philosophical paths. These are narrative milestones as much as mechanical upgrades.

1.4.5 On-Screen vs. Off-Screen

Fate's Edge distinguishes between resources you see at the table and those that shape the world behind the scenes:

On-Screen Resources are companions, hirelings, or allies who stand beside you in danger. They add dice pools and flavor, but they can falter, be captured, or die.

Off-Screen Resources are assets, titles, networks, or safe houses. They never swing a blade in combat, but they shape the story between sessions, turning XP into narrative leverage.

1.5 Design Philosophy

1.5.1 Core Principles (Extended)

1. **Narrative Primacy:** Mechanics serve story, not replace it.
2. **Risk as Drama:** Every roll carries potential for triumph and complication.
3. **Meaningful Growth:** XP investment creates lasting character and world change.
4. **Consequence Weight:** Choices ripple outward; nothing is free.
5. **Fail Forward:** Misses fuel Boons; 1s become Story Beats that drive the fiction onward.

1.5.2 Mechanical Constraints

Table 1.2: Core Mechanical Limits

Rule	Limit
Assist Maximum	+3 dice total per roll from all helpers.
Boon Maximum	Hold 5 Boons; trim to 2 at scene end.
Boon-to-XP Conversion	2 Boons → 1 XP, once per session, max 2 XP per session via conversion.
Follower Initiative	1 Follower Action per scene, party-wide.
Over-Stack	2+ structural advantages = start a relevant clock +1 OR GM banks +1 SB.
Position States	Dominant Controlled Desperate (affects success/failure texture).
Dice Pool Cap	Maximum 10d10 per roll; extras become auto-successes.

1.5.3 The Golden Rule

When in doubt, make the choice that serves the story. If you find yourself asking “What’s the optimal move?” try reframing it as “What would be most interesting for the story?”

The dice do not determine success or failure—they help decide which path you take to get there.

1.5.4 Flavor is Free

Players may add descriptive details, cultural elements, and atmospheric touches without spending resources or requiring rolls. Flavor enriches the narrative without changing mechanical outcomes. The GM should encourage this and reciprocate.

Chapter 2

Core Mechanics

2.1 The Core Resolution Cycle

When a player rolls dice, they engage the world through risk, consequence, and discovery.

2.1.1 Step-by-Step Resolution

1. **Declare Action & Approach:** Intent + Attribute + Skill.
2. **Set Difficulty Value (DV):** GM sets DV (2–7+) based on stakes.
3. **Roll Dice Pool:** Attribute + Skill d10s (max 10 dice; extras = auto-successes).
4. **Count Results:**
 - 6–9 = 1 success
 - 10 = 2 successes
 - 1 = 1 Story Beat (SB) for GM
5. **Compare to DV** → Outcome Matrix (see [Table 2.1](#)).
6. **Spend SB:** GM introduces complications (see [section 2.1.8](#)).

2.1.2 Difficulty Value (DV)

Default DV Ladder

DV	Typical Case
2	Routine: clear intent, modest stakes, controlled environment
3	Pressured: time limits, mild resistance, partial information
4	Hard: hostile conditions, active opposition, precision required
5+	Extreme: stacked constraints, dangerous failure, high drama

Default DV = 3.

2.1.3 Position & Effect

Position (risk) Dominant (safe), Controlled (balanced), Desperate (high stakes).

Effect (reward) Limited, Standard, Great.

GM sets both based on fiction.

2.1.4 Outcome Matrix

Table 2.1: Outcome Matrix

Roll Result	What Happens
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB = 0	Clean Success – achieve intent without complication.
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB > 0	Success & Cost – achieve intent; GM spends SB for complication.
$0 < \text{Successes} < \text{DV}$	Partial – progress with complication; player gains 1 Boon.
Successes = 0	Miss – no progress; GM escalates with SB; player gains 2 Boons.

2.1.5 Critical Success (10s)

If roll succeeds, each 10 adds narrative weight. Effects apply only on success.

- **1 ten:** Strong success – improved Position or minor advantage.
- **2 tens:** Exceptional – choose two benefits (e.g., increased Effect + free Boon).
- **3 tens:** Legendary – decisive victory; clear 1 clock segment.
- **4+ tens:** Mythic – reshape scene; clear 1–2 clock segments.

Tens are never rerolled by Position effects.

2.1.6 Dice Pool Limit & Auto-Successes

Max dice = 10d10. Extra dice become auto-successes (no SB generated).

2.1.7 Boons

Earning Boons

- Partial ($0 < \text{successes} < \text{DV}$): 1 Boon
- Miss (successes = 0): 2 Boons (meaningful roll only)
- Bond-driven action (once per bond/session): 1 Boon
- GM award

Limit: Max 2 Boons from failures per character per scene.

Spending Boons (1 Boon)

- Reroll one die (after result)
- Activate an on-screen Asset
- Improve Position by one step before roll
- Power certain Rites/abilities
- Convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (once/session downtime, max 2 XP)

Carryover: Max 5 Boons; at scene end, reduce to 2.

2.1.8 Story Beats (SB)

Each die showing 1 = 1 SB for GM. Rerolling a 1 does not erase its SB; another 1 adds extra.

	Cost	Effect
SB Spend Menu	1 SB	Minor: noise, trace, tick clock +1, worsen Position
	2 SB	Moderate: alarm raised, lose cover/Position, lesser foe appears
	3 SB	Serious: reinforcements, key gear breaks, major twist, advance front clock
	4+ SB	Major: trap springs, authority arrives, scene shift, Patron intervenes

2.2 Player-Managed Modules

Players track their own: Obligation, Corruption, Leash, Asset States.

What Players Track		
Module	Owner	Tick Triggers (examples)
Obligation (per Patron)	Player	Invoke Rite, Push, Crack the Seal
Corruption Clock	Player	Cantor Push, Resonant Rite, GM SB on occult actions
Leash (Summoning)	Player	Spirit takes Harm, acts against nature, crosses [WARD]
Asset State (Symbol)	Player	Neglect, Crack the Seal → Compromised

Obligation Capacity = Spirit + Presence.

- Over capacity: +1 Fatigue per segment.
- Double capacity: Clear Fatigue, +1 Harm, Patron Intrusion.

Corruption Full Apply last Patron's boon burden, reset to 0.

Leash Full Spirit acts once to its nature then departs/turns hostile.

Symbol State Compromised – repair downtime (DV 3) or 1 XP.

2.3 Turn Economy

Each turn: **1 Action + 1 Move**.

2.3.1 Movement

- **Move:** Shift one band (Close ↔ Near ↔ Far) or stand from prone.
- **Dash (Action):** Move two bands; next defense Desperate.
- **Disengage (Action):** Then Move does not provoke opportunity attacks; cannot Attack this turn.

2.3.2 Action Options

- **Attack** (melee/ranged)
- **Disengage** (as above)
- **Charge (full turn):** Move two bands toward enemy + melee attack. Costs 1 Fatigue. Next defense Desperate. Requires open ground.
- **Skirmish (full turn):** Move two bands away + ranged attack. Costs 1 Fatigue. Next defense Desperate. Requires open ground.
- **Observe / Change Position:** +1 Position once per turn.
- **Setup:** Grant ally +1 Position or step up Effect.
- **Assist:** Spend 1 Boon for +1 die (max +3 from all assists).
- **Defend, Channel/Weave, Cast Rite/Song, Interact, etc.**

Talents (Effortless Charge, Relentless, etc.) modify these.

2.3.3 Initiative

No fixed order. GM spotlights based on fiction; ambushers act first.

2.3.4 Opportunity Attacks

Leaving an enemy's Close without Disengage provokes one free melee attack (Controlled Position, no action cost).

2.4 Fatigue & Harm

2.4.1 Fatigue Track

Size = Body. Mark from exertion, magic, stress.

Effects

- Each Fatigue worsens Position: Dominant → Controlled → Desperate.
- If already Desperate, each Fatigue → -1 die.
- **Overflow:** When track fills, increase Harm by 1 level, clear all Fatigue.

Recovery: Short rest removes 2 Fatigue; full night removes all. Requires adequate Supply.

2.4.2 Harm Levels

Harm	Effect	
Harm 1	-1 die on related actions	Recovery: medical or magical care.
Harm 2	-1 die on most actions until treated	
Harm 3	Incapacitated or dying	

2.4.3 Taking Harm & Fatigue – The Procedure

When hit:

1. **Convert** Harm to Fatigue using armor (see [subsection 2.4.4](#)). Minimum 1 Fatigue per hit.
2. **Apply remaining Harm:** If any, increase Harm level and clear all existing Fatigue.
3. **Add Fatigue** from step 1. If track fills, resolve overflow (Harm +1, clear Fatigue).

2.4.4 Armor Conversion Table

Armor Type	Conversion (Harm → Fatigue)	Minimum Fatigue	
Light	1 → 1	1	<i>Example: Light</i>
Medium	2 → 1	1	
Heavy	3 → 2	1	

armor hit with Harm 2 → convert 1→1 Fatigue, remaining Harm 1 → increase Harm 1, clear Fatigue, then add 1 Fatigue. Result: Harm 1, Fatigue 1.

2.4.5 Fear Effects

When Fear Track escalates (Shaken → Frightened → Panicked), roll d10 or choose:

d10	Effect
1	Freeze (cannot act)
2	Flee
3	Drop held item
4	Beg/bargain
5	Hide
6	Panic attack (nearest target)
7	Blunder into danger
8	Obeys simple command
9	Break down (useless until aided)
10	Catatonia

2.5 Skills

Action roll = Attribute (Body, Wits, Spirit, Presence) + Skill. GM sets Position and DV.

2.5.1 Core Skills (Abridged)

Skill	What It Covers
Arcana	Magic theory, wards, rituals
Athletics	Running, climbing, swimming, balance
Brawl	Unarmed combat, grappling
Command	Leadership, morale
Craft	Making, mending
Deception	Lying, bluffing
Insight	Reading emotions, detecting lies
Investigation	Research, deduction
Lore	History, cultures, general knowledge
Medicine	Healing, first aid
Melee	Close combat with weapons
Notice	Perception, spotting ambushes
Performance	Acting, music, oration
Ranged	Bows, thrown weapons
Stealth	Moving unseen
Subterfuge	Casing, forgery, sleight of hand
Survival	Wilderness navigation, foraging
Sway	Persuasion, charm
Tinker	Lockpicking, traps, devices

2.5.2 Attribute + Skill Combos

Same action can use different pairs. Example: Persuading a guard: Presence+Sway (charm), Wits+Sway (logic), Spirit+Sway (conviction).

2.6 Experience Points (XP)

2.6.1 Awarding XP (per session)

- Attendance: +2
- Major objective: +2–4
- Discoveries: +1–2
- Hard choices: +1–2
- Complication spotlight: +1–3
- Bond/flag driven: +1–2
- GM curveball: +0–3

End of major arc: +8–12 XP to all.

2.6.2 Spending XP

- **Attribute:** new rating $\times 3$ XP, downtime = new rating days.
- **Skill:** new level $\times 2$ XP, downtime = new level days.
- **Talents:** 2–12+ XP per tier.
- **Follower:** Cap^2 XP, downtime 1–3 days.
- **Asset:** Minor (4 XP, 1d), Standard (8 XP, 1w), Major (12 XP, 1 month).

Rush Rule: Skip downtime $\rightarrow$ start Haste [4] clock. On fill, ability gains flaw/hitch.

2.6.3 Reputation Tiers

Novice (0–40 XP) Local, prestige locked.

Seasoned (41–90 XP) Regional, some prestige unlock.

Veteran (91–150 XP) National, second follower slot.

Paragon (151–220 XP) Continental, rivals emerge.

Mythic (221+ XP) Legendary, kingdoms react.

2.7 Game Structure

2.7.1 Narrative Time

A Moment (heartbeat), **Some Time** (minutes), **Significant Time** (hours), **Days**.

2.7.2 Game Units

Scene (conflict/question), **Session** (3–6 hrs, 2–4 scenes), **Campaign** (6–20+ sessions).

2.8 Assets & Followers (Quick Reference)

2.8.1 Assets (Off-Screen)

Costs: Minor (4 XP, 1d), Standard (8 XP, 1w), Major (12 XP, 1m).

- **Free off-screen use:** once/session.
- **Boon activation:** 1 Boon for on-screen scene.
- **Conditions:** Maintained → Neglected → Compromised.

2.8.2 Followers (On-Screen)

Cost: Cap² XP, downtime 1–3d.

- **Assistance:** +min(Cap, relevant skill) dice, capped at +3 total.
- **Independent action:** once/scene (party-wide). Cost: 1 Exposure or 1 Harm.
- **Conditions:** Exposure, Harm tracks.

2.8.3 Upkeep (per downtime)

- **Efficient:** XP = max(1, acquisition/3).
- **Intensive:** 1 XP + dedicated downtime action.

Failure to pay: follower → Wary → Seized; asset → Neglected → Compromised.

Chapter 3

Deck-Based Generators

3.1 Introduction to Deck Generators

Deck generators in **Fate's Edge** transform random card draws into coherent narrative elements. Each deck has a distinct purpose and suit meanings so that randomness serves the story rather than derailing it. These generators provide structured inspiration for GMs while maintaining the game's narrative-first philosophy.

3.2 Standard Deck Structure

Fate's Edge uses several card-based tools, each with specialised suit meanings:

Travel Decks (regional, 52-card) Used for journey content and location-based adventures.

- **Spade** = Place / Location
- **Heart** = Actor / Faction
- **Club** = Pressure / Complication
- **Diamond** = Reward / Opportunity

Deck of Consequences (scene drama) Used for immediate complications and narrative twists during gameplay.

- **Hearts** = Social / Emotional Fallout
- **Spades** = Harm / Escalation
- **Clubs** = Material Cost / Resource Drain
- **Diamonds** = Magical / Spiritual Disturbance

Important

Never mix suit meanings across decks. When rules reference *Spade / Club / Diamond*, they mean the **Travel Deck**. When they say *Hearts / Spades / Clubs / Diamonds*, they mean the **Deck of Consequences**.

3.3 Rank Severity and Clock Size

Card rank sets the size / significance of the primary Clock:

- **2–5 (Minor)**: 4-segment Clock
- **6–10 (Standard)**: 6-segment Clock
- **J, Q, K (Major)**: 8-segment Clock
- **Ace (Pivotal)**: 10-segment Clock

Colour Influence:

- **Black suits** (♠, ♣): Travel hazards, tangible threats, fatigue.
- **Red suits** (♥, ♦): Social intrigue, reputational pressure, emotional complications.

3.4 Draw Procedures

3.4.1 Quick Hook (2 cards)

Ideal for spontaneous scene generation or when players zag unexpectedly:

1. Draw one **Spade** (place) and one **Heart** (actor / faction).
2. Use the higher rank to set Clock size.
3. Combine elements into a simple, compelling scenario.

3.4.2 Full Seed (4 cards)

For full adventures or significant arcs:

1. Draw until one card of each suit appears:
 - **Spade** = Primary location
 - **Heart** = Main actor / faction
 - **Club** = Central complication
 - **Diamond** = Key reward / opportunity
2. The highest rank sets the main Clock size.
3. If multiple face cards or Aces appear, create parallel Clocks for secondary threats or opportunities.

3.4.3 Act Builder

Structure sessions or multi-part adventures:

1. Draw three cards: setting (**Spade**), actor (**Heart**), complication (**Club**).
2. Treat **Diamond** cards drawn during play as foreshadowed opportunities or act payoffs.
3. Highest rank determines the session's primary challenge scope.

3.5 Using the Deck in Play

1. Players roll; each die showing **1** generates **1 Story Beat (SB)**.
2. The GM chooses one method for that roll:
 - (a) **Direct Spend:** Translate SB into immediate consequences or clock ticks.
 - (b) **Deck Draw:** Draw up to **min(SB, 3)** cards and synthesise a single twist guided by suit and highest rank.
3. Interpret the cards to create a coherent complication that advances the narrative.

3.6 Combo Rules

Special combinations add texture:

Pair (same rank) Recurring motif with a twist.

Run (3+ sequential ranks) Momentum – reduce the main Clock by 1 segment.

Flush (3+ same suit) Strongly theme the act toward that suit’s axis.

Face + Ace Reveal a hidden patron or power behind the element.

All one colour GM gains **+1 SB** to use in that scene.

3.7 Regional Generator Summary

Table 3.1: Regional Generator Summary

Region	Theme	Special Mechanics
Acasia	Broken Marches	Curse motifs; every Ace adds a lingering omen.
Aelaerem	Hearth & Hollow	Red-thread motifs; Ace echoes quiet bells / watch-geese.
Aeler	Crowns & Under-Vaults	Stone / breath motifs; Ace: keys click, bells answer.
Aelinnel	Stone, Bough, Bright Things	Moonlight motifs; Ace adds a shortcut where none should be.
Black Banners	Condotta & Crowns	War & winter motifs; Ace: weapons remember, ice holds the dead.
Ecktoria	Marble & Fire	Imperial forms; Ace carves precedent in marble.
Kahfagia	Pilot’s Mirror	Lantern-law jurisdiction shifts; Ace redefines lanes.

Table 3.1 – continued

Region	Theme	Special Mechanics
Linn	Skerries & Storm-Oaths	Sea omens; Ace: horns on wind, white horses on swell.
Mistlands	Bells, Salt, Breath	Breath / boundary motifs; Ace: bells answer across water.
Silkstrand	City of Bridges & Dyewater	Dye / bridge motifs; Ace adds a lingering omen.
Theona	Three Greens, No Ninth	“No Ninth” custom; Ace adds a telling omission.
Thepyrgos	City of a Thousand Stairs	Height / sound motifs; Ace echoes bells / wind / stair-steps.
Ubral	Stone Between Spears	Upland motifs; Ace echoes horns / heather / stone.
Valewood	Empire Under Leaves	Empire echoes (J/Q/K add relic-logic); Ace rearranges approach.
Vhasia	Fractured Sun	Broken-sun motifs; Ace blots medal / scratches milestone.
Vilikari	Laurels & Longhouses	Two-laws motifs; Ace shows wolf / eagle side-by-side.
Viterra	Last Kingdom	Legacy, parishes, and final-stand themes.
Wilds	Roads, Ruins, Weather	Reskin palette for any biome.
Zakov	Salt & Serpent	Salt & serpent omens; Ace: tides remember, reefs shift, deep listens.

3.8 NPC Generation Deck

Every NPC should feel like a person with desires, convictions, and contradictions. This deck lets you assemble a complete profile quickly by drawing one element from each category.

3.8.1 Generation Categories

Ambition What they seek to achieve or obtain.

Belief The principle or philosophy guiding their worldview.

Attitude How they present themselves and interact day-to-day.

Twist A contradiction or hidden facet that creates tension.

3.8.2 Using the NPC Generator

Select or draw one from each column and consider the frictions between public ambition, private belief, surface attitude, and the twist.

Table 3.2: NPC Generation Categories

Ambition	Belief	Attitude	Twist
Power	Might makes right	Arrogant	Secretly insecure
Wealth	Ends justify means	Charismatic	Betraying their allies
Revenge	Honour above all	Cold	Working for their enemy
Love	Truth is sacred	Friendly	Hiding a dark past
Knowledge	Loyalty is paramount	Paranoid	Actually an impostor
Survival	Family above all	Cruel	Deeply compassionate
Fame	Justice must prevail	Pious	Corrupted by power
Freedom	Fate can be changed	Optimistic	Hopelessly cynical
Protection	Tradition must be upheld	Pessimistic	Revolutionary at heart
Control	Change is necessary	Calculating	Acts on impulse
Recognition	The system works	Naive	Cynical manipulator

3.9 Practical Deck Usage Examples

3.9.1 Example 1: Quick Scene Generation

The party detours through the Mistlands. The GM draws:

- **Spade (8)**: Ancient standing stones covered in moss.
- **Heart (Queen)**: A territorial spirit guardian.

A 6-segment Clock *Spirit's Wrath* begins: the guardian demands tribute for safe passage.

3.9.2 Example 2: Consequences During Play

Kael misses a stealth roll and generates **2 SB**. The GM draws:

- **Hearts (7)**: Social complication.
- **Clubs (3)**: Resource cost.

Synthesis: *A ceremonial urn shatters; cultists recognise your patron's mark. Future dealings will demand extra tribute and materials.*

3.9.3 Example 3: NPC Creation

Merchant in Valewood:

- **Ambition:** Wealth
- **Belief:** Family above all
- **Attitude:** Charismatic
- **Twist:** Secretly compassionate

Result: *A charming hard-bargainer who supports a large family and quietly donates to orphanages – even aiding struggling competitors.*

3.10 GM Guidance for Deck Usage

3.10.1 When to Use Which Deck

- **Travel Decks:** journey planning, location adventures, regional exploration.
- **Deck of Consequences:** immediate twists during active scenes.
- **NPC Generator:** fast creation with built-in tension and hooks.

3.10.2 Interpreting Card Draws

- Prioritise narrative coherence over literalism.
- Use suits as inspiration, not constraints.
- Combine cards into layered complications rather than parallel noise.
- Remember: players can mitigate, pivot, or overcome deck outcomes.

3.10.3 Balancing Randomness and Narrative

- Draw when you want surprise or need a nudge.
- Ignore or modify draws that don't serve the current story.
- Treat combinations as creative prompts, not mandates.
- The goal is to *enhance* the narrative, not derail it.

Chapter 4

Travel Reference

4.1 Introduction to Travel

Travel in **Fate’s Edge** is not just movement between locations—it is an opportunity for adventure, discovery, and complication. The travel system uses deck-based generators to create meaningful journeys that advance the story while presenting challenges and opportunities.

4.2 Core Travel Procedure

For each leg of a journey, follow this structured approach.

4.2.1 Card Draw Sequence

Draw 3–4 cards using the appropriate regional decks:

Spade from the destination deck Sets the scene (place and environment).

Heart from the destination deck Introduces the local actor or faction.

Club from the Wilds (general hazards) or destination (if strongly policed) Brings pressure and complications.

Diamond from the authority that controls the route Represents papers, escorts, rights, or exceptions needed.

4.2.2 Travel Clock Setup

Set a travel clock based on the highest card rank drawn:

Table 4.1: Travel Clock Sizes

Rank	Clock Size	Typical Journey
2–5	4 segments	Short, straightforward journey.
6–10	6 segments	Standard journey.
J, Q, K	8 segments	Extended or complex journey.

Ace 10 segments Epic or highly dangerous journey.

4.2.3 Resolution and Consequences

- On success: advance to the next leg of the journey.
- On failure: mark delay, debt, or diversion and resolve consequences in the fiction.
- Each segment filled typically represents significant progress or a meaningful encounter.

4.3 Travel Modes and Special Rules

4.3.1 Sea Travel

Sea journeys (Amaranthine / Dolmis / Aberderrin routes) follow special considerations:

- If Theona or Valewood 9s appear in the seed, add an omission or taboo to the leg.
- Navigational challenges use *Sailing* or *Survival* skills with modified DVs.
- Weather and sea conditions act as persistent complications.

4.3.2 Underground Passes (Aeler)

Aeler's underground routes have unique mechanics:

- Any Ace can convert a surface route to an under-route.
- Diamond cards from Aeler always codify outcomes—no roll required—for sealed doors, breath time, and escorted segments.
- Underground travel uses different skill sets (*Engineering*, *Geology*, *Survival*).

4.3.3 River Travel

River journeys present distinct challenges:

- **Ecktoria / Viterra rivers:** bridges, booms, and legal checkpoints.
- **Mistlands / Linn waters:** reed-mazes and bell-line navigation systems.
- Current strength and river conditions affect travel pace and difficulty.

4.3.4 Frontier and Border Crossings

When traveling between regions with different laws or authorities:

- Draw two Diamond cards (one from each controlling authority).
- Choose which authority's laws you will be judged by at the journey's end.
- Border crossings typically add +2 segments to the travel clock.

4.4 Major Regional Routes

4.4.1 Amaranthine Coastway

Route: Kahfagia → Ecktoria → Acasia → Marcott (Vhasia) → Fairport (Viterra).

- Draw Spade+Heart from the port you are entering.
- Draw Club from the Wilds deck (gales, quarantine, harbor booms).
- Draw Diamond from the port's deck (permits, berths), or Kahfagia if convoy / lantern law applies.
- **Note:** Silkstrand is Acasia's sole metropolis and a major trading hub.

4.4.2 Astroegro Straits

Thepyrgos controls this crucial maritime hinge.

- Draw Spade+Heart and Club from Thepyrgos deck (stairs, boom, synod).
- Draw Diamond from Thepyrgos (harbor pass, crane allotment).
- Switch to Dolmis / Amaranthine modules once the boom is lowered.

4.4.3 Dolmis Sea Circuits

Route: Fairport (Viterra) → Theona (Three Greens) → Ubral fjords → Aelinnel west shore.

- Spade+Heart from destination deck.
- Club from Linn or Wilds decks.
- Diamond from Theona when island custom matters.
- Island-hopping presents unique navigation challenges.

4.4.4 Aelerian Underground Passes

Route: Vhasia / Viterra / Ubral south slopes → Aeler gates → Mistlands.

- Spade+Heart and Club from Aeler deck.
- Diamond from Aeler (Underway Pass, Key-Writ, Breath Time).
- Underground routes bypass surface dangers but present their own risks.

4.4.5 Shadow Corridors (Valewood)

Thin Shore route along Valewood's east coast toward Zakov.

- Spade from Valewood deck.
- Heart from Mistlands or Valewood deck.
- Club from Mistlands deck (wraiths, bell-line failures).
- Diamond from either Mistlands (Ward-salt, Lantern Writ) or Valewood (Way-cord, Truce-bough).

Rule of 9s

Any **9** in the seed adds an omission or taboo: a missing step, an unsaid name, an unseen guest.

4.4.6 Green Gate Tidal Routes (Aelinnel)

Aelinnel's tide-dependent passages:

- Spade+Club from Aelinnel deck (tides, geasa).
- Diamond from Aelinnel (Tide-path Key, Host-rights).
- Timing is critical—miss the tide and wait for the next cycle.

4.4.7 Major River Systems

Belworth River Boundary between Vhasia and Viterra.

- Twin ports at the mouth (Marcott and Fairport).
- Tarlington Falls requires lift / portage to plateau towns.
- Use Viterra for east-bank audits, Vhasia for west-bank politics.

Yloka River Northern raid routes into Aberderrin and Dolmis.

- Overlay Linn Clubs for hazards.
- Draw destination for Spade+Heart.

Acasian Rivers Hazardous approaches to Silkstrand.

- Use Acasia Clubs (feuds / levies / curse).
- Diamonds represent condotta permits, bridge rights.

4.4.8 Steppe Frontier Routes

Ykrul ↔ Vilikari ↔ Ecktoria / Acasia borders:

- Spade from the road (Wolf Road or Foedus Stone).
- Heart from the counterpart region (envoys, comitatus).
- Club from Wilds or frontier decks (rasputitsa, hostage protocol).
- Diamond from either Ykrul (paiza, remounts) or Vilikari (foedus seal).

4.5 Strategic Gateways and Control Points

Table 4.2: Major Travel Gateways and Control Points

Gateway		Controlling Deck	Diamond Source	Typical	Require-
				ments	ments
Kassamira (Kahfagia)		Kahfagia	Kahfagia	Convoy lantern-law pilotage token	letter; warrant;
Ecktoria Capital Port	Ecktoria	Ecktoria	Ecktoria	Berth coin-house procession permit	priority; credit;
Silkstrand		Acasia	Acasia	Exchange floor condotta permit; wa-	access;
Marcott		Vhasia	Vhasia	Letters safe-conduct; fair-	patent; ground precedence
Fairport		Viterra	Viterra	Customs seal; ferry priority; Dawn escort	
Tarlington Falls		Viterra	Viterra	Lift bridge/portage County ruling	priority; pass;
Thepyrgos Boom		Thepyrgos	Thepyrgos	Harbor pass; crane al-	lotment; Synod indul-
High-Mist Pass		Aeler	Aeler	Underway Key-Writ; breath-time allotment	pass;
Payden's Port		Mistlands	Mistlands	Lantern ward-salt; indemnity	writ; wraith
Thin Shore		Valewood	Valewood / Mist-	Way-cord; dew-mirror; lantern writ	
Green Gate		Aelinnel	Aelinnel	Tide-path host-right salt license	key; bough;
Ubral Passes		Ubral	Aeler / Ubral	Vurim hill-fort shelter guide's braid	pass-ring; writ;
Thing-holm		Linn	Linn	Thing harbor-green; writ	ruling; escort
Foedus Stone		Vilikari	Vilikari / Ykrul	Foedus re-mount hostage treaty	renewal; re- allotment;

Table 4.2 – continued

Gateway	Controlling Deck	Diamond Source	Typical ments	Require-
Zakov Roadstead	Theona / Linn	Theona / Linn	Raid-truce whale-road market immunity	ribbon; escort;

4.6 Special Travel Rules and Regional Features

4.6.1 Theona and Valewood Taboos

Whenever a 9 appears in a travel seed involving Theona or Valewood:

- Add an omission: missing step, unsaid name, unseen guest.
- If the 9 is a Diamond, you may break the taboo once—but someone will come to collect.
- These taboos create ongoing narrative hooks and complications.

4.6.2 Aeler Ace Route Manipulation

Aeler’s underground network allows special route manipulation:

- An Ace can rewrite routes beneath the mountains.
- You may swap your Spade to Aeler (keeping other seed cards) and continue under-vault procedures.
- This represents discovering or activating hidden passages.

4.6.3 Echoing Omens and Motifs

Any Ace drawn during travel adds a recurring motif:

- Examples: ash on the wind, a bell heard underground, a landmark that reappears.
- These motifs can be referenced later for narrative advantage or complication.
- Makes the world feel interconnected and memorable.

4.7 Worked Travel Examples

4.7.1 West-to-East Coastal Journey

Leg 1: Kassamira → Ecktoria

- Seed: Ecktoria Spade (Aqueduct arcades), Ecktoria Heart (Coin-house factor), Wilds Club (gale), Kahfagia Diamond (convoy letter).
- Clock: 6 segments.

- *Narrative:* Cross under coin-house eyes with convoy priority; bad weather strains schedules.

Leg 2: Ecktoria → Silkstrand

- Seed: Acasia Spade (Three-Queens Bridge), Acasia Heart (Dyers' Guildmistress), Acasia Club (loom strike), Acasia Diamond (Exchange pass).
- Clock: 6–8 segments depending on unrest severity.

Leg 3: Silkstrand → Marcott

- Seed: Vhasia Spade (Pont-du-Tithe), Vhasia Heart (Parlement clerk), Vhasia Club (coin rumor), Vhasia Diamond (letters patent).

Leg 4: Marcott → Fairport

- Seed: Viterra Spade (Fairport tideworks), Viterra Heart (shipwright), Linn Club (boom lifts), Viterra Diamond (customs seal).
- Clock: 6 segments.

4.7.2 Mountain Pass Expedition**Leg 1: Silkstrand → Aeler Gate**

- Seed: Aeler Spade (Avalanche gallery), Aeler Heart (Geometer), Aeler Club (Engineer requisition), Aeler Diamond (Underway Pass).
- Underground route bypasses surface dangers.

Leg 2: Aeler Gate → Mistlands

- Seed: Mistlands Spade (Bell-Line levee), Mistlands Heart (Bell-warden), Mistlands Club (wraith crossing), Mistlands Diamond (Ward-salt).
- Mistlands present unique navigation challenges.

4.7.3 Shadow Route Travel**Leg 1: Payden's Port → Thin Shore**

- Seed: Valewood Spade (Green lane), Mistlands Heart (Protectorate clerk), Mistlands Club (bell failure), Mistlands Diamond (Lantern writ).
- Rule of 9s applies for additional complications.

Leg 2: Thin Shore Transit

- Seed: Valewood Spade (Unfound stile), Valewood Heart (Path-warden), Valewood Club (Sweet wind), Valewood Diamond (Way-cord).
- Shadow corridors require special navigation skills.

4.7.4 Frontier Diplomacy Journey

Leg: Foedus Stone Parley

- Seed: Vilikari Spade (Foedus Stone), Ykrul Heart (Noyan envoy), Wilds Club (rasputitsa), Vilikari Diamond (Foedus Renewal).
- Additional draw: Ykrul Diamond (Paiza) for border crossing rights.
- Choose which authority's laws govern your passage.

4.8 Travel Pace and Consequence Guidelines

4.8.1 Standard Travel Times

Table 4.3: Standard Travel Times

Terrain Type	Clock Size and Modifiers
Road / River leg	6-segment clock standard; +2 segments if crossing law boundaries.
Sea strait / Mountain pass	8-segment clock; -2 segments with priority documents.
Shadow corridor	6-segment clock; Ace adds free omen for future use.
Urban travel	4-segment clock; complications are more social than environmental.

4.8.2 Failure Consequences

Standard failure outcomes include:

Delay Lose time; enemies advance their plans.

Diversion Forced alternate route; draw new Club card for additional complications.

Debt Promise, fine, or favour owed to the controlling authority.

Discovery Unexpected find that creates new opportunities or dangers.

4.8.3 Success Benefits

Successful travel can provide:

- Information about upcoming regions or threats.
- New contacts or faction relationships.
- Resource acquisition or trade opportunities.
- Narrative advantages for future scenes.

4.9 Locations Lore and Generators

4.10 Acasia — “Broken Marches”

Margravine of the Broken March (Elite): “The tithe must be paid, not merely offered. A promise written in ash and sealed with iron will is worth more than a thousand gold coins scattered on the wind.”

Hedge-Witch (Commoner): “Don’t cross the Pale Causeway at dusk, especially not if you’ve got a silver tooth. The bridge’ll remember it, and next time you pass, it’ll want more than just your footfall. In Acasia, every road owes a debt. The question is who pays.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Acasia is a former province of the Utaran Empire that rots in the space between famine and ambition. Every hill wears a crown, every bridge bears a toll, and every road curves back to the same cursed crossroads. Where once the Empire’s coin and grain flowed, now tithe-collectors gnaw the marrow of starving villages, and warlords dress themselves as kings. The land itself has grown bitter: grain blights spread like gossip, wine turns to vinegar in the cask, and the old Imperial roads have forgotten where they lead. The Curse—the nameless thing that makes crossroads loop back on themselves—is not a myth. It is the price of broken promises, and Acasia is drowning in them.

What you notice first: The smell of mildew on old parchment and wet ash. The way every milestone has been recarved. The silence of a village that heard you coming and chose not to open its gates.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never sign a contract on a bridge. The river is a witness, and it never forgets a signature.

Regional Mood: Famine and Ambition

Here, the past is not a memory—it is a predator. The Utaran Empire left behind roads that lead to nowhere, laws that contradict each other, and a hunger that no harvest can fill. Acasia’s petty kings hold court in burned keeps, their crowns forged from iron nails pulled from famine coffins. The Margravine keeps a ledger of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days. Free Companies trade loyalty like grain, swapping colors mid-march. And beneath it all, the Curse waits. It is not a monster. It is a geometry: the wrong turn, the bridge that leads back to the same shore, the bell that tolls for no funeral. In Acasia, the land itself has become a contract, and the fine print is written in mildew.

Starting Location: The Pale Causeway’s last inn, walls soot-blackened by coal and a century of gossip. A bounty poster flutters beside a half-empty hearth. The innkeeper is a one-eyed woman who pours small beer without asking. A stranger at the bar offers a sealed contract: retrieve a dowry chest from a Blackwood matriarch before the Margravine’s feast day. “The chest contains a claim, not coin,” the stranger whispers. “But a claim in Acasia is worth more than gold—it is a key to a bridge that does not loop.”

(Pass/Ruin/Toll-Town) Broken milestone on the old Imperial Road; borders “moved” overnight. Vine-terrace hillside with an abandoned press; strangler ivy owns it now.

Spades — Places

2. **Broken Milestone** — On the old Imperial Road; borders “moved” overnight. *The stone has been chiseled seven times. The last mark is still wet.*
 3. **Vine-Terrace Hillside** — Abandoned press; strangler ivy owns it now. *The ivy has grown around a skeleton. The skeleton still holds a wine cup.*
 4. **Toll-Bridge Town** — Over a cold river; two tolls, no receipts. *The second toll is collected by a child. The child does not speak.*
 5. **Wolfstairs Pass** — Switchbacks beneath a stonefall cliff. *The stones were placed by a landslide that knew your name.*
 6. **Sootfall Abbey Ruins** — Bell tower intact; crypts breathing. *The breathing is a prayer. The monks are still down there.*
 7. **Hill-Motte** — Fresh palisade; ditch scattered with caltrops. *The caltrops are from a siege that ended last week. The bodies are still rotting.*
 8. **Border-Stone Ring** — Carved with seven crowns; each points wrong. *The crowns belong to kings who never existed. The stones remember them anyway.*
 9. **Blackwood Charcoalers’ Hollow** — Witch-posts at every path. *The witch-posts were made from the gibbets of tax collectors. The tax collectors still swing.*
 10. **Salt-Road Ford** — Rains expose old bones in the chalk banks. *The bones are from three wars. They are not all human.*
- J **Iron Mine Adits** — Held by a miners’ commune; the air is full of whispers. *The whispers are the mine’s memory. It remembers every collapse.*
- Q **Margravine’s Hunting Lodge** — Tapestries of victories that never were. *The tapestries were woven by a blind weaver. The threads are from her own hair.*
- K **War-Camp City** — Tents around a burned keep; every banner claims the throne. *The keep was burned by its own lord. He did not want to share the heat.*
- A **The Pale Causeway** — The last high road that survives the spring thaws. *The causeway is made of bones. The bones are from the workers who built it.*

(Petty Crowns/Priests/Companies) Tithe-collector’s runner with a tally-rod and an empty stomach; roadside prior with three lay brothers guarding a relic.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Tithe-Collector’s Runner** — Tally-rod, empty stomach, and a list of names. *His tally-rod has notches from a dozen villages. The villages are now empty.*
 3. **Roadside Prior** — Three lay brothers guarding a relic. *The relic is a finger bone. The prior claims it belonged to a saint who starved to death.*
 4. **Hedge-Witch** — Knows which bridges eat travelers. *Her price is a story. The story must have a bad ending.*
 5. **Free Company Captain** — Pike and shot between contracts. *He has served three kings this year. He does not remember their names.*
 6. **River Reeve** — Rents every boat twice. *His ledger is a single page. The page is folded into a boat.*
 7. **Salt-Baron** — Hired blades; owns the ford and your timetable. *His salt is grey. It was cut with ashes from a burned village.*
 8. **Blackwood Matriarch** — Tends the feud like a garden. *Her garden grows tombstones. She waters them with tears—her enemies’.*
 9. **Ex-Imperial Surveyor** — Has the last accurate map. *The map shows villages that no longer exist. The surveyor visits them anyway.*
 10. **“King” of Three Villages** — Iron-nail crown, iron-will taxes. *His crown was a plowshare. He reversed the curse.*
- J **Bride with No Dowry but a Claim** — Daggers in the wedding chest. *The claim is to a bridge that drowned. The bride intends to collect.*
- Q **Margravine of the Broken March** — Half saint, half tax roll. *She has never lost a feud. Her ledger is her sword.*
- K **The Lame King** — Traveling throne; makes law by pointing. *His throne is a sedan chair carried by debtors. They owe him everything.*
- A **The Cursed Child of Silkstrand** — A rumor more than a person; her laughter ends sieges. *She is said to be twelve years old. She has been twelve for a century.*

(Feud/Levy/Weather/Curse) Peat-fog; all horns sound like someone calling your name. Sudden levy—every traveler pressed for a day’s service. Bridge feud; rival banners drop the chain on your cart.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Peat-Fog** — All horns sound like someone calling your name. *The name is not yours. Answer it, and the fog will take you.*
3. **Sudden Levy** — Every traveler is pressed for a day’s service. *The levy master has a list. Your name is on it—in fresh ink.*

4. **Bridge Feud** — Rival banners drop the chain on your cart. *The chain was forged from a broken oath. It rattles when liars approach.*
5. **Grain Blight** — Doubles the tithe; refusal means torches at night. *The blight has a face. It is the face of a tax collector who died hungry.*
6. **Scree Slide** — Seals the pass; the “safe” detour is owned by your enemy. *The enemy raised the toll yesterday. He was expecting you.*
7. **Wedding Turns Ambush** — You are caught between two bloodlines. *The bride’s veil is a shroud. The groom’s ring is a knife.*
8. **Witch’s Tithe Night** — Lights move in the woods; owe nothing or else. *The lights have voices. They are arguing over who should collect.*
9. **Pox Sign** — On a village gate; your escorts desert you. *The pox is a rumor. The desertion is real.*
10. **Condotta Breaks** — The Free Company flips colors mid-march. *The new colors are the same as the old colors. The captain just wanted to raise morale.*
- J **Heretic Preacher** — Sparks a march; toll-gates come down in splinters. *The preacher’s text is a tax receipt. He reads it like scripture.*
- Q **Imperial Pretender** — Arrives; every petty lord changes tabards. *The pretender’s seal is a sunburst. The sunburst is slightly crooked.*
- K **River Overruns the Levee** — The pontoon goes; your rivals don’t. *The river’s name is “Debt.” It remembers every unpaid crossing.*
- A **The Curse Stirrs** — No matter the road, you return to the same crossroads. *The crossroads has a signpost. The arms are labeled “Regret,” “Hunger,” “The Same.”*

(Papers/Claims/Safe-Conduct) Toll-exemption plaque for one bridge (once); monastery letter for bed and bread on a named road.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Toll-Exemption Plaque** — For one bridge (once). *The plaque is a bronze leaf. Hold it up, and the toll-keeper will spit—but step aside.*
3. **Monastery Letter** — For bed and bread on a named road. *The letter is sealed with a wax tear. The monks will honor it—or they will not.*
4. **Wine-Right** — On an abandoned terrace; locals will work for shares. *The wine is from a vine that grows over a mass grave. It tastes of iron.*
5. **Condotta Contract** — A signed pike contract (one battle on your terms). *The contract is written in blood. The blood is from the captain’s own finger.*
6. **Tithe-Remission Writ** — For a village; they owe you a season’s labor. *The writ is stamped with a bell. The bell’s clapper is a finger bone.*

7. **Border-Stone Adjustment** — Move a line two fields over. *The adjustment is a lie. The truth is that the line was always there.*
 8. **Pass-Key Charm** — Recognized by Pale Causeway watchmen. *The charm is a knotted cord. Untie it to pass—or to stay.*
 9. **Sealed Dowry Chest** — Of claims, not coin; certain doors open. *The chest is locked with a riddle. The answer is a name you do not know.*
 10. **Mine-Share** — In the commune; they fight like they mean it. *The share is a pickaxe. The commune will lend you a miner—or a grave.*
- J **Blood-Peace Charter** — Suspend a feud long enough to move your wagons. *The charter is a white ribbon. Blood will not be spilled while it flies—but blood will remember.*
- Q **Marriage Proxy** — From the Margravine; bind a hill-king to your cause. *The proxy is a wedding veil. The veil was worn by a ghost.*
- K **The Lame King’s Traveling Writ** — Troops must make way (for now). *The writ is a broken scepter. The Lame King’s seal is a footprint.*
- A **Curse-Redemption Rite (Temporary)** — For one night, no crossroads can hold you. *The rite is a whisper. The whisper is a name you have never spoken.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/claims/safe-conducts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo plague and curse motifs—crossroads that turn back on themselves, bells tolling for no funeral, banners blackened by mildew.

Additional Features

- **Feud as Currency:** Any insult, accident, or rumor can birth a feud; the GM may replace an SB result with a feud-token tied to a petty lord or house. Feud-tokens act as reusable complications: once per scene, the GM can spend a feud-token to have a rival appear, a bridge close, or a village refuse aid.
- **Rot & Tithe:** Each market or harvest scene carries a risk of rot—add a pressure if food or coin are exchanged without a blessing or a seal. A failed roll may double the tithe or spoil stored supplies.
- **The Curse Remembers:** When roads or negotiations stall, the GM may quietly repeat imagery—crossroads, whispers, mildew—to remind players that Acasia itself resists resolution. If the party ignores three such omens, the *Curse Stirrs* complication triggers automatically.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice in a burned abbey. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the charcoalers, trying to untie her cord from a Rothari death warrant.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Pale Causeway is a Class II Anchor site—the ghosts of workers who died building it still carry stones. Saikou Ira would leave a silver coin in every crack.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the toll-collectors. Take it, and your passage is always free—but the coin will taste of blood every time the Causeway floods.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Acasian psions are called “Feud-Readers.” They taste the weight of old grudges in the water. The Margravine employs two—and has never trusted a settlement they didn’t whisper.
- **The Ninth:** In any Acasian scene, the ninth toll paid at a bridge is never the last. The wise pay eight and barter for the ninth.

Acasian Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Milestone:** Crumble a crust at a broken milestone. Ignore the first *Peat-Fog* penalty.
- **Knot the Contract:** Tie a single knot in a writ’s ribbon. Cancel *Bridge Feud* or take –1 die on your next negotiation (your choice).
- **Name to the Blight:** Whisper a dead tax collector’s name into a grain sack. Gain +1 Effect when avoiding tithes this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Margravine.

Decline & Patronage

Patronage here is as brittle as candle wax. The Rothari Clan holds their marches by fear and iron law—patronage from them is real, but cruel, demanding service in blood or levy. Elsewhere, noble names are little more than titles printed on parchment and sold like debts. The Margravine keeps a ledger like scripture, binding feuds to her feast days, while mercenary captains trade loyalty for coin, switching colors with each bell.

To seek a patron in Acasia is to choose which hunger you will feed: the Rothari’s iron teeth, a Free Company’s purse, or the hollow blessing of a saint who may never have lived. Yet even false crowns cast shadows long enough to shelter those desperate enough to kneel.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **tithe-collectors or petty lords**.

- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **Free Company** patrols or village watchmen.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **feud-trackers** or **hedge-witches**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable road conditions**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **River reeve** or **Free Company captain** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **fog** or **bridge closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival bloodline** or **toll-lord’s enforcer** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **feud-kin**, **Free Company deserters**, or **Margravine’s guards** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **contract voided/levy doubled/curse triggered**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Margravine**, **Lame King**, or **Cursed Child** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog thickens/bridge falls/curse loops**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Acasia (Feud & Tithe):** Toll collectors demand double, bloodlines take offense, wagons are seized as “payment.”
- **Acasia (Rot & Famine):** Grain blights spread, wells run dry, abandoned villages hold only ghosts.
- **Acasia (Curse & Crossroads):** Roads loop back, milestones point the wrong way, the same bridge appears twice.

Boss Archetypes in Acasia

- **The False King (Feud/Authority)** — A petty lord or pretender who crowns themselves on the ruins of empire. *Phases:* Levy Demanded → Feud Declared → Hasty Coronation. *Cracks:* a **Blood-Peace Charter** suspends his authority; a **Marriage Proxy** binds him to a rival.
- **The Witch of the Blackwoods (Witchcraft/Curse)** — A hedge-witch, matriarch, or revenant who manipulates feuds and curses. *Phases:* Tithe of Fear → Curse of the Crossroads → Hollow Wedding. *Cracks:* a **Curse-Redemption Rite** breaks her hold; a **Mine-Share** gives the commune courage to defy her.
- **The Tithe Collector (Greed/Extortion)** — A bureaucrat-priest with writs, escorts, and the ability to summon feuds or famine with a single decree. *Phases:* Audit of Souls → Seizure of Grain → The Ledger’s Reckoning. *Cracks:* a **Toll-Exemption Plaque** voids his claim; a **Wine-Right** pays off his debtors.
- **The Rotting Child (Mystery/Curse)** — A folkloric horror tied to Acasia’s plague of false crossroads. *Phases:* Laughter in the Fog → The Bridge That Loops → The Feast of Ends. *Cracks:* a **Tithe-Remission Writ** fed to the fog; a **Monastery Letter** read aloud at the crossroads.

Encounter Seeds (Quick Hooks)

- **The Dowry That Walked:** A Blackwood matriarch’s dowry chest has been stolen. The chest contains a claim to a bridge that never floods—and a curse that the Margravine wants broken.
- **The Lame King’s Feast:** The Lame King invites the party to a feast. The feast is a trial. The food is memory. The wine is lies.
- **The Curse of the Pale Causeway:** The Causeway is repeating. Every crossing brings the party back to the same inn. The innkeeper is missing a finger. She says she gave it to the bridge.

4.11 Aelaerem (Halflings) — “Hearth & Hollow”

Apple-Matron (Elite): “A proper harvest feast requires three things: the finest cider aged in the right barrel, a guest-loaf baked with intention, and the wisdom to know when to invite the quiet ones to sit by the fire.”

Miller (Commoner): “My geese know a stranger’s step from a mile off, and they’ve never been wrong. If they start honking at noon, you best check your larder – someone’s coming who wasn’t invited. And when the Hollow walks, the only safe place is a lit hearth with the ninth cup unpoured.”

Theme & Atmosphere

In Amedell, the Aelaerem keep their bargains with bread, bells, and careful counting. Lanes run under ash and hawthorn; doors reddened with thread promise a seat and a story to any who step right. Their magic is housekeeping writ large – thresholds groomed, names jarred like jam, the Hollow fed with silence and the ninth cup left unpoured. When the Neighbors stir beneath the barrows, the folk answer with kettle songs and lantern law, and the fields behave because someone asked them to. Hospitality here is not kindness—it is a contract. Every meal is a promise, every gift a debt, every candle an argument against the dark.

What you notice first: The smell of baking bread and old apples. The way every threshold has a red thread tied at eye level. The silence of children when a stranger passes the village stone.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse an offered cup. The Hollow counts refusals as invitations. Pour the ninth cup for the empty chair, and you may feed it—or feed it.

Regional Mood: Warm Hearths, Cold Thresholds

Here, the land is not wilderness—it is a living ledger of favors and omissions. The Aelaerem do not build walls; they build hedges, stiles, and the careful geometry of guest-right. A red door means bread, salt, and one safe night if you come honest. A cup-mark stone on the verge accepts butter as a prayer. The watch-geese know your step before you do, and the scarecrow turns to face the road when the Hollow is hungry. The Neighbors—the things that live under the barrows, in the uncounted ninth step, in the space between the candle and its shadow—are not enemies. They are neighbors. And neighbors, if treated politely, will stay on their side of the hedge.

Starting Location: A cider-press barn perfumed with crushed apples and rain, where masks hang from beams awaiting the next festival. The Apple-Matron sits on a stool of woven twigs. Behind her, a Moot Oak leaf bleeding red sap onto a stone. “The Hollow walks early this year,” she says. “The Moot Oak bleeds wine. Will you speak for the field, or let the Neighbors claim it? Speak true—the geese are listening.”

(Lanes/Orchards/Mills/Downs/Barrows) Willow ford with flat stones and a bowed pollard that remembers faces; cider-press barn with sweet reek, old songs, doors that stick after dusk; chalk sheep-downs with a turf maze cut like a wheel.

Spades — Places

2. **Willow Ford** — Flat stones, bowed pollard that remembers faces. *The willow has a name. It will tell you if you sit beneath it and listen.*
3. **Cider-Press Barn** — Sweet reek, old songs, doors that stick after dusk. *The press was built from a barrow oak. The oak still dreams.*
4. **Chalk Sheep-Downs** — Turf maze cut like a wheel; sheep know the pattern. *The maze is a prayer. Walk it backward to ask a favor.*
5. **Millpond Under Alders** — The wheel turns some nights without water. *The water is not water. It is the memory of rain.*
6. **Bluebell Wood Path** — Rabbit-gates and snares set by careful hands. *The snares are for the Hollow. They catch only shadows—mostly.*
7. **Hedge-Tunnel Lane** — Between fields; nine stiles, locals count “eight-and-one.” *The ninth stile is a gap in the hedge. Step through, and the lane behind you changes.*
8. **Cup-Mark Stone on the Verge** — Butter left in niches goes missing kindly. *The butter vanishes before dawn. The Hollow leaves a pebble in exchange.*
9. **Barrow-by-the-Beech** — Bees go quiet at noon. *The bees are not sleeping. They are listening.*
10. **Market Green** — Maypole and stocks; carved village stones turned inward. *The stones face the green. They watch the maypole dance—and the dancers.*
- J **Dovecote Hill** — The scarecrow faces the road, not the rows. *The scarecrow has a face. It is the face of the last person who broke guest-right.*
- Q **Mother’s Orchard** — Rows straighten if you don’t look—curve if you do. *The orchard is a promise. Break it, and the apples will taste of ash.*
- K **Moot Oak** — Lantern nails hammered deep; benches at the roots. *The nails are from a hundred feuds. Each one holds a grudge.*
- A **Hollow Field** — A ring where no plow will hold a line, not for any coin. *The field is a mouth. It has not fed in a century.*

(Keepers/Elders/Mummers/Quiet Powers) Hedge-witch midwife who ties red thread and unties feuds; miller and his watch-geese—better sentries than men.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Hedge-Witch Midwife** — Ties red thread, unties feuds, and knows which births the Hollow watches. *Her thread is from her own hair. She never cuts it—only knots it.*
3. **Miller** — Watch-geese that remember faces; better sentries than men. *The geese have names. One is “Stranger.” It has never been wrong.*

4. **Orchard Reeve** — Tally-stick, cider-stained smile, and a list of who owes what harvest. *His tally-stick is an apple branch. The notches grow back.*
 5. **Beekeeper** — Keeps odd honey aside for “winter churches.” *The honey is from barrow flowers. It tastes of earth and old promises.*
 6. **Shepherd** — Bone whistle that calls dogs—and other things. *The whistle is from a wolf. The wolf still answers.*
 7. **Lantern-Warden** — Trims lamps and knows which shadow is wrong. *She lights the lamps in a pattern. The pattern is a prayer to keep the Hollow back.*
 8. **Mummers’ Captain** — Chest of masks, stricter rules than church. *The masks are not carved. They are grown.*
 9. **Traveling Tinker** — Bright kettles, dull knife for cutting oaths. *The knife was his father’s. His father used it to cut a contract with the Hollow.*
 10. **Bailiff of the Moot Oak** — Polite as a noose, carries a ledger of grudges. *His ledger is bark. The writing grows deeper each year.*
- J **Wold-Wardens** — Elders who swear by hedges, not crowns. *They measure time in hedge-layers. A hedge that has grown for a century has a hundred opinions.*
- Q **Apple-Matron** — Hostess of harvest feasts; power sits where she pours. *She pours the first cup for the eldest, the second for the guest, the eighth for the fire. The ninth cup is for the empty chair.*
- K **Thresher-King** — A title that moves but never leaves; harvest robes, seasonal authority. *He is chosen by the last sheaf. The sheaf is always a little damp.*
- A **The Pale Shepherd** — Comes when lambs are born and when people go missing. *He has no face. His hat is a shadow.*

(Folk Omens/Rites/Beasts/Night) Unseasonal fog; the road walks you back to your own gate. Scarecrow turns; it watches the lane, not the field. Black sow through the orchard; hooves scuff every charm.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Unseasonal Fog** — The road walks you back to your own gate. *The gate is closed. The latch is red. Do not touch it.*
3. **Scarecrow Turns** — It watches the lane, not the field. *The scarecrow’s head follows you. The crows are silent.*
4. **Soured Wassail** — The bowl gives back names you did not speak. *The names are of people who died last winter. They are not listed in any ledger.*
5. **Black Sow in the Orchard** — Hooves scuff every charm. *The sow was a woman once. She broke a vow.*

6. **Hive-Swarm at Dusk** — Smoke curls the wrong way. *The bees are spelling a word. The word is “guest.”*
 7. **Old Song Taken Up by Children** — Adults remember the verse none should sing. *The verse is about a barrow that opened. The children think it is a lullaby.*
 8. **Lanterns Burn Blue at the Ford** — Crossing costs more than coin. *The blue light is a toll-keeper. Payment is a story—or a secret.*
 9. **Out-of-Season Mumming** — Masks stick; faces won’t come off. *The masks are warm. They have a heartbeat.*
 10. **Chalk Maze Fills with Mist** — You step out somewhere older. *The mist has a smell—old wool and older bread.*
- J **Church Bell Rings Thirteen** — Something attends the sermon. *The thirteenth pew is empty. The dust on it is fresh.*
- Q **Harvest Tithe Demanded** — Hands gloved in leaves. *The hands do not belong to anyone in the village.*
- K **Moot Oak Bleeds Sap** — The color of wine; talk turns to knives. *The sap is warm. It tastes of blood and honey.*
- A **The Hollow Opens** — Burrows and barrows connect; footfalls answer underground. *The footsteps are counting. They stop at eight.*

(Blessings/Tokens/Host-Rights) Guest-loaf and salt—one night’s safe board anywhere with a red door; cider-mark—a free cup on the green buys gossip and patience.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Guest-Loaf & Salt** — One night’s safe board anywhere with a red door. *The loaf is barley and rye. Break it with the host, and the Hollow will not cross the threshold—for one night.*
3. **Cider-Mark** — A free cup on the green buys gossip and patience. *The mark is a notch on a barrel. The tapster will remember you—or pretend not to.*
4. **Hedge-Pass Ribbon** — Step through any thicket unsnagged, once. *The ribbon is red. Tie it to a branch, and the thorns will part—once.*
5. **Bee-Queen Share** — Honey and a warning from the hives when danger nears. *The honey is from a queen who died last year. Her ghost still guards the comb.*
6. **Shepherd’s Whistle** — Dogs and door-bolts heed you for one scene. *The whistle is a knucklebone. Blow it, and the dogs will obey—or they will hide.*
7. **Lantern-Writ** — The lamps stay lit along your path despite wind. *The writ is a bell. Ring it, and the lamps will not flicker—until dawn.*

8. **Mummers’ License** — Lawful mask and after-dark crossing for a feast day. *The license is a wooden mask. Wear it, and the Hollow will see a stranger—not a guest.*
9. **Orchard Right** — Pick at Mother’s Orchard without offense; the fruit hides a truth. *The fruit is a secret. Bite it, and the secret will become yours—or it will become you.*
10. **Mill Token** — The wheel turns at any hour, grain or rumor ground. *The token is a millstone chip. Feed it to the wheel, and it will grind anything—truths included.*
- J **Apple-Matron’s Blessing** — Hands help unseen when you ask no coin. *The blessing is a cup. Pour it out in trouble, and the fields will send rain—or roots.*
- Q **Private Moot Under the Oak** — Elders hear you alone; precedent sticks. *The moot is held at midnight. The oak’s roots are the jury.*
- K **Thresher-King’s Guard** — Six red-hooded harvesters escort you; doors open. *Their hoods are the color of dried blood. They do not speak.*
- A **Pale Shepherd’s Clause** — Once, the Hollow will not notice you; pass uncounted. *The clause is a silence. The Hollow will step aside—and will remember that it did.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (blessings/tokens/host-rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo Hearth & Hollow motifs—quiet bells, red thread, watch-geese, footsteps under the soil—so the dread feels woven through the hedges.

Additional Features

- **Bread & Lantern:** Presenting a guest-loaf and a lit lantern at a threshold shifts your next social action one step safer while you remain a guest of that hearth. The lantern must be lit from the host’s fire.
- **Neighborly Courtesies:** When you keep local taboos (count “eight-and-one,” turn village stones inward, leave butter at cup-marks), cancel the first SB generated by rites or negotiations in that scene.
- **Listen at the Stile:** A quiet pause at a stile, barrow, or hedge-tunnel yields a true omen—ask one short question about what the Hollow wants *here and now*; the answer arrives as a sign, a sound, or a small animal.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice in a hollow field. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the hedge-witches, trying to untie her cord from the Hollow’s ledger.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The cup-mark stones are Class II Anchor sites—the spirits of old offerings. Saikou Ira would leave butter in every niche—and a silver coin for luck.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the mummers. Take it, and your mask will never slip—but the coin will taste of dust every time the Hollow walks.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Aelaerem psions are called “Threshold-Readers.” They taste the weight of an invitation. The Apple-Matron employs one—and has never trusted a guest they didn’t vet.
- **The Ninth:** In any Aelaerem scene, the ninth guest to arrive at a feast is never human. The wise count eight and leave a chair empty.

Aelaerem Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Barrow:** Crumble a crust at a cup-mark stone. Ignore the first *Hive-Swarm* penalty.
- **Knot the Ribbon:** Tie a single knot in a red thread at a threshold. Cancel *Out-of-Season Mumming* or take –1 die on your next festival roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Hollow:** Whisper a dead person’s name into an empty chair. Gain +1 Effect when invoking guest-right this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Pale Shepherd.

Hearth Magic

The Aelaerem weave their power through careful observance and small courtesies. Their magic lies not in grand gestures but in the precise attention to thresholds, seasons, and the proper ordering of things. Red thread binds more than wounds—it ties names to places, promises to people, and the living to the Hollow that walks beneath their feet. To offend a hedge-witch is to invite the Neighbors’ attention; to earn an elder’s blessing is to walk with the earth’s favor.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or hedge-keepers**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **watch-geese or mummers**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or the Hollow**.

- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable light**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Orchard reeve or lantern-warden becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **fog** or **threshold shift**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **scarecrow** or **Hollow spirit** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **wold-wardens**, **mummers**, or **Neighbors** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **taboo broken/geese turn/Hollow stirs**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Apple-Matron**, **Thresher-King**, or **Pale Shepherd** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog thickens/barrow opens/Hollow walks**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Aelaerem (Hearth & Hollow):** Quiet bells toll for no reason; red thread appears tied to your belongings; watch-geese honk warnings in the night.
- **Aelaerem (Threshold Magic):** A door you passed through earlier now leads somewhere else; your shadow walks behind you instead of beside you.
- **Aelaerem (Folk Customs):** You forget a crucial local taboo and offend the Neighbors; small things begin to go wrong—milk sours, knots loosen, a child points at the empty chair.

Boss Archetypes in Aelaerem

- **The Scarecrow Regent (Omen/Threshold)** — A hedge-raised guardian wearing twelve charms and one wrong knot. *Phases:* Stare of the Lane → Scare the Crows → Harvest of Faces. *Cracks:* a **Guest-Loaf** offered to its post; a **Mummers’ License** to wear a mask it cannot read.
- **The Hollow Bride (Otherworld/Hospitality)** — A Neighbor wearing a borrowed name and wedding veil. *Phases:* Invitation Drifted → Feast of Shadows → Ninth Cup Poured. *Cracks:* a **Shepherd’s Whistle** to call the dogs that guard the threshold; a **Lantern-Writ** to see her true face.
- **Lantern Bailiff of the Moot (Justice/Order)** — Enforcer of hedge-law with warrant-nails and bell-keys. *Phases:* Lantern Law → Midnight Moot → Binding Geas. *Cracks:* a **Cider-Mark** to buy a night’s silence; a **Moot Oak bench** to appeal his ruling.
- **Beekeeper of Winter Church (Sacred/Whisper)** — Keeper of cold honey and sleeping hymns. *Phases:* Swarm Omen → Waxed Vow → Memory Tithe. *Cracks:* a **Bee-Queen Share** to call her swarm to heel; a **Lantern** lit from a winter church candle.

Faction Entanglements

- **Wold-Wardens:** Honor hedge-law (count stiles, turn stones inward) or suffer +1 SB on each night march; bringing steel disputes to the Moot Oak reduces the next travel DV by 1.
- **Mummers’ Companies:** Travel under mask grants advantage crossing parochial borders; anger them (perform out of season) and village gates close at dusk (Position –).
- **Lantern-Wardens:** Donate oil or mend lamps to earn an escort marker; ignore a lit-lane and pay a “darkness toll” (first Stealth/Scout roll each night suffers –1 die).
- **Apple-Matron Circles:** Feast-days open barns and purses; snub an invitation and local prices double until amends are made.
- **Neighbors (quiet powers):** Leave butter at cup-marks to cancel the first supernatural SB this leg; break taboo and the Hollow stirs (add a *Hollow Attention* tick).

Cross-Regional Ties

- **Aeler Soft-Power:** Red-thread guest-right and ledger courtesies are fashionable among Aeler houses; reputation for keeping hearth-law grants +1 die to parley with Aeler stewards and toll-clerks.
- **Kahfagian Sea-Lanes:** Beeswax, cider-brandy, and wool ride river-to-coast. Storm seasons push Kahfagian factors inland—good silver, stricter contracts.
- **Way of Silk Spurs:** Caravans detour across the downs for night-safe lanes under lantern law; counterfeit guest-loaf tokens discovered here echo as distrust along Silk waystations (Social DV +1 until cleared).
- **Valewood Fallout (North):** Moon-sap and dream pollen drift on certain winds: chalk mazes misalign, barrow-whispers grow bold. When *Valewood Weather* is in effect, the first night omen is always true (good or ill).

Encounter Seeds (Quick Hooks)

- **The Hollow Bride’s Invitation:** A wedding invitation arrives at the inn. The bride is not from any village on the map. The groom has not been seen in a week. The ninth chair at the feast is already occupied.
- **The Scarecrow’s Harvest:** Crows are building a nest on the scarecrow’s shoulder. Inside the nest is a key. The key opens a door that should not exist.
- **The Beekeeper’s Tithe:** The winter church’s bees have stopped producing honey. They are producing wax effigies of the PCs. The beekeeper wants to know why.

4.12 Aeler (Dwarves) — “Crowns & Under-Vaults”

Elite (Vault-Queen of a crownland)

“The mountain remembers every word carved in its stone, every seal pressed into its walls. To govern here is not to command, but to harmonize with the ancient songs that still echo in the deep places.”

Commoner (Under-Mason who can hear stone shift a room away)

“When the stone starts singing a different tune, you best listen. Three knocks in the morning means all’s well, but three knocks at night means something’s coming through the walls that wasn’t meant to walk.”

Crowns & Under-Vaults

The Aeler Kingdoms hold the mountains by breath, bell, and bargain. Dozens of sovereign holds – some sealed for centuries, others trading openly with lowland markets – share only the deep roots of stone and the supremacy of the High King Beneath the Peaks. Their halls run like arteries, their cities open in thunderous caverns where bridges leap between ribs of stone and cisterns shine like night skies turned inward. *Survival* is the first law: air is counted, water is bartered, light is rationed by wick and prayer. *Tradition* is the second: seals are kept, measures remain true, and the dead keep their offices as carefully as the living. Between the two, a people learn to argue quietly and build loudly.

Collectives (clans, guild-kin, lamp-companies) own what the mountain allows; individuals are custodians by oath. Trade runs under and over the range through under-ways and pass-forts, stitching protectorates and lowland markets to vault-mouth gates. When tunnels whisper or the air tastes wrong, the Aeler move as one animal; when the Kingsmoot calls, crowns and abbesses argue in bell-code and sealed writs until the stone itself seems to lean in.

The Fractured Crowns: Aeler Faction Spectrum

Aeler society is not monolithic. Beneath the High King’s nominal authority, each crownland follows its own star. Attitudes toward the surface range from open partnership to militant isolation, and even the most reclusive holds maintain **Edgewalker** contacts to monitor the world above.

- **Traditionalist / “Reactionary”** – These holds idealize the old mountain-empire: closed gates, iron tariffs, and the certain knowledge that surface-dwellers cannot be trusted. They resemble the dwarves of fireside tales: stubborn, insular, and quick to reach for an axe when a human mentions “progress.” Their kings speak of the days when no foreigner stepped past the vaultmouth. *Clocks: FOREIGNER SUSPICION [4], HOLD SEALED [6]*.
- **Cooperative / “Open Hand”** – These holds trade freely with Aelaerem, Kahfagia, and even the Vilikari. They staff the under-markets, send engineers to repair bridges in Viterra, and treat the surface as a resource to be managed, not a threat to be shunned. *Clocks: TRADE ROUTE PROSPERITY [6], CULTURAL FRICTION [4]*.

- **Isolationist / “Silent Stone”** – Deep holds that have not answered a Kingsmoot call in living memory. Their gates are lost, their peoples rumoured to have turned inward, worshipping forgotten depths. They neither help nor harm the surface – but when a White Flood or a gas flare occurs, their silence becomes a hazard of its own. *Clocks: SILENT HOLD AWAKENS* [8], *ANCIENT GRUDGE* [6].

Most Aeler characters and settlements fall somewhere between these poles, and the same hold might shift its stance over a season, depending on grain prices, a new Vault-Queen, or a disaster that forces its hand.

Spades — Places (vaultmouths, descents, underways, crown seats)

2. (Security/Gatekeeping) Vaultmouth Gate in a hillslope: bronze lungs for breath-tests, tally-niches for lamps.
 3. (Tradition/Oaths) Crown-Crypt Porch where oaths are sworn to sleeping kings.
 4. (Commerce/Underground) Under-Market: lantern alleys between cistern pillars; damp coin, dry wit.
 5. (Labor/Danger) Smoke-Shaft Stair spiraling up to a soot hatch; handprints black as seals.
 6. (Mystery/Whispers) Gloam Cistern—black water, lead scales, whispers carry too far.
 7. (Maintenance/Travel) Lamplighter’s Mile on the Under-Road; niches sting with spent wicks.
 8. (Precision/Authority) Measure Vault: standard rods and weights chained under glass and oath.
 9. (Sacred/Knowledge) Reliquary Arcade: bell-chimes answer drafts; saints keep their own tallies.
 10. (Military/Strategic) Twin-Throne Gate—surface fortress straddling a chasm bridge.
- J (Knowledge/Secrecy) Deep Archive Stacks behind grillwork; scriptoria cells breathe ink and dust.
- Q (Royalty/Privilege) Queen’s Descent: private stair from palace to royal vault-house.
- K (Politics/Power) Kingsmoot Cavern—crownstones in a ring around a bottomless dark.
- A (Infrastructure/Majesty) The Spine Underway, a great tunnel linking crownlands beneath the peaks.

Hearts — People & Factions (crowns, keepers, guilds, legates)

2. (Apprenticeship/Dedication) Lamplighter apprentice with a jingling key-ring and soot in the lungs.
 3. (Craft/Knowledge) Under-Mason who can hear stone shift a room away.
 4. (Authority/Duty) Vault Warden with breath-ledger and seal-rods; patient as granite.
 5. (Protection/Faith) Censer-Knight of the Dawn – fights miasma and men with equal zeal.
 6. (Sacred/Craft) Key-Sister (monastic locksmith) who names wards like prayers.
 7. (Commerce/Authority) Under-Market assessor whose stamp can starve or save a stall.
 8. (Engineering/Expertise) Engineer of Underways (geometer) with rod, hammer, and the right maps.
 9. (Tradition/Law) Oath-Keeper of the Crown Crypt – memory like iron, smile like law.
 10. (Diplomacy/Authority) Legate of the Under-Seal, royal commissioner between kingdoms.
- J (Communication/Loyalty) White-Ribbon tunnel courier; runs blind, rings true.
- Q (Royalty/Authority) Vault-Queen of a crownland, sovereign above and below.
- K (Supreme Authority/Tradition) High King Beneath the Peaks, first among crowns by ancient concord.
- A (Spiritual Power/Resolution) Lumenor of the Under-Altars, one sentence opens doors and closes debates.

Clubs — Complications/Threats (air, water, stone, rite, jurisdiction)

2. (Danger/Disorientation) Bad air pocket—candles gutter blue; lungs complain, schedules fail.
3. (Disruption/Flood) Drip-flood from a burst cistern reroutes corridors without asking.
4. (Accident/Destruction) Gas flare kisses a lamp; eyebrows and evidence vanish.
5. (Error/Security) Seal misread—the wrong door opens, the right one will not.
6. (Quarantine/Delay) Under-mold quarantine shuts the market just as your crate arrives.

7. (Danger/Warning) Settling crack—dust snow warns the roof wants down.
8. (Accusation/Suspicion) Stolen key turns up in your kit; accusations ring like bells.
9. (Conflict/Jurisdiction) Bell-code conflict—two authorities claim the same chime.
10. (Political Conflict/Violence) Vault-right feud: crown guards face basilica wardens on a stair.
- J (Disaster/Trapped) Cave-in behind—proof, friends, and retreat on the far side.
- Q (Religious Conflict/Inquisition) Heresy inquest in the under-chapel; arrests in whispers.
- K (Authority/Restriction) General Under-Seal—all vault traffic halted by royal decree.
- A (Natural Disaster/Destruction) White Flood—mountain thaw becomes a river through your route.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (keys, passes, breath, priority, precedent)

2. (Utility/Time) Lamp-priority tally—skip one lamplighter queue.
3. (Safety/Access) Breath-measure allotment—lawful time in a sealed chamber (once).
4. (Security/Authority) Key-Writ—operate a named lock one time, witnessed.
5. (Travel/Security) Underway Pass—escorted travel between two vaultmouths.
6. (Commerce/Rights) Stall-Right in the under-market for a season.
7. (Engineering/Safety) Engineer Shoring—a crew stabilizes your chosen corridor on your timetable.
8. (Commerce/Trust) Assay Mark—your coin/metal accepted sight unseen below.
9. (Protection/Law) Crypt Asylum—temporary sanctuary under crown law.
10. (Authority/Access) Vault Inventory License—remove a named cache under witness.
- J (Military/Authority) Under-Guard Commission—command a vault detachment for a day.
- Q (Royalty/Privilege) Private Descent with the Vault-Queen or High King’s chancellor.
- K (Supreme Authority/Access) High King’s Sealed Writ—doors open, mouths close across crownlands.
- A (Exception/Power) The Under-Seal Clause—temporary exception to any lock, levy, or rite below.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: **Spade** = place, **Heart** = actor, **Club** = pressure, **Diamond** = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2→5→4, 6→10→6, J/Q/K→8, A→10).
- Treat **Diamonds** as codified outcomes (keys/passes/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any **A** appears, echo stone & breath motifs—keys click, bells answer, and the mountain listens (and remembers).

Additional Features

- **Count the Air:** When a scene establishes scarce air, a character who actively paces their breathing (counted steps, measured rests) may shift *Position* one step safer on their next physical action in a confined space.
- **Bell-Code Courtesy:** If the party adopts local bell etiquette (asking a warden which chime applies and heeding it), gain +1 assist die on negotiations or passage requests within a vault or under-market.
- **Measure is Mercy:** Presenting a certified measure (rod, weight, sealed tally) calms a dispute: cancel the first SB generated by commerce or jurisdictional friction in the scene.

Stone & Sovereignty

In the deep places, survival depends on precision and tradition. The Aeler understand that stone does not forgive error – a misread seal can mean death, a miscalculated air measure can doom an expedition, and a broken bell-code can spark jurisdictional war. Their society is built on layers of authority, each with its own rites, rights, and responsibilities. To navigate their realm is to learn a complex dance of deference and demand, where even the humblest lamplighter holds power over the darkness, and the smallest key can unlock the greatest vault.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **vault wardens or lamplighter companies**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **under-guards or echo bats**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or assessors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable air**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised: Breath warden or vault warden** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **air shift or seal change**.
- **Foe Appears:** A rival crown’s guard or gas wraith arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional crown guards, true masons, or lamp companies arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **seal misread/cave-in/flare ignites**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Vault-Queen, High King’s Legate, or Lumenor** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **gas floods/water breaks/floor collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Aeler (Stone & Breath):** Keys click in the wrong locks, bells answer without being rung, mountain air grows thin without warning.
- **Aeler (Authority & Tradition):** A seal is misread, bell-codes conflict between jurisdictions, a vault warden demands proper credentials.
- **Aeler (Underground Hazards):** Bad air pockets form, settling cracks warn of collapse, gas flares ignite unexpectedly.

Aeler — Under-Vault Tensions

Starting Location: An Underway junction lit by guttering brass lanterns, its stone walls scored with tally-marks from a dozen forgotten crowns.

“Among the Aeler, stone remembers the weight of oaths, and every echo calls a reckoning.”

In... An Underway junction, a Geometer halts the party with a tally-rod. “The Spine shifts,” he says, stone-dust in his beard. “Choose a crown—or be buried by one.”

Regional Motifs Load-bearing oaths, fault-prayers, crown-rights, catacomb guilds.

Whispers to Offer “Cut a supporting tie,” “Sign for another’s debt,” “Take a shortcut through the sealed tunnel.”

External Clocks Threat: “The Spine Slips”; Fracture: “Maps Reorder”; Community: “Surface Panic.”

Complications Load-lights dim; echoes reply in politics; crown agents arrive early.

Anchors at Risk A PC’s workshop; a shared refuge tunnel.

Escalation Beat The tally-rod points to the most guilty PC.

Relief Shore a vault with sacrifice (1 anchor), or complete a truce between crowns; Spirit + Resolve (5) to hold a cave-in long enough to evacuate.

Faction Entanglements

- **Edgewalkers (Prospectors):** If you accept their escort or intel, start a 4-segment *Opportunity* clock you can cash for +1 Effect on one venture. If you refuse a posted hazard, they post *your* route as “open” (first stealth or smuggling roll this leg suffers –1 die).
- **True Masons (Infrastructure Orders):** Pledge tools or labor to earn a *Mason’s Stamp* (treat as papers to traverse construction zones). Cross a marked barrier without their leave and gain the *Tampered Work* tag—first structural mishap SB against you is free.
- **Lamplighter Companies:** Donate wick, oil, or time on the Mile to bank a *Lamp Credit*; spend to ignore darkness penalties once on the Under-Road. Skip a service bell and all under-market buys that scene cost +1 clock tick (queues & suspicion).
- **Under-Market Assessors:** Submit to measure/weigh and reduce Commerce DV by 1 this scene. Try to pass unassayed goods—on a Miss, lose the load *or* accept a *Caveat Stamp* that poisons your price two markets downstream.
- **Breath Wardens:** Register bodies & flames before sealed work; compliance cancels the first air-hazard SB. Skipping registry adds a *Thin Air* tick to the leg (applies –1 die to the first exertion test in confinement).

Cross-Regional Ties & Soft Power

- **Agrarian Reliance (Human Breadbelts):** Grain, timber, tallow, and fleece convoys from Acasia/Vhasia/Viterra sustain vault populations. Famine or levy spikes uprange impose night rationing: Under-Road checks +1 DV and food trades add +1 SB pressure until relief.
- **Standards Diplomacy:** Aeler *Measure Vault* rods adopted abroad grant +1 die to settle disputes in foreign markets; rejecting Aeler standards increases toll and inspection frequency (first border scene gains a free “Lock/Barrier” SB).
- **True Mason Missions Abroad:** Accept a Mason cadre to “stabilize” bridges, ports, or sluices: reduce Travel DV by 1 on that route for the arc, but the route now respects Aeler closure bells (authorities can halt traffic with one writ).
- **Edgewalker Concessions:** Prospect notes traded to frontier lords exchange for wayleaves and salvage rights; cash once for an *Under-Seal Clause (local)* or accept a rival claimant clock that will mature if you delay.
- **Kahfagian Interface (Sea Monopoly):** Aeler export hard-goods via Kahfagian factors; storm seasons or privateer scares add a *Harbor Quarantine* tick to any surface leg feeding those ports (customs DV +1).
- **Aelerem/Aelinnel Fallout:** When *Valewood Weather* is signaled, Aeler works creak; all bell-codes in mixed settlements (Aelerem/Aelinnel) are one step easier to misread (first bell-etiquette scene: add a free “Error/Security” SB unless you consult a local).

Trade Goods & Consequences

- **Airworks & Wick (Oil, Char, Filters):** Donate to a vault—bank a *Breath Favor* to cancel the next bad-air complication. Hoard in a shortage and your lot is flagged; all purchases beneath that crown suffer –1 die until you settle a fine or tithe.
- **Stonework & Ironwork (Beams, Keys, Rods):** Selling to foreign keeps spreads Aeler codes: once per arc, treat a foreign gate as if it used Aeler warding (gain +1 die with Key-Sisters/warders there). Counterfeit measure rods trigger a cross-border inquest clock.
- **Foodflows (Grain, Fleece, Tallow):** Move relief trains to clear one *Rationing* tag for a settlement (DV –1 for social checks there). Divert a relief train and gain an *Audit* clock that follows you three markets hence.
- **Cistern-Right & Water Engineering:** Fund a sluice or cistern abroad to gain *Water Priority* (skip one queue during drought). Neglect maintenance and the keeper may invoke *Aeler Liability*—pay or lose access to the route for a season.

Patron Networks (Below and Beyond)

- **The Sealed Gate:** Consecrated door-nails from True Mason kits act as single-use *stay* writs (negate one forced entry this scene).

- **The Traveler:** Spine milestones double as wayshrines; leave a brass chit to reroll one failed travel test on that segment this arc.
- **Inquisitor Prime:** Breath-pure censers sanction “clean rooms”; once per delve, dispel one ambient miasma or ward-rot effect at cost of +1 Obligation to local abbey-knights.
- **Maelstræus:** Under-Market stalls tithe to the Great Ledger; cash a *Market Dominance* tick to flip one price band in your favor for a scene, then mark a 4-segment *Karmic Debt* with assessors.

Survival-Horror Procedures (Use Often)

- **Headcount & Flamecount:** At scene start in confinement, ask “Who breathes, what burns?” If headcount+flamecount exceeds posted limit, add a free “Thin Air” SB and start a 4-segment *Stale Air* clock.
- **Two Bells to Safety:** Any time the fiction stalls underground, ring two nearby bells (authority vs. sanctum). PCs must pick one to heed; ignoring both increases the next hazard’s Cap by +1 (stone holds grudges).
- **Measure or Mistrust:** Producing a certified rod/weight cancels the first commerce/jurisdiction SB this scene; failing to present one imposes –1 die on haggling or passage until appeased.

Diplomatic Favor & Reputation Echoes

- **Breath Favor (minor resource):** Earned by donating wick/oil or assisting air wardens. Spend to downgrade one underground hazard outcome or to bypass a lamplighter queue.
- **Stamps & Seals:**
 - *Mason-Marked:* Doors to worksites open; smugglers avoid you (harder to buy contraband, easier to cross safely).
 - *Edge-Trusted:* Prospectors share fresh maps—first detour per leg is free; officials eye you as opportunists (first civic audience DV +1).
 - *Assessor-Clean:* Under-markets honor your assay; rivals spread rumors—add a trailing *Audit* clock if you score a windfall.

Boss Archetypes in Aeler

Systemic / Economic / Conspiracy

- **Under-Market Syndic (Cartel/Measure Fraud):** Price-fixes breath, wick, and water; wields corrupt assay marks to starve rivals. *Win by exposing forged measures or seizing the Assay Chain.*
- **True Mason Provost (Infrastructure Coup):** Locks cities behind “safety closures,” weaponizes detours and permits. *Win by forcing a public bell-code audit or breaking the Permit Clock.*

- **Edgewalker Concessionaire (Route Monopolist):** Controls salvage and shortcuts, posts hazards to strangle traffic. *Win by proving route tampering or opening a sanctioned bypass.*
- **Bell-Code Inquisitor (Silent Coup):** Rewrites chimes to shift jurisdiction; arrests arrive as echoes. *Win by restoring canonical bell charts or capturing the Chime Key.*

Survival Horror (Environment as Boss)

- **White Flood (Water/Pressure):** Thaw-swollen river through the halls; phases at *trickle* → *surge* → *roar*. *Win by sluicework, sacrificial breach, or riding the flood.*
- **Bad Air (Miasma/Invisible):** Candles gutter blue; thoughts slow; corridors choose the slowest. *Win by air discipline, filter rites, or opening a lung-shaft.*
- **Hungry Stone (Creep/Collapse):** Settling cracks hunt noise and heat; shudders on every miss. *Win by shoring, silence, and rerouting stress through old ribs.*
- **Lamp Famine (Darkness/Isolation):** Wicks fail in sequence; last lights lure you deeper. *Win by restoring the Lamplighter’s Mile or kindling a saint-wick.*

Undead / Fallen Kingdom / Eldritch / Demonic

- **Crown-Lich of the Crypt (Undead Sovereign):** Keeps ancient offices; binds petitioners with oaths to the dead. *Win by repealing a mortmain writ or severing the Oath-Chain.*
- **Echo-King in the Deep (Eldritch Memory):** A throne of voices; answers every argument you will ever make. *Win by changing the Measure (new precedent) or striking the Silent Note.*
- **Seal-Devil (Demonic Contract):** Lives in locks and signatures; eats exceptions. *Win by offering a flawless counter-seal or starving it of loopholes.*
- **The Hollow Architect (Fallen Works):** A ghost-guilder rebuilding the empire wrong on purpose. *Win by unkeying the master plan or collapsing the false load paths.*

Boss Mechanics Notes

- **Air & Light Tracks:** In confined scenes, track *Headcount*, *Flamecount*. If *Headcount* + *Flamecount* exceeds posted limit, add a free “Thin Air” SB and start **Stale Air** [4]. Each tick imposes −1 die to exertion until vented.
- **Jurisdiction Clocks:** Many bosses run a **Bell-Code Conflict** [4] or **Seal Dispute** [6]. On fill, the boss gains *Authority Surge*: increase their social DV by +1 and seize initiative once.
- **Lair Actions (choose 2–3):**
 - *Collapse Probe:* Mark “Settling Crack”; nearest noisy PC tests PROWESS or risk *Pin/Separate*.

- *Breath Tax*: Reduce *Flamecount* by 1; next exertion in zone costs Fatigue 1 on a miss.
 - *Blackout/Glare*: Snuff or flare lamps; impose Disorient (—1 die) until a *Lamp-lighter Action* restores balance.
 - *Bell Overrule*: Swap which faction’s law applies; social actions vs. boss gain +1 DV this round.
 - *White Flood Surge*: Advance environment clock; force MOVE/WRECK or be *Separated*.
- **Phase Triggers**: Environment bosses phase when *Air* hits 2/4, *Water* hits 3/6, or *Light* hits 0; Conspiracy bosses phase when *Audit* or *Permit* clocks fill.
 - **Truth & Measure**: Producing a certified rod/weight cancels the first commerce/jurisdiction SB each phase; forging one gives the boss 1 SB and a free *Expose Fraud* reaction.
 - **Crowd Pressure**: In under-markets, add **Panic Crowd [4]**; each tick adds +1 DV to precise actions (shoot, pick, ritual) unless calmed with bell-code or coin.
 - **Fear Hooks (optional)**: *Bad Air* inflicts FEAR vs. suffocation; *Echo-King* inflicts FEAR vs. isolation; *Seal-Devil* inflicts FEAR vs. helplessness. On Fail: mark *Shaken*; on Critical Fail: drop a resource (*lamp*, *key*, *breath*).

4.13 Aelinnel (Gnomes) — “Stone, Bough, and Bright Things”

Elite (Stone Prince of Aelinnel)

“The law here flows like water over stone – it finds its own path, and woe to those who try to dam it with paper and pretense. The earth itself will testify against the unjust.”

Commoner (Charcoal-burner clan who read draught and omen by smoke)

“Our kilns tell us more than your books ever could. When the smoke curls left, the tide’s with you. When it splits in three, best stay by your own hearth till it burns straight again. And never trust a court that speaks in only one ledger.”

Stone, Bough, and Bright Things

Aelinnel homeland of Aevrossa clings to the Dolmis coast beneath the shadow of the Valewood, its halls threaded through granite and hawthorn, its roads counted by antler-posts and moonlit math. Here, promises have weight and numbers have manners. *Even* steps are safe, *odd* words are careful, and truths are traded like copper nails – bright, useful, slightly dangerous in the wrong pocket.

Yet no single crown rules the gnomish lands. Dozens of courts, guilds, and seasonal pacts weave a shifting lattice of loyalty. Some Aelinnel hold fast to ancient fae treaties; others barter in the Green Market with pragmatic coin; still others vanish into the deep woods, speaking only to stag-roads and stone-singers. The gnomish heart is divided – and that division is their strength.

Craft and courtesy govern traffic between fae courts and mortal keeps. Gnomish stone-singers tune bridges with a hum; forester-wardens hammer copper where iron would offend. In markets under living roofs, a sentence can be cut to fit a purse, and a memory can be wrapped for travel. Paths sometimes shorten themselves for those who keep good count, and lengthen for those who sneer at patterns.

At a Glance

- **Atmosphere:** Moonlit math, polite iron, and the uncanny certainty of numbers.
- **Key Conflict:** Said versus meant; fae courtesy versus mortal bluntness.
- **Notable Threats:** Glamour fog, iron offense, geas-catch, the Green Gate yawning at the wrong hour.
- **Common Rewards:** Hazel tokens, tide-path keys, oath-beads, and the Wild Hunt’s clemency.

The Three Courts: Aelinnel Alignments

Aelinnel society is not a single crown but a lattice of courts, guilds, and seasonal pacts. Three broad stances shape their dealings with outsiders and with the fae. Most gnomes shift between these postures depending on the season, the tide, and who is asking.

- **Thorn–Courteous (Fae–Lean)** – These gnomes keep the old pacts with the Lady of Thorns and the Green Knight. They speak in two ledgers, never carry naked iron,

and treat every threshold as a negotiation. They are the ones who remind visitors to count their steps and pour no ninth cup. *Clocks: COURTESY DEBT [4], HAWTHORN PATIENCE [6].*

- **Market–Square (Trade–Lean)** – These gnomes prioritize the Green Market, the Under-Market, and the flow of quartz, copper, and name-script. They are pragmatic, will use iron if it is gilded, and view fae courtesies as bargaining chips rather than sacred laws. *Clocks: TARIFF DISPUTE [4], MARKET DOMINANCE [6].*
- **Forester–Trusted (Wild–Lean)** – These gnomes live among the stag-roads and root-galleries, closer to the stone-singers and the tree-wardens. They speak the old names of tides and groves, and they are the first to notice when the thorn blight spreads or the moonwell stains a name wrong. *Clocks: ROOT CALLING [4], WILD HUNT INTEREST [6].*

Most Aelinnel characters and settlements fall somewhere between these poles, and the same gnome might wear a different mask when trading at the Green Market than when walking the stag-roads.

Spades — Places (stone spires, sea-rock, deep woods)

2. (Tide/Mystery) Tide-rift steps cut into black rock; limpets and old votive nails keep count for those who forget.
 3. (Magic/Transformation) Moonwell basin in a granite bowl; coins turn green in a week, names in a season.
 4. (Music/Stone) Dolmen stair up a ridge; each capstone rings a different interval if you tap it true.
 5. (Magic/Secrecy) Charcoal coppice under witch-hazel; a neat ash-heap hides a door that opens on even knocks only.
 6. (Nature/Music) Basalt organ cliffs: sea-caves breathe like slow bellows; the wind prefers prime numbers.
 7. (Nature/Tradition) Stag Road – game-trail marked by antler-posts; hooves know it best, maps accept it grudgingly.
 8. (Magic/Purity) Quartz spring where the sand shines like ground stars; drinkers tell the same story with better structure.
 9. (Fae/Visibility) Elf-causeway of pale flags through a marsh; visible at dawn and dusk and whenever someone is counting aloud.
 10. (Underground/Living) Root gallery under an oak hill; lanterns hang from living bark – two lit, one listening.
- J (Death/Music) Barrow gallery with stone chimes; a cold draft from below plays scales no throat can sing.

- Q (Fae/Danger) Thorn Court ring – hawthorns trained into arches; petals fall like knife-points and settle into proofs.
- K (Civilization/Magic) Hall of Aelinnel: a timber keep threaded between standing stones; floors level themselves for guests.
- A (Otherworld/Gate) The Green Gate in a sea-arch; at certain tides it opens to a forest not on any map, and expects exact change.

Hearts — People & Factions (keepers, courts, craftsmen, hunters)

2. (Practical/Knowledge) Goat-herd of the stone edges – measures danger in hoof-widths; never wrong twice.
 3. (Craft/Divination) Charcoal-burner clan who read draught and omen by smoke; their kilns hum in thirds.
 4. (Magic/Commerce) Hedge-witch with a pocket of thorns and prices stated in *un-leses*.
 5. (Craft/Magic) Stone-singer (quarryman) whose hum finds a seam and a secret; walls relax when they pass.
 6. (Nature/Courtesy) Forester-warden with copper nails and a polite dislike of iron; paths obey their hammer.
 7. (Nature/Tradition) Reed-net fisher who knows when the selkies listen; mends nets to lullabies in 5s and 8s.
 8. (Law/Magic) Oath-carver who sets promises in quartz so they can be seen; breaks none, bends many.
 9. (Navigation/Guidance) Way-keeper of the Stag Road; never lost, often followed, sometimes found ahead.
 10. (Commerce/Magic) Green-market broker trading truths for trinkets and back again; receipts in leaf-vein script.
- J (Fae/Authority) Green Knight – antler helm, mirror-bright blade, courtesy old as frost; keeps a tally of saved insults.
- Q (Fae/Power) Lady of Thorns, sovereign of a hawthorn court; smiles like a snare and forgives in exact measures.
- K (Authority/Magic) Stone Prince of Aelinnel, mortal crown with fae debts properly indexed and current.
- A (Hunt/Destiny) Huntsman of the Moonlit Ride; his horn turns shortcuts into roads, and debts into destinations.

4. (Magic/Authority) Dolmen carving-right – inscribe a name or claim on a speaking stone; arguments quiet while you carve.
 5. (Hospitality/Fae) Guest-bough from the Thorn Court – one night’s safe table among thorns; knives behave.
 6. (Magic/Access) Quarry allotment of clear quartz; subtle doors open to its bearer if asked in the right tense.
 7. (Commerce/Magic) Green Market voucher – buy a truth at face value (today only); tomorrow costs interest.
 8. (Magic/Binding) Oath-bead; a spoken promise warms the bead when kept, chills when not, glows if misunderstood.
 9. (Travel/Magic) Tide-path key – lawful crossing of a named sea-cave at neap; the cave will wait.
 10. (Nature/Permission) Forest truce – hunt, cut, or travel through a warded copse without offense; the birds file no reports.
- J (Protection/Fae) Green Knight escort from ridge to gate; watchers bow, paths part, insults lodge elsewhere.
- Q (Fae/Authority) Private audience with the Lady of Thorns; a whisper exits as policy with petals attached.
- K (Authority/Magic) Stone Prince’s seal – levies defer, foresters guide, scribes stop arguing and fetch tea.
- A (Hunt/Protection) Wild Hunt clemency – ride under the horn for one night; no hound will take you, no debt will sleep.

Quick use notes

- Draw until all four suits appear: **Spade** = place, **Heart** = actor, **Club** = pressure, **Diamond** = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5→4, 6–10→6, J/Q/K→8, A→10).
- Treat **Diamonds** as codified outcomes (charms/passes/host-rights) that *change position* rather than call for a roll.
- If any **A** appears, echo moonlight-on-stone and tidy-logic motifs – antlers in shadow, petals that cut, a tide that breathes, and a shortcut that insists on proper counting.

Additional Features

- **Counting Etiquette:** Once per scene, any character who carefully counts (steps, breaths, beads, stitches) may shift *Position* one step safer for the next action that exploits pattern or timing.

- **Copper over Iron:** When the party visibly favors copper/brass tools over iron in fae-facing scenes, gain +1 assist die from locals (or avoid a -1 penalty) for acts of courtesy, passage, or petition.
- **Spoken Maths:** Reciting a simple sequence (2-3-5-8...) in tense moments steadies the scene: cancel the first SB generated by a navigation or negotiation misstep this encounter.

Courtesies of the Green Gate

- **Never bring iron** past a hawthorn arch unless it is gilded or named. Copper is polite, silver is opinionated.
- **Always return what points the way.** Way-cords, antler-posts, chalk. Borrow the path; do not keep it.
- **Speak debts in the daylight.** Promises made under lantern-boughs are heard by leaves as well as by law.

Numbers & Nature

In Aelinnel, the boundary between mathematics and magic blurs like morning mist. The gnomes understand that numbers are not merely tools for calculation but the underlying rhythm of reality itself. Their courtesy is mathematical – a precise exchange of value, a careful balance of obligation and favor. To offend their sense of order is to invite the world’s correction; to honor it is to find that paths open, doors speak, and even the stones themselves become allies. The fae courts they traffic with recognize this respect for pattern and respond in kind, creating a delicate dance of mutual benefit and barely-contained chaos.

Thematic SB Spend Table (Aelinnel)

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **thorn-courtiers** or **forest-wardens**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **stone-singers** or **green-market traders**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **stag-road trackers** or **oath-carvers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Green Knight** or **Lady of Thorns’** herald becomes aware and begins responding.

- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **glamour fog** or **root-slide**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **stone-wight** or **thorn blight spirit** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **fae courtiers**, **forester-wardens**, or **stag-horn riders** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **geas triggers/green gate opens/iron offense declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Lady of Thorns**, **Stone Prince**, or **Huntsman of the Moonlit Ride** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **tide turns/green gate yawns/thorn blight spreads**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options (Aelinnel)

- **Numbers & Magic (1–2 SB):** Antler-posts rearrange themselves, petals cut like blades, moonlight reveals a path that was not there a moment ago.
- **Fae Courtesy (1–3 SB):** A hawthorn arch closes behind you; copper tools glow with fae attention; a polite phrase becomes a binding geas.
- **Glamour (1–2 SB):** Conversations arrive folded and misaddressed; time drifts unexpectedly; your footfalls no longer match your steps.

Aelinnel — Tidal Bargains

Starting Location: A tide-shed at dawn, fog curling over anchored barges, while gulls cry omens over the river’s black glass.

“In Aelinnel lands, the river speaks with many tongues, and each tide demands a name in return.”

In . . . a tide-shed at dawn, a gnomish reeve offers passage on a sealed barge. “The Green Gate opens at neap tide. What we trade there, the Dolmis will not name.”

Regional Motifs Tide-ledgers, river gods, sealed cargo, name-taboo.

Whispers to Offer “Peek in the crate,” “Speak the hidden name,” “Break quarantine.”

External Clocks Threat: *Green Gate Thirst* [6]; Community: *Dockside Fear* [4]; Anchor: *Barge Oath* [4].

Complications Freshwater turns brackish; the cargo sings; a rival reeve boards with knives.

Anchors at Risk A PC’s river-kin; the barge’s blessing.

Escalation Beat The Gate opens early; the tide runs backwards.

Relief Offer a river-gift; carry a name written in river-mud across the threshold; spend 2 to seal the leak for a scene.

Faction Entanglements

- **Stone–Singer Conclave:** Sponsor a bridge-chant or way-tuning and bank a *Harmonic Favor*—spend to shift *Position* one step safer on any passage across worked stone or living root. Skip their rites and the first crossing this leg gains a free “Lock/Barrier” SB as paths sulk.
- **Forester–Wardens:** Accept copper-nail protocols to cancel the first *Fae Offense* SB in a wood scene. Drive iron stakes or break taboo and mark a 4-segment *Polite Apology* clock you must clear before locals assist you again.
- **Green-Market Brokers:** Submit an itemized truth (what was said / what was meant) to reduce barter DV by 1 for the scene. Try to haggle on single-ledger terms, and the market tags you with *Exact Change Only*—all bargains hereafter demand a tithe of memory or name until appeased.
- **Oath–Carvers’ Guild:** Have a promise set in quartz to gain a *Visible Oath* token; spend to treat one social test as if aided by a reputable witness. Breaking a quartz-oath spawns a 4-segment *Shattered Nuance* clock that complicates future negotiations.

- **Tide-Reeves:** File a tide-plan before neap to earn a *Tide Window*—ignore one tidal timing penalty this leg. Skipping the ledger adds a free “Wrong Tide” SB the first time you touch the Dolmis.

Cross-Regional Ties & Soft Power

- **Way of Silk Interface:** Kon’reh-counted caravans that adopt Aelinnel step-metrics (even steps, counted halts) gain +1 die to avoid ambushes on the Way this arc. Breaking count invites a free “Glamour Fog” SB at the next way-shrine.
- **Aeler Standards (Rods & Wards):** Recognize Aeler measures publicly to reduce dispute DV by 1 with dwarven legates; insist on gnomish dual-ledger and foreign merchants grumble—first mixed-market scene gains an “Assay Doubt” SB.
- **Vhasia/Viterra Complications:** Vhasian hedge-duties (wood rites) and Viterra tithe-scripts (grain flows) cross your ledgers. When either region is “Stressed,” add +1 DV to Green-Market exports that travel their roads unless you carry a *Forest Truce* or *Tithe Waiver*.
- **Valewood Fallout:** On a *Valewood Weather* signal, fae proofs spill downslope; counting etiquette cancels the first navigation SB each scene, but any iron shown gains a free “Fae Complaint” SB (even among humans). Aelaerem hospitality rites mitigate this: presenting guest-loaf removes one such complaint per hall.

Trade Goods & Consequences

- **Quartz & Proof-Stone:** Donate clear quartz to a shrine to bank a *Seen Promise*—once, treat a murky contract as if properly witnessed. Peddle clouded quartz as “ritual grade” and spawn a roaming *Counterfeit Proof* inquiry clock.
- **Copper Etiquette Kits:** Issuing copper over iron in mixed courts grants +1 assist die on petitions; flooding markets with cheap copper pins offends foresters—add a “Copper Resentment” tag that raises DV in wood jurisdictions until you make amends.
- **Name-Script & Memory Wraps:** Legal export of name-script lowers espionage DV by 1 for allies who carry it. Smuggling wraps risks a *Name-Tax*—first customs scene converts 1 SB into a compelled disclosure.
- **Tide Rights & Barge Seals:** Funding barge-seals creates a *Waiting Cave*—once per arc the cave “waits” an extra beat for your crew. Ignoring seal-maintenance flips it: first Dolmis crossing suffers “Wrong Hour” SB.

Patron Networks (Patterns & Thresholds)

- **Sacred Geometry:** Chalk a golden-mean spiral at a ford to reroll one failed prediction/trajectory check this leg; doing so in view of fae courts adds a 2-segment *Proof Envied* clock.
- **The Sealed Gate:** Hawthorn-gilded door-nails act as single-use stay writs: negate one forced entry or pursuit at a hedge-gate.

- **Lunara:** Counting under moonlight lets you ask one terse yes/no about a hidden path; on a Miss, secrets spread—mark Exposure +1 in the nearest Green Market.
- **The Traveler:** Antler-posts double as wayshrines; leave a copper and recite a sequence to finish one travel clock tick for free on forest legs.

Field Procedures (Use At the Table)

- **Two-Ledger Talk:** When parley stalls, the GM asks: “What was said? What was meant?” If players state both, cancel the first social SB this scene; if they refuse, the next bargain demands collateral (memory/name).
- **Count or Be Counted:** At any fae-touched crossing, a player who audibly counts in a fitting sequence shifts *Position* one step safer for that crossing. Boasting or mocking numbers adds a free “Geas Catches” SB.
- **Copper Courtesy Check:** Producing copper/brass tools in a ritual space removes the first *Fae Offense* tag this scene; drawing iron instead escalates the next Complication by +1 Cap.

Diplomatic Favor & Reputation Echoes

- **Hazel Favors (minor resource):** Earned by returning way-cords, restoring antler posts, or paying tide-dues. Spend to downgrade a *Glamour* or *Geas* complication once per leg.
- **Alignment Reputation:**
 - *Thorn-Courteous:* Doors of the hawthorn courts open a step easier; human clerks distrust your clauses (first city office DV +1).
 - *Market-Square:* Brokers vouch your weights; rival stalls circulate riddled slander—add a trailing *Folded Rumor* clock.
 - *Forester-Trusted:* Paths shorten for you once per journey; port inspectors assume concealed copper—first harbor search gains a free “Alarm Raised” SB unless declared up front.

Boss Archetypes in Aelinnel

Court & Courtesy (Fae Sovereigns)

- **Lady of Thorns (Etiquette Engine):** Punishes breaches with precise harms, rewards perfect courtesy with literal boons. *Win by satisfying three courtesies in sequence (no iron, two-ledger speech, return the waymark).*
- **Green Knight (Trial by Pattern):** Duel of paths and proofs, not blades. *Win by presenting a higher-count route (Fibonacci, even-steps) or yielding a deserved apology at the right number.*

Threshold & Hunt (Environment that Judges)

- **Moonlit Ride (Wild Hunt):** Three phases—*Sounding* (horns), *Coursing* (paths shorten for the bold), *Closing the Ring*. *Win by naming safe-clemency, joining the chase without taking a prey, or blowing the right counter-call (2–3–5).*
- **Green Gate (Living Crossing):** Demands exact change in truths. *Win by paying a memory that fits the posted proof; forcing passage triggers “Roads Rewired.”*

Numbers & Glamour (Logical Anomalies)

- **Glamour Fog (Layered Illusion):** Each layer dispelled by a correct count, courtesy, or copper rite. *Win by completing the Three Proofs: count aloud, return a borrowed path token, trade a said/meant receipt.*
- **Lost Day (Time Miscount):** The sun misnumbers hours. *Win by reconciling two ledgers (what happened / what should have), then ringing a prime-number chime.*

Market & Oath (Contract Tricksters)

- **Green-Market Broker (Truth Arbitrage):** Buys your meanings, sells your words. *Win by catching them in a one-ledger statement or producing an Oath-Bead that chills (misunderstood clause).*
- **Oath-Carver Gone Wrong (Quartz Tyrant):** Binds towns with over-precise promises. *Win by carving a Release Unless into communal quartz at cost of a public truth.*

Stone & Memory (Ancestral Hazards)

- **Stone-Wight Chorus (Echo Jurors):** Resent footsteps, adore proofs. *Win by tapping the dolmen scale that matches the grievance and returning a taken token to the barrow.*

Boss Mechanics (Use 2–3 levers)

- **Courtesy Track [4]:** Each breach (iron bared, skipping greetings, single-ledger lie) ticks it. On fill, boss gains *Polite Punishment*: escalate DV +1 and impose a Geas.
- **Counting Proofs (three steps):** Name a pattern, perform it, return a waymark. Completing all three lowers boss tier for one exchange or ends a phase.
- **Said/Meant Ledgers:** Any bargain scene runs two mini-clocks; if *Said* fills first, glamour favors the boss; if *Meant* fills first, PCs gain a *Visible Oath* token.
- **Iron Offense Meter [0–3]:** Showing iron, striking hawthorn, or salting impolitely raises it. At 3, fae gain a free “Thorn Blight” SB; reduce by copper rites or gifts.
- **Hunt Phases:** *Sounding* (fear checks; pass to gain +1 die to pace), *Coursing* (paths shorten for counted strides), *Closing* (only truth-payment or clemency halts the circle).

- **Lair Actions (pick two):** *Fold the Conversation* (re-target a statement); *Shift the Count* (odd ↔ even penalties); *Petal Cut* (apply 1 Harm unless copper shown); *Wrong Tide* (swap entry/exit costs at a gate).

4.14 Black Banners — “Condotta & Crowns”

Banner-Captain (Elite): “A contract is only as good as the next payday, and a grudge is only as sharp as the sword backing it. In this game, we sell steel by the season and vendettas by the year.”

Veteran Sergeant (Commoner): “I’ve seen three captains rise and fall in the time it takes to grow a beard, but the mud stays the same and the pay comes when it pleases. Best keep your own counsel and your blade sharp. The camp sings? You live. They stop singing? Even the best charter bleeds.”

Condotta & Crowns

Ecktorian treasuries bankroll a perpetual border-war they claim to be *containing*. In truth, the gold keeps the fire burning. The Black Banners are mercenary leagues—ex-Utaran legionaries, second-sons, debt-dodgers, and exiles—who sell steel to the highest bidder, today’s ally becoming tomorrow’s quarry. Between them move the Ykrul steppe-clans (swift, pragmatic, oath-canny) and the Vilikari hill tribes (crafty, patient, and proud). Ecktorian ministers call it “pressure management.” The companies call it a season.

What you notice first: The smell of wet wool and old blood. The way every tent has a ledger pinned to its flap. The silence when the paychest is opened—and the murmur when it’s light.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never break a Bell Dawn. Three bells at sunrise means bury the dead, trade prisoners, fix the wells, no ambushes. Violating it is how legends end badly—and how captains end hanging.

Regional Mood: The Theater of Banners

Here, war is a marketplace. The Black Banners are not a single army but a squabbling league of freelance violence, bound by camp law, pay customs, and the shared knowledge that tomorrow’s enemy might be today’s employer. The real battles are fought in counting-tents over clauses and riders; the clash outside is just the audit. Loyalty is a coin that fluctuates with the market, and a captain’s true skill lies in reading the political winds that blow across contested borders. Between the rigid honor codes of Ecktorian nobility and the fluid pragmatism of steppe clans and hill tribes, mercenaries navigate a dangerous middle ground where survival depends on knowing when to keep an oath and when to break one—always at dawn, with a witness, and with surety paid.

Starting Location: A war-camp crossroads where two banners snap in the same wind, their sigils bleeding into one another. A Condotta broker with ink-stained fingers lays two contracts on a barrel—one from Ecktoria, one from Ykrul. “Pick a war. Pick a grave. The bell tolls at noon.”

(Camps/Battlefields/Fortresses/War-roads) Burned village turned field-hospital; flies, tinctures, and fever-prayers. Frozen ford with last month’s dead held under glass; standards trapped in the ice.

Spades — Places

2. **Burned Village** — Field-hospital; flies, tinctures, fever-prayers. *The flies are fat. They’ve eaten well this season.*
 3. **Frozen Ford** — Last month’s dead held under glass; standards trapped in the ice. *The ice is clear—clear enough to read the terror on their faces.*
 4. **Latrine Row** — At dusk; mud, shame, whispered mutiny, a sergeant who hears too well. *The sergeant’s ears are scarred. He listened to a mutiny once and survived.*
 5. **Crater Pasture** — From an alchemical barrage; in spring, glass flowers sprout like guilt. *The flowers cut. They remember the hands that sowed them.*
 6. **Supply Road** — Twelve broken wagons; oxen nose the wreckage for salt. *The salt is from a burned caravan. The oxen are from the same village.*
 7. **Half-Raised Siege Tower** — In an abandoned camp; every rung creaks with grudges. *The tower was paid for twice. It still leans toward the richer patron.*
 8. **Salt-Cured Cache** — Behind the surgeon’s tent; the wrong kind of maggots move. *The maggots have a pattern. It spells a name—yours, or the surgeon’s.*
 9. **Command Tent** — Maps show borders that diplomacy has already erased. *The maps were drawn by a clerk who died last winter. He was still updating them.*
 10. **Watch-Tower** — Stacked from skulls and slate; the crows know the countersign. *The crows are paid in eyes. They are very well paid.*
- J **Ancient March-Keep** — Held by a skeleton garrison of veterans; they remember when the banners were gold. *The veterans are dead. They just haven’t noticed yet.*
- Q **The Bone Fields** — Where Ykrul elders parley among cairns and reckon oaths with the dead. *The dead vote. Their votes are always for war.*
- K **Marcher’s Fortress** — Three walls, two sieges’ scars, one gate that opens inward only. *The gate opens inward so the dead can leave. The living are not invited.*
- A **The Singing Wastes** — Fallen weapons hum with the voices of their last wielders on a wind that tastes of iron. *The hum is a petition. The dead want their names back.*

(Captains/Cadets/Clans/Tribes) Young cadet with a father’s sword and a mother’s debt; veteran sergeant who counts scars like coins—and spends them on whiskey and mercy.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Young Cadet** — Father’s sword, mother’s debt, and a hunger to prove himself. *The sword is old. The debt is older. Both weigh the same.*

3. **Veteran Sergeant** — Counts scars like coins—spends them on whiskey and mercy. *His left ear is gone. He says a mutineer took it. He says the mutineer apologized.*
4. **Ecktorian Banner-Captain** — Griffon standard, a ledger of noble grudges, and a smile like a winter. *The griffon’s eyes are rubies. They were looted from a temple. The god still watches.*
5. **Condotta Broker** — Changes colors when the wind turns, but always lands on his feet. *His feet are calloused from landing. He has never broken an ankle.*
6. **Ykrul Clan Emissary** — Speaks in riddled proverbs and pays in copper and promises. *The copper is from a cursed mine. The promises are from a cursed tongue.*
7. **Vilikari War-Chief’s Second Son** — Honor burns brighter than his father’s patience. *His father’s patience is measured in seasons. This is the last season.*
8. **Surgeon of the Red Ledger** — Treats friend and foe alike; her ledger balances only in blood. *Her ledger is bound in human skin. The skin was a gift from a patient who lived.*
9. **Quartermaster** — Knows where every coin went and every man will fall. *His bribe book is thicker than his roster. He calls it “risk assessment.”*
10. **Tribune’s Aide-de-Camp** — Sealed orders that contradict the general’s intent. *The general’s intent was to retire. The seals say otherwise.*
- J **The Black Colonel** — Legendary commander not seen in the line for months, yet his banner still rides. *The banner rides alone. The horse is riderless. The men follow anyway.*
- Q **Ykrul Clan-Mother** — Weaves war-braids from the hair of oath-breakers. *Each braid has a name. The names are still attached.*
- K **Vilikari High Chief** — Trades mercenaries like game pieces and never tips the board. *The board is an old treaty map. The pieces are real.*
- A **The Bannerless One** — Commands loyalty without rank or flag; men follow because they want to. *They follow into the Singing Wastes. They follow into the ice. They follow because she asked.*

(Betrayals/Weather/Politics/War) Payday delayed; supplies die before coin arrives. False orders: your target is now your ally—on paper. Blizzard pins two rival companies in the same cloister; vows and knives both come out.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Payday Delayed** — Supplies die before coin arrives. *The coin was eaten by interest. The interest has teeth.*
3. **False Orders** — Your target is now your ally—on paper. *The paper is from a dead notary. The signature is warm.*

4. **Blizzard Pins** — Two rival companies, one cloister; vows and knives both come out. *The cloister’s abbot is counting. He will sell the winner’s story.*
5. **Ykrul Counter-Offer** — Better terms than Ecktoria; your contract becomes a liability. *The terms are written in salt. They will dissolve in rain—or blood.*
6. **Condotta Flip** — Unit switches colors mid-battle; your “relief” hits your flank. *The new colors are the same as the old colors. The captain just wanted a raise.*
7. **Camp-Fever** — Blooms in the surgeon’s tent; the counting-house for the dead. *The fever has a face. It is the face of a soldier you left behind.*
8. **Vilikari Raid** — Cuts your supply road; winter moves the schedule. *The raiders took the salt and left a recipe. The recipe calls for tears.*
9. **Honor Code Collision** — Ecktorian ideals vs. mercenary pragmatism; the camp splits by doctrine. *The doctrine is written on a napkin. The napkin is from a feast that ended badly.*
10. **Tribune Captured** — The aide must choose: the rescue or the war. *The war is a ledger. The rescue is a name. Names are heavier than ledgers.*
- J **Black Colonel’s Banner** — Appears on the wrong field; confusion is a weapon. *The banner is frayed. It has seen too many wrong fields.*
- Q **Blood-Feast** — Clan-Mother calls it; all contracts suspended until dawn’s judgment. *The judgment is a feast. The feast is a trial. The trial is a knife.*
- K **High Chief’s Game** — Plays companies against each other; “winner” takes obligations, not spoils. *The obligations are written in invisible ink. You will see them when it is too late.*
- A **The Singing Wastes Awaken** — Every fallen blade rises to seek its last hand. *The blades remember the grip. They do not remember mercy.*

(Contracts/Claims/Dispensations) Emergency requisition—strip a fallen company for what you need (and their ghosts for what they’re owed). Dual contract—serve two masters with goals that cannot both be met.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Emergency Requisition** — Strip a fallen company; their ghosts watch. *The ghosts will remember. They will collect.*
3. **Dual Contract** — Serve two masters whose goals cannot both be met. *The masters are both paying. The interest is your reputation.*
4. **Honor Dispensation** — Your acts are justified regardless of code (for now). *The dispensation is a bell. Ring it, and the tribunal looks away—once.*

5. **Condotta Rider’s Pass** — Cross any camp perimeter unchallenged. *The pass is a feather. The feather is from a messenger who arrived too late.*
6. **Ykrul Safe-Conduct Token** — Pass a named clan’s lands unmolested (until the moon changes). *The token is a horse’s tooth. The horse was a gift from a Khagan. The Khagan is dead.*
7. **Vilikari War-Mark** — Their scouts guide you through hostile hills—and remember the favor. *The favor will be called at dawn. The location will be a ridge. The odds will be even.*
8. **Surgeon’s Debt-Note** — Medical care when no coin remains; the interest is names. *The names are of people who owe the surgeon. You are now one of them.*
9. **Tribune’s Cipher Ring** — Decode orders that do not exist yet. *The ring is warm. The future is cold.*
10. **Banner-Captain’s Seal** — Commandeer resources from junior companies (and their resentment). *The seal is a skull. The jaw moves when you press it.*
- J **Field Promotion Warrant** — Assume command of a shattered unit, inherit its clocks. *The clocks are ticking. The unit is watching.*
- Q **Clan-Mother’s War-Braids** — Her chosen fight beside you this battle, then judge you after. *The judgment is a song. The song will be sung at your funeral.*
- K **High Chief’s Trading Charter** — Buy or sell *anything* in any camp, no questions asked aloud. *The questions are asked in silence. The answers are paid in silence.*
- A **The Bannerless Word** — Loyalty that outruns rank, law, and coin. *The word is a whisper. The whisper is a promise. The promise is a grave.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (contracts/claims/dispensations) that shift position rather than call for a roll.
- If any Ace appears, echo war and winter motifs—ice that keeps the dead, weapons that remember, loyalty that needs no banner.

The Fractured League: Banner Alignments

The Black Banners are not a single army but a squabbling market of violence. Three loose alignments shape the loyalties of any war-camp. Most companies shift between these poles depending on the season, the paychest, and the weather.

- **Condotta Brokers (The Paper Men)** – They own the contracts, not the swords. They flip companies like playing cards and measure victory in percentages. Most captains hate them, but everyone pays them. *Clocks: BROKER’S GRIP [4], DOUBLE CHARTER [6]*.
- **Company Loyalists (The Old Banners)** – Veterans who remember when a banner meant a blood-oath, not a season’s wage. They grumble, they desert, they are sometimes bought – but they fight like demons when the paychest is full. *Clocks: VETERAN WRATH [4], OATH REMEMBERS [6]*.
- **Free Companies (The Tide)** – Newly raised, culturally mixed, and chronically unpaid. They are as likely to mutiny as to charge, and their loyalty can be bought with a hot meal and a day’s rest. *Clocks: MUTINY WHISPER [4], PAYDAY FEVER [6]*.

Superimposed on these are the **Ykrul steppe-clans** (honour-bound, quick to take insult) and the **Vilikari hill tribes** (pragmatic, patient, and skilled at ambush). A wise captain learns to read all three.

Additional Features

- **Payday & Supply Clocks:** Track two pressures common to the Black Banners: **Payday** [4] and **Supply** [4]. When Payday fills, morale falters and the Keeper may peel away a squad or impose a desertion SB. When Supply fills, all risky maneuvers begin one step worse Position until the players secure fresh provisions or bargain a Diamond.
- **Allegiances in Flux:** At the start of a scene, roll 1d6 to see if loyalties shift:
 1. Condotta broker flips colors mid-parley.
 2. Ykrul emissary offers better terms; accept and mark Obligation, or refuse and tick Payday.
 3. Vilikari scouts reveal a shortcut; gain +1 Effect but risk SB from hostile terrain.
 4. Ecktorian clerk “corrects” your orders; obey for +1 Position, defy and gain a Diamond but earn a Black Mark.
 5. Rival captain spreads falsified orders; unless revealed, counters are harder this scene.
 6. The Bannerless One’s messengers arrive; accept their word to clear 1 Payday, but the Keeper gains 1 SB.
- **Honor vs. Pragmatism Dial:** Place a two-step dial between *Honor* and *Pragmatism*.
 - **Honor:** +1 Position in parley or oathbound actions; logistics costs rise faster.
 - **Pragmatism:** +1 Effect in ambushes or sabotage; parley begins one step worse Position.

Center the dial by a symbolic act—repaying arrears, returning prisoners, or honoring a broken writ.

Mercenary Realpolitik

In the world of the Black Banners, loyalty is a currency that fluctuates with the market. A man’s worth is measured not in noble blood or ancestral holdings, but in the sharpness of his blade and the reliability of his word. The condotta system creates a web of shifting allegiances where today’s enemy may become tomorrow’s employer, and a captain’s true skill lies not in strategy alone but in reading the political winds that blow across contested borders. Between the rigid honor codes of Ecktorian nobility and the fluid pragmatism of steppe clans and hill tribes, mercenaries navigate a dangerous middle ground where survival depends on knowing when to keep an oath and when to break one.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice in the burned village. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the quartermasters, trying to untie her cord from a condotta broker’s ledger.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Singing Wastes are a Class II Anchor site—the bound spirits of fallen soldiers. Saikou Ira would trade his silver mirror for a single harmonic.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the paychests. Take it, and your company’s arrears vanish—but the coin will taste of blood every time the camp sings.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** War-camp psions are called “Banner-Readers.” They taste the weight of a contract in the captain’s shadow. The Bannerless One employs three—and has never trusted a signature they didn’t witness.
- **The Ninth:** In any war-camp, the ninth tent pitched in a row will collapse before dawn. The wise pitch eight and leave a space.

Black Banner Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Paychest:** Crumble a crust into an empty chest. Ignore the first *Payday Delayed* penalty.
- **Knot the Colors:** Tie a single knot in a banner’s cord. Cancel *Condotta Flip* or take −1 die on your next morale check (your choice).
- **Name to the Wastes:** Whisper a dead captain’s name into the wind. Gain +1 Effect when rallying their former unit this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Bannerless One.

Boss Archetypes in the Black Banners

Contract & Command (Human Adversaries)

- **Banner-Captain (Fixer General)** — Wins by paperwork and parade-ground precision. *Break their chain-of-command clock [6] by flipping lieutenants, forging orders, or seizing the paychest.*

- **Condotta Broker (Color-Flipper)** — Turns loyalties like cards. *Expose a dual contract or force public arbitration under neutral bells to collapse their leverage track.*
- **Quartermaster-Provost (Logistics Tyrant)** — Starves you with ledgers. *Complete the Three Cuts: road, ration, rumor—any two stalls them; all three topple their supply engine.*

Tribe & Tactic (Field Sovereigns)

- **Ykrul Raid-Mother (Oath-Weaver)** — Fights with remounts and safe-hostages. *Honor horse-rites to gain truce windows; break one braid in parley to end a phase.*
- **Vilikari Hill-Fox (Ambush Architect)** — Owns ridgelines and feint paths. *Clear Three High Stones (overwatch, supply cache, signal cairn) to force even ground.*

Faith & Fear (Camp Powers)

- **Field Chaplain-Inquisitor (Morale Engine)** — Smelts guilt into zeal. *Win by sanctifying plague-ground or redeeming prisoners; each rite drops their Zeal track [0–3].*
- **Surgeon of the Red Ledger (Mercy’s Price)** — Keeps units marching past sense. *Expose graft or pay blood-debts; on three reconciled names the operating tent stands down.*

The Unquiet Field (Supernatural Front)

- **The Singing Wastes (Weapon-Host)** — The battlefield itself retaliates. *Complete the Silencing Acts: oil the choir (funeral honors), bury the standards, ring the wind-break bell—each lowers its Tier for one exchange.*
- **Black Colonel’s Banner (Legend in Motion)** — A rumor that commands. *Prove the lie or become the truth: either unmask the courier network (three ciphers cracked) or fly a counter-sigil to pull rank on the myth.*

Faction Entanglements

- **Condotta Brokers’ Syndicate:** Register your charter and bank a *Broker’s Favor* – spend to reduce one parley DV inside a war-camp. Skipping registration flags your unit with *Unauthorized Colors*: the first checkpoint scene gains a free “False Orders” SB.
- **Camp Quartermasters:** Accept ration-scale audits to cancel the first *Supply* tick this leg; refuse and mark a 4-segment *Short Rations* clock that worsens Position on marches.
- **Field Chaplains & Leech-Circles:** Donate time or tithe to clear 1 segment from *Camp-Fever*; if ignored, the Keeper may convert the first 1 SB of a scene into “Disease/Death.”

- **Steppe Envoys:** Honor horse-rites (salt, water, shade) to gain *Remount Rights* – once, treat a retreat as movement with +1 Effect. Break rites and add a *Soured Oath* tag that raises parley DV with riders until cleansed.
- **Hill Truce-Holders:** Enter a stones-circle under their witness to bank a *Blood-Truce* – spend to negate one ambush on hill roads. Violating the circle spawns a 4-segment *Guest Right Forfeit* clock.

Field Procedures (Use at the Table)

- **Colors & Countersigns:** Declaring correct countersigns cancels the first “False Orders” SB each night; wrong signs worsen Position on first contact.
- **Payline Drill:** If a scene depicts orderly pay, clear 1 *Payday*. If pay is “creative,” clear it but mark *Black Mark* – future officers begin one step colder in parley.
- **Scavenge Doctrine:** After battles, you may gain 1 temporary Gear tag or advance *Supply* by 1; on a 1–2 on 1d6, spawn “Honor vs. Pragmatism” conflict immediately.

4.15 Dungeon — “Living Infrastructure”

Elite (Dungeon’s Creator)

“I built more than walls and corridors – I crafted a living symphony of stone and shadow, where every passage breathes and every chamber remembers. The structure itself is the true inhabitant.”

Commoner (Scholar-Prisoner)

“The walls here got a memory like old parchment – they remember every scream, every spell, every drop of blood spilled on the stones. And sometimes, when the air’s just right, they whisper it back to you. The dungeon listens. The question is whether it learns.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Beneath the surface, ancient places breathe with mechanical lungs and dream electric dreams. Dungeons are not merely ruins but living systems—vascular networks of stone and shadow where every corridor hums with purpose and every chamber holds its own hungry logic. The walls remember every footfall, the air carries whispers of forgotten conversations, and the very architecture shifts like a sleeper turning in bed. Here, the boundary between structure and organism blurs, and those who would plunder its secrets must first learn to speak its language of echoes, scents, and subtle pressures.

What you notice first: The wet stone smell of a place that sweats. The distant grinding of gears that should have seized centuries ago. The way your footsteps echo back with an extra beat—like someone is following, or catching up.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never ignore a door that opens when you’re not looking. The dungeon is offering you a choice. Refuse, and the next door may not open at all.

The Living Hierarchy: Factions of the Deep

Dungeons are not empty. They host a fragile ecology of factions, each with its own relationship to the site’s “consciousness.” A site’s dominant faction determines its mood; a dungeon ruled by *Custodians* may be melancholic and negotiable, while one overrun by *Awakened Organs* is actively predatory.

- **Custodians (Forgotten Caretakers)** – The original stewards, now half-mad or ghostly. They maintain the dungeon’s rhythms (polishing thresholds, oiling traps) and may trade safe passage for a memory or a promise. *Clocks: CUSTODIAN PATIENCE [4], MAINTENANCE ROUNDS [6].*
- **Invaders (Plunderers & Refugees)** – Living interlopers: mercenary remnants, cult initiates, refugee families. They exploit the dungeon’s resources while trying to avoid its attention. Their presence raises *Dungeon Awareness (Heat)*. *Clocks: INVADER DESPERATION [4], RIVAL CLAIM [6].*
- **Awakened Organs (The Dungeon’s Will)** – Manifestations of the site’s internal systems: the *Heart Chamber*, the *Digestive Array*, the *Ledger Lich*. They act as immune

responses or as twisted echoes of the original purpose. *Clocks: ORGAN HUNGER [4], SYSTEM REBOOT [6].*

- **Wild Symbiotes (Echoes & Aberrations)** – Creatures that evolved within the living infrastructure: stone-wights, memory eels, gravity ticks. They are neither friendly nor hostile – they simply follow the dungeon’s new rules. *Clocks: SWARM TIDE [4], SYMBIOTIC ACCORD [6].*

Most expedition sites will feature two or three of these factions in uneasy balance. A dungeon with predatory *Awakened Organs* and desperate *Invaders* is a very different crawl than one haunted by melancholic *Custodians* and curious *Wild Symbiotes*.

Spades — Places

2. **Cracked Gallery** — Hairline faults veined with damp; grit ticks from the ceiling like a slow clock. *The ticking is a language. It is counting the number of intruders.*
 3. **Sunken Vestibule** — Waist-deep water glazed with oil rainbows; cold leeches the knees, something brushes past. *The water has a pulse. It is not yours.*
 4. **Vaulted Refectory** — Tables laid for a meal gone to dust; goblets taste faintly of iron when breathed upon. *The iron is blood—old, dried, and patient.*
 5. **Spiral Stairwell** — Steps cupped by centuries; one cough ricochets down into a throat not your own. *The throat is the dungeon’s. The cough is an answer.*
 6. **Collapsed Observatory** — Stars stare through ribs of broken dome; wind brings ash that smears like soot. *The stars are not real. The dungeon remembers the sky and shows it wrong.*
 7. **Armory Alcove** — Weapon shadows longer than the racks; a glass-front case fogs from the inside. *The fog has a shape. The shape is a hand.*
 8. **Chained Sanctuary** — Prayer-niches and iron hooks; stone bruised where something strained to leave. *The chains are warm. Something wore them recently.*
 9. **Mirror Hall** — Reflections lag by a heartbeat; one pane shows you older, another shows you missing. *The missing reflection is ahead of you. It will wait.*
 10. **Garden of Stone** — Statues mid-breath; a chisel-mark still weeps dust as if freshly struck. *The dust is from the statues. They are not statues. They are frozen.*
- J **Throne of Echoes** — A single block worn satin-smooth; sit and your name returns in a stranger’s verdict. *The verdict is from a trial you never attended. The jury is the dungeon.*
- Q **Vault of Whispers** — Books exhale when opened; vowels crawl up the spine and into the ear. *The books are not books. They are memory. They eat yours to grow.*
- K **Chamber of Seasons** — Air flips from pollen-sweet to knife-cold; breath ghosts, sweat beads, leaves skitter. *The seasons are the dungeon’s moods. Today it is spring. Tomorrow, winter without end.*

- A **The Heart Chamber** — Mortar smells like blood, light like fever; floor hums to your pulse then sets its own. *The pulse is not your own after the third beat.*

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Forgotten Custodian** — Keys like teeth on a ring; polishes thresholds no one crosses. *He has forgotten why he polishes. The threshold remembers.*
 3. **Scholar-Prisoner** — Ink-stained nails, hollow cheeks; knows which lies the walls prefer. *The walls prefer lies that are almost true. She tells them often.*
 4. **Symbiotic Colony** — Many mouths, one hunger; bargains in warmth, hoards salt. *The mouths whisper in chorus. Their voices are the dungeon’s breath.*
 5. **Cursed Noble** — Velvet rotted to lace; voice drags like chain, eyes beg for ending. *The curse is the dungeon’s favor. He has worn it too long.*
 6. **Mercenary Remnant** — Dried mud, wet fear; map carved into forearm with a dinner knife. *The map is accurate—for now. The dungeon moves while he sleeps.*
 7. **Bound Guardian** — Filigree of wards across stone skin; obeys the letter, hears the spirit. *The spirit is the dungeon’s. The letter is a suggestion.*
 8. **Cult Initiate** — Pupil-widened zeal; speaks passwords like prayers, prayers like debts. *The debt is to a god that does not answer. The dungeon answers instead.*
 9. **Refugee Family** — Boot-scrapes under cots; clutch charms that grow warm when danger nears. *The charms are stones from the garden. The statues are their ancestors.*
 10. **Merchant of Curiosities** — Breath like cloves and rust; sells certainty bottled and slightly used. *The certainty is a lie. The bottle is genuine.*
- J **Ascended Vermin** — Crown of wire, court of nests; taxes crumbs, enforces with a thousand eyes. *The eyes are not all vermin. Some are the dungeon’s.*
- Q **Fallen Hero’s Shade** — Armor of frost, sword of grievance; wants one last right choice. *The right choice is the one that frees her. The dungeon disagrees.*
- K **Dungeon’s Creator** — Architect’s hands cracked with mortar; still moving rooms the way others move chess. *He does not remember the Heart Chamber. The Heart Chamber remembers him.*
- A **The Collective Consciousness** — Voices braided into one intention; your thoughts return carrying fingerprints. *The fingerprints are yours. The thoughts are the dungeon’s.*

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Shifting Walls** — Mortar pops like knuckles; corridors narrow behind you with polite insistence. *The insistence is the dungeon’s. It wants you to stay.*

3. **Hungering Dark** — Wicks gutter blue; shadows lip the flame and swallow the heat first. *The dark has weight. It leans.*
4. **Memory Fog** — Cool on the gums, sweet on the tongue; you “recall” a door that never was. *The door is real. The memory is the dungeon’s.*
5. **Gravity Wells** — Knees turn to iron; dropped coins smack floor like thrown knives. *The coins are the dungeon’s now. It will spend them later.*
6. **Temporal Echoes** — Footfalls not yours keep pace; a conversation repeats with one word wrong. *The wrong word is a clue. The clue is a trap.*
7. **Corrosive Atmosphere** — Leather slimes, metal freckles; breathe shallow or taste copper. *The copper is blood. The blood is the dungeon’s offering.*
8. **Phantom Locks** — Doors exist when watched sidelong; they prefer particular hands and hours. *The hands are yours. The hours are the dungeon’s.*
9. **Borrowed Time** — Hair whitens at the tips; hunger leaps ahead of the clock. *The time will be returned. The interest is your memory.*
10. **Infectious Transformation** — Fingertips grain to stone, pupils catch light like a cat’s; urges shift. *The urge is to stay. The garden needs new statues.*
- J **Reality Anchor Points** — Candles burn sideways, water beads uphill; spells itch in the teeth. *The itch is the dungeon laughing.*
- Q **The Dungeon’s Will** — Maps argue with themselves; paths rephrase your intentions. *The path is the dungeon’s intention. Your intention is a suggestion.*
- K **Cascading Failure** — A cracked lintel sighs and the far cistern answers; systems talk in groans. *The groans are a warning. The warning is too late.*
- A **The Price of Passage** — Each shortcut salts your tongue with loss; the house keeps its ledger. *The ledger is the dungeon’s. The loss is yours.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Wayfinder Compass** — Needle twitches toward safety like a frightened animal; steadies if you hum. *The humming must be in tune with the dungeon’s breath. The breath changes.*
3. **Key of Echoes** — Warms in the palm when a door remembers being opened. *The door’s memory is not yours. It remembers a different key.*
4. **Lantern of Clarity** — Light outlines hollows in the world; truths show up as clean edges. *The truths are sharp. They cut if you look too long.*
5. **Cloak of Passage** — Hem sips through stone or mist; leaves damp prints on the far side. *The prints are the dungeon’s. It will follow.*

6. **Tome of Convenient Knowledge** — Pages grow new margins; ink creeps to answer the question you’re afraid to ask. *The answer is a lie. The lie is useful.*
 7. **Ration of Sustenance** — Bread that tastes like last winter; settles the stomach, quiets the shakes. *Last winter was in the dungeon. The bread was grown in the garden.*
 8. **Focus Crystal** — Thrum matches your breath; thoughts align the way teeth fit. *The breath is the dungeon’s after the third inhale.*
 9. **Token of Safe Return** — Thread around a wrist; tugs once when it’s time to flee. *The tug is the dungeon’s mercy. It does not offer twice.*
 10. **Map that Grows** — Charcoal blooms corridors as you walk; tiny figures drift where things currently are. *The figures are the dungeon’s. They are not always accurate.*
- J **Shield of Temporary Immunity** — Hazards strike sparks and spend themselves like rain on slate. *The immunity is borrowed. The dungeon will ask for it back.*
- Q **Crown of Momentary Authority** — Creatures blink, recognize a crest they cannot name, and obey. *The crest is the dungeon’s. The obedience is a misunderstanding.*
- K **Forge of Quick Repair** — Heat like a heartbeat; fractured gear exhales and remembers its shape. *The memory is the dungeon’s. The gear will remember you, too.*
- A **The Dungeon’s Blessing** — A knack that lingers in the bones; doors like you now, as do certain hungers. *The hungers are the dungeon’s appetites. They like you very much.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (safeties/knowledge/immunities) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **living infrastructure**—walls shift, voices repeat your plans, light returns redder.

Additional Features

- **Living Infrastructure:** Fluids, heat, dust, and sound move like blood—follow the drafts, the drips, the echoes to find organs: cisterns, chimneys, nerve-halls.
- **Scent Ledger:** Track smells (ozone, wet lime, tallow, old wine); they foretell hazards and factions before you see them.

- **Echo Etiquette:** Some rooms reward whispers and punish shouts; others demand a spoken price to cross. Listen first.

Patronage & Power

The true dungeon is not a place but a process—a slow alchemy that transforms intruders into something the structure can understand or consume. Every chamber is a test, every corridor a negotiation, and every inhabitant a symptom of the site’s deeper hungers. The wise explorer learns to read the dungeon’s moods in the way light falls, the way echoes return, and the way the very air seems to lean toward certain passages. Here, knowledge is not power but currency, and the smart adventurer knows when to pay with memory, when to pay with blood, and when to simply walk away.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **dungeon dwellers or factions**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **creatures or echoes**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or spirits**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or resources**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **The dungeon’s will** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **shifting architecture**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **minor entity or faction member** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **dungeon entities or guardians** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **trap springs/route blocked/ally turns**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.

- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: The Dungeon’s Creator or Collective Consciousness** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **walls shift/floor collapses/air thickens**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Living Infrastructure (1–2 SB):** Corridors whisper your name, reflections blink slower, scent trails loop back.
- **Echo Etiquette (1–3 SB):** Shouts echo thrice, silence answers back, doors ask riddles.
- **Cascading Failure (1–2 SB):** One crack becomes many, water flows uphill, lights dim in sequence.

Dungeon — Living Infrastructure

Starting Location: A spiral stairwell deep beneath a forgotten citadel, pulsing with a heartbeat not entirely mechanical.

“In the Dungeon, walls breathe, corridors shift, and memory is the only map worth keeping.”

In... a spiral stairwell, the steps hum underfoot. A Forgotten Custodian keys a door that wasn’t there yesterday. “The Heart Chamber hungers,” they whisper. “Will you feed it—or be fed?”

Regional Motifs Maintenance spirits, adaptive stone, ritual vents, memory valves.

Whispers to Offer “Take the shortcut that erases you,” “Trade blood for passage,” “Leave a companion behind as toll.”

External Clocks Threat: *Heart Pressure Rises [6]*; Fracture: *Floorplan Loops [4]*; Anchor: *Safe Route Fails [4]*.

Complications Corridors swap; keys rust to teeth; the Custodian forgets who asked.

Anchors at Risk Camp cache; a mapping apprentice.

Escalation Beat The stairwell adds a step every circuit.

Relief Vent the Heart with a true name; feed it a secret belonging to all PCs (reduces Threat by one).

Plug-in Expedition Layer

- **Universal Clocks (drop into any site):**

- *Dungeon Awareness (Heat)* [10]: rises on loud actions, light spillage, blood, or haste. At 4/7/10, the Keeper may promote Clubs results one step.
- *Structure Stress* [6/8]: ticks on blasts, overloading mechanisms, or ignored warnings; when full, trigger *Cascading Failure*.
- *Expedition Supply*: three pooled tracks—*Light* [4], *Air* [4] (if sealed), *Load* [4] (fatigue/overburden). Each empty track worsens Position for relevant actions until refreshed.

- **Safe Route Tokens:** On a strong success mapping/scouting, issue a *Safe Route* token. Spend to bypass one known hazard in that segment or to negate a single “Position Lost” SB.

- **Retreat & Seal:** When withdrawing, a PC may *seal the way* (chalk, wedges, wards). Clear 1 Heat, but tick *Structure Stress* or spawn a *Phantom Lock* in that lane.

Interfaces & Entanglements (use what fits your campaign)

- **Surface Stakeholders:** *Scavenger Union, Shrinekeepers, Civic Factors*. Register finds to bank a *Finder’s Favor*—spend to reduce one sell-off DV; skipping registration adds a “Disputed Claim” tag to the haul.

- **Internal Politics:** *Custodians, Bound Guardians, Refugee Enclaves*. Parley with proper tokens (salt, names, warmth) to downgrade the next Clubs result in their turf.

- **Patron Hooks (optional):**

- **The Sealed Gate:** Chalk lines cancel one intrusion for a scene; breaking them adds 1 Heat.
- **Lunara:** Moon-silver reveals one hidden organ (cistern, nerve-hall); mark Exposure +1.
- **The Traveler:** Waymarks let you finish one travel tick after a room clear.
- **Varnek Karn:** Naming the dead here clears 1 *Awareness* but starts a *Ledger Attention* [4].
- **Maelstraeus:** Trade salvage tags at “fair rate” once/expedition; skewed trades create a *Karmic Debt* [6].

Keys, Locks, & Doors (drop-in schema)

- **Door Attitudes:** *Literal* (wants the right key), *Courteous* (opens to the right words), *Hungry* (takes a toll), *Shy* (hates crowds), *Proud* (demands ceremony).
- **Key Types:** *Mechanical* (wards/picks), *Mnemonic* (password, name), *Somatic* (gesture, breath), *Affective* (emotion offered), *Sacrificial* (blood, time, memory).
- **Rule of Two:** Each important barrier recognizes two different key types; learning either grants +1 Effect to breach or parley with it.

Salvage, Haul, & Conversion

- **Salvage Tags:** *Stable* (safe to carry), *Volatile* (ticks Stress on jostle), *Bound* (linked to site), *Loud* (adds Heat when moved), *Forbidden* (attracts factions).
- **Convert on Exit (choose one):** trade haul for a *Map that Grows* upgrade, a *Pass-Key Writ* (one automatic door compliance), or *Market Credit* (reduce next sell-off complication).

Table Prompts (d6 each, fast prep)

Echo Questions

1. What does the room want?
2. Who set this alarm?
3. What was repaired last?
4. Where does the draft go?
5. What memory sticks here?
6. What price opens the way?

Find the Organ

1. Cistern (fluid)
2. Bell-shaft (signal)
3. Heat lung (thermal)
4. Nerve-hall (control)
5. Waste sluice (decay)
6. Relay shrine (intent)

Procedures at the Door (one-minute read-aloud checklist)

1. **Sense:** Name two smells; ask which grew stronger.
2. **Listen:** Offer one echo; ask what word returns wrong.
3. **Light:** Describe color/behavior; ask who steadies it (hum, prayer, silence).
4. **Count:** Beats, drips, or breaths—players may claim *Counting Etiquette* to shift Position safer once.
5. **Declare Price or Key:** Players state attitude + key type; on a hit, grant +1 Effect or a *Safe Route* token.

Plug-in SB Conversions (use with any dungeon)

- First 1 SB in a scene may become *Heat +1* instead of a narrative wrinkle (signal without immediate harm).
- Any 2 SB can instead tick *Structure Stress* and foreshadow *Cascading Failure* rather than spawn foes.
- On 3+ SB, offer a bargain: pay with *memory/gear/time* to halve the consequence and add *Price of Passage* [3].

Bosses & Lairs (Classic Crawl Feel, Fate’s Edge Framework)

Using Bosses Each boss runs on a **Phase Clock** and 2–3 **Lair Actions**. Tie them to the site’s *Dungeon Awareness (Heat)* and *Structure Stress*; as either rises, promote boss position/effect. Boss defeats should yield a Diamond-tier boon keyed to the lair.

Oculus Warden (many-eyed sentry)

A floating nerve-knot studded with glass eyes; lenses irise like gills.

- **Phase Clock:** [8] *Calibration* → *Overwatch* → *Lethal Focus* → *Blind Panic*
- **Moves:** *Disintegrate Signage* (erase waymarks), *Anti-magic Glare* (downgrade 1 magical effect this exchange), *Scry Ping* (advance Awareness +1).
- **Lair Actions (Mirror Hall / Vault of Whispers):**
 1. *Prismatic Sweep:* Split the party’s positions (each PC steps one tier toward Controlled).
 2. *Echo False Order:* One PC hears an ally’s command that was never given; test or waste an action.
 3. *Lens Flare:* Next ranged attack against the Warden loses 1 Effect unless the light source is doused.
- **Counters:** Smoke, darkness, reflective shields, calling shots on specific lenses (name a lens: cancel one Move this round).
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Crown of Momentary Authority* or *Lantern of Clarity*.

Digestive Array (cube-that-crawls)

A transparent, room-sized solvent held in grid tension; carries tools it cannot digest.

- **Phase Clock:** [6] *Probe* → *Enmesh* → *Dissolve*
- **Moves:** *Corrode* (apply COMPROMISED to metal/wood), *Engulf* (split group; trapped PC marks Fatigue or gear loss), *Clean Bones* (remove tags from fallen).
- **Lair Actions (Sunken Vestibule / Chained Sanctuary):**
 1. *Flood Gate Twitch:* Water level rises a step; footing worsens.
 2. *Sluice Pulse:* Pushes all creatures one range band.

3. *Reagent Bloom*: Vapors add −1 die to breathy actions this round.

- **Counters:** Grates, cold cinders, base powders; lures with iron filings or salted meat (draw off for a scene).
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Forge of Quick Repair* salvage or *Ration of Sustenance* (3).

Ledger Lich (archivist revenant)

A curator bound by indices; hands of ink, breath of dust.

- **Phase Clock:** [8] *Citation* → *Injunction* → *Foreclosure* → *Redaction*
- **Moves:** *Name Forfeiture* (steal a declared tag until bell), *Writ of Seizure* (lock a Diamond or gear under spectral seal), *Errata* (retroactively worsen one PC’s prior roll Outcome).
- **Lair Actions (Vault of Whispers / Deep Archive):**
 1. *Quiet Hours*: Casting/rites generate +1 SB or fail softly.
 2. *Reference Only*: Movement through stacks costs an action unless proper tokens are presented.
 3. *Cross-reference Collapse*: Bookshelves reconfigure; split the party.
- **Counters:** True names carved in quartz, burning a citation (sacrifice an *index*—a map, a ledger, a vow) to cancel one Move.
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Key of Echoes*, *Tome of Convenient Knowledge*.

Protocol Titan (stone sentinel)

A walking paragraph of law in granite; joints clock with tiny bells.

- **Phase Clock:** [6] *Challenge* → *Adjudicate* → *Execute*
- **Moves:** *Ward Stomp* (shockwave; prone or position −), *Clause Capture* (binds a PC to a declared rule), *Countermeasure* (reflect mundane force).
- **Lair Actions (Measure Vault / Throne of Echoes):**
 1. *Bell of Standing*: Only those who declare an intent may act this round.
 2. *Weigh Deceit*: The largest lie in the scene takes Harm 1 (Stress).
 3. *Seal Turned*: A door the party used closes and locks under new terms.
- **Counters:** Present certified measures, exploit contradictions, or swear a binding minor oath (shift boss Position −).
- **Drop (Diamond):** *The Under-Seal Clause* (local), *Key-Writ*.

Mimetic Colony (door-that-eats)

An ecosystem of impostor hinges, handles, chests, and carpets.

- **Phase Clock:** [6] *Invitation* → *Adhesion* → *Ingestion*
- **Moves:** *Stickfast* (immobilize limb/gear), *Swallow Noise* (negate assists), *Split & Flank*.
- **Lair Actions (Armory / Garden of Stone):**
 1. *Everything's a Mouth:* First interacted object bites.
 2. *False Safe:* Creates a “short rest” that actually advances Heat +2.
 3. *Chew Through:* Destroys one rung/bridge segment.
- **Counters:** Iron spikes, chalk lines, bait boxes; fire/acid cause the colony to fragment (treat as minions).
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Cloak of Passage*, *Token of Safe Return*.

Sluice Dragon (steam & acid wurm)

A heat lung grown proud; scales are boiler plates, breath a flash-boil scream.

- **Phase Clock:** [10] *Banked Heat* → *Pressure Rise* → *Vent Fury* → *Rupture*
- **Moves:** *Scalding Cone*, *Vacuum Lurch* (pull PCs), *Steam Blind* (Position –).
- **Lair Actions (Heat Lungs / Cistern):**
 1. *Valve Spin:* Change terrain tags (Dry/Wet/Boiling).
 2. *Gauge Pop:* Structure Stress +1; cracks form.
 3. *Pressure Shadow:* The dragon gains +1 Effect for one exchange.
- **Counters:** Chill the room (dump cistern), bleed valves (two actions), or bait with metal ingots.
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Forge of Quick Repair*, *Shield of Temporary Immunity*.

Crawl Procedures (Quick, Crunchy Options)

- **Short Rest (10 minutes):** Clear Fatigue 1 *or* refresh one spent tool; advance *Dungeon Awareness* +1 and roll once on *Ambient Signs* (below).
- **Secure Camp (1 hour, defensible):** Clear Fatigue 2 and one *Condition* (not Harm); *Structure Stress* +1d2 from barricading/heat, *Awareness* +2 unless *Sealed*.
- **Search a Room (5 minutes):** On success, gain 1 *Safe Route* token *or* a *Map that Grows* tick; on miss, trigger a *Door Attitude* complication.
- **Light, Air, Load:** Track three pooled clocks [4] (see Plug-in Expedition Layer). Empty tracks worsen Position until restored.

Wandering Signs & Encounters (d12)

1. Whisper returns one word wrong; nearest door adopts a *Hungry* attitude.
2. Drip changes rhythm; nearby *Gravity Well* awakens.
3. Custodian chalk erased and redrawn *behind* you.
4. A stack exhales: *Memory Fog* for one exchange.
5. Pilfer-vermin court demands toll (crumbs, salt, *or* gossip).
6. Bound Guardian patrol, willing to debate terms (papers help).
7. Refugee child with a *Key of Echoes* that hates you.
8. Floor warms; *Heat Lung* cycling—steam hazard next room.
9. Echo sermon on “proper doors”; ignoring it adds Heat +1.
10. Sloshing in walls; *Digestive Array* scouts with a filament.
11. A mirror shows your gear two items lighter—choose which or mark Fatigue 1.
12. Stone hymn—sing along to cancel first SB this scene, or suffer *Hungering Dark* pulse.

Classic Traps, Living-Site Style (pick 1–2 tags)

- **Pressure Mosaic** (Artful, Loud): Floor pattern asks for a dance step; wrong beat drops spears from *ceiling*, not floor.
- **Breath Tax** (Subtle, Lingering): Room meters exhalations; excess vents sleeping gas; counting etiquette downgrades risk.
- **Magi-Siphon Grate** (Hungry, Magnetic): Drains charges from tools/wards; feeding it a *Focus Crystal* buys safe passage.
- **Echo Latch** (Riddle, Social): Door opens to a truth spoken softly; lies trigger *Phantom Locks*.

Treasure & Upgrade Hooks (d8 hoard seeds)

1. Cage of *tame echoes*—store a sentence for later; release as perfect mimicry.
2. *Map that Grows* (upgraded): shows *organs* (cistern/nerve-hall) when rubbed with tallow.
3. *Wayfinder Compass* attuned: hum a note to swap “nearest exit” with “nearest objective.”
4. *Key-ring of Attitudes*: once each—*Courteous*, *Hungry*, *Proud*.
5. Bottle of *stolen seasons*: pour to set room to *pollen-sweet* or *knife-cold* for one scene.

6. *Token of Safe Return* (party-wide) that tugs twice when the *Heart Pressure* hits threshold.
7. A ledger page signed by the *Dungeon’s Creator*—treat one barrier as if you are expected.
8. *Lantern of Clarity* mantle: once/session, reveals the *Price of Passage* without paying it.

Boss Build Template (one-minute prep)

1. **Name & Nature:** What organ of the dungeon is this boss the face of?
2. **Phase Clock:** 6/8/10 with 2–4 titled phases.
3. **Three Moves:** One space-control, one resource-tax, one identity/knowledge twist.
4. **Two Lair Actions:** Environmental toggles keyed to this lair.
5. **Counters:** A courtesy, a tool, a sacrifice. (Players should be able to *learn* these.)
6. **Drop:** A Diamond (from §4.15) or bespoke boon tied to the organ.

Dungeon Boss: The Heart Itself (set-piece)

A chamber of ribs and lintels; mortar smells like blood, light like fever.

- **Phase Clock:** [10] *Palpate* → *Synchronize* → *Pacemaker* → *Arrest*
- **Moves:** *Syncopate* (force actions to resolve off-beat; assist dice misfire), *Tachycardia* (Heat +2, Structure Stress +1), *Backflow* (reverse one clock tick on *Floorplan Loops*, but split the party).
- **Lair Actions:**
 1. *Valve Close:* Seal exits; require a “Somatic” or “Affective” key to reopen.
 2. *Adrenal Surge:* The Heart acts twice next round unless fed a secret *all PCs share*.
- **Counters:** Speak the dungeon’s *true purpose* (as inferred via organs), vent a heat lung, or sacrifice mapped ground (tear up a *Safe Route*).
- **Victory States:** *Stabilize* (site becomes safer; Awareness clears to 0), *Pacify* (gain *Dungeon’s Blessing*), or *Slay* (collapse risk; Structure Stress +2 across the level).

4.16 Ecktoria — “Marble & Fire”

Grand Magistrate (Elite): “The law here is written not in books but in marble and flame. Every edict carries the weight of centuries, and every judgment echoes in the very stones of the Forum.”

Ferrymaster (Commoner): “I’ve seen the city burn three times and rise again like a phoenix made of stone. The marble remembers, the bells tell the truth, and the fire judges all – especially those who think coin can buy clean hands.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Once the heart of the Utaran Empire, Ecktoria has worn its laurels into chains. Three centuries of sack, fire, and slow decline have not stripped its marble forums nor its gold-sealed coin-houses – but each day, more of its wealth slips into the hands of mercenaries and factions. The Black Banners march on its purse, avenging old Ykrul wounds by proxy. Processions still crown its stairways, yet ash lines every step. The city burns not only with memory, but with ambition still unquenched. Beyond the capital’s walls, the province is a patchwork of struggling towns, abandoned fortresses, and grainlands whose harvests are disputed by rival tax-collectors. The Everflame Orthodoxy preaches unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The statues watch. The fire judges.

What you notice first: The smell of old incense and fresh bread. The way crowds part for a procession—and close again for a knife. The marble steps, worn smooth by centuries of petitioners.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a toast in a coin-house. The ledgers are the true judges, and a declined cup is a declined credit. You will not borrow again.

Regional Mood: The Flame That Remembers

Here, the past does not fade—it is polished into monuments. Every statue, every obelisk, every triumphal arch is a legal precedent carved in stone. Ecktoria is not one city but three: the marble forums of the old patricians, the soot-stained alleys of the mercenary camps, and the basilicas where the Everflame’s priests balance piety against profit. The Grand Magistrate presides over a skeleton empire, but the real power moves in coin-houses, grain ledgers, and the whispered judgments of the Censor’s Hall. The Black Banners are not invaders; they are employees. The Ykrul are not enemies; they are creditors. And the Everflame is not a god; it is an auditor that never sleeps.

Starting Location: The Coin-House floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles burn beside melted icons. A factor with smoke-singed ledgers offers a purse. “The Lame King moves,” she says. “And the Basilica burns with him. Your credit is good—for now. Find out who lit the fire, or the Flame will audit your soul at dawn.”

At a Glance

- **Atmosphere:** Marble grandeur, ash-tipped ambition, and the slow rot of imperial forms.

- **Key Conflict:** Legitimacy versus wealth; old families, new mercenaries, and the Everflame’s judgment.
- **Notable Threats:** Bread riots, arena spills, ducal conflicts, inquisitorial visits, and the Red List.
- **Common Rewards:** Procession permits, coin-house credit, laurel deeds, and a Golden Edict carved in precedent.

The Three Ecktorias: Faction Spectrum

Ecktoria is not a single polity but a battlefield of three competing visions. Most citizens and factions fall somewhere between these poles, shifting allegiance as the grain price changes.

- **Old Blood (Patrician Traditionalists)** – The ancient senatorial families who remember when Ecktoria ruled the world. They worship precedent, hoard marble, and see mercenaries as necessary filth. Their power is in law, lineage, and the silent networks of the Censor’s Hall. *Clocks: PATRICIAN PATIENCE [4], BLOOD DEBT [6].*
- **Black Purse (Mercenary & Trade Leagues)** – The new power: condotta brokers, coin-house factors, and mercenary captains who have bought what birth could not give. They care about supply lines, not bloodlines. Their loyalty is to the next contract, and their god is the ledger. *Clocks: CONTRACT SPIRAL [4], PAYDAY FEVER [6].*
- **The Everflame (Church & Inquisition)** – The priests, inquisitors, and relic-keepers who claim that the Eternal Flame is the only true sovereign. They offer legitimacy to whoever pays the tithe—and withdraw it from whoever forgets. Their power is in pulpits, processions, and the fear of excommunication. *Clocks: HERESY INDEX [4], SANCTUARY VIOLATION [6].*

Superimposed on these are the **Ykrul creditors** (who hold Ecktoria’s debt like a leash) and the **Black Banners** (who hold its streets like a lease). A wise politician learns to balance all three—and keeps a boat ready on the Dolmis.

Spades — Places

2. **Petition Steps** — Milk-stone steps where dawn petitions are pinned. *The petitions are written in ink and hope. The steps answer in marble and silence.*
3. **Tally-Ford Ferryhouse** — Rope-drums thrum all day; the ferrymaster watches coin and banners. *The rope-drums have a pattern. It spells the names of those who paid late.*
4. **Arena Hypogeum** — Practice sand and whispered secrets beneath the games. *The sand is from the Tiber. It still remembers the blood of the last revolt.*
5. **Everflame Cloister** — Candle markets and side-chapels where flame speaks truth. *The flame has a voice. It is the voice of the last liar who tested it.*

6. **Shatterline Bazaar** — Between quake-toppled columns, merchants hawk broken dreams. *The columns were toppled by an earthquake that killed a senator. He still haunts the rubble.*
7. **Coin-House Floor** — Counting ledgers under glass; factors seal credit with three ribbons. *The ribbons are colored: white for “ask,” red for “now,” black for “never.”*
8. **Mile-Zero Obelisk** — Surveyors’ starting point; all roads measured from here. *The obelisk has a crack. The crack is a mile long—in the other direction.*
9. **Triumph Stairs** — Processional Way switchback; marble worn smooth by ambition. *The stairs have a name: “The Rise of the Forgotten.” No one remembers why.*
10. **Aqueduct Walk** — Narrow guardpath above the city’s arteries; perfect for ambush or escape. *The water below tastes of iron. It is the city’s memory of its own blood.*
- J **Ducal Loggia** — High above a packed square; a duchess watches and waits. *The duchess has not blinked in three hours. She is counting.*
- Q **Censor’s Hall** — Red-lacquered tablets record every name, every shame. *The tablets are redacted in invisible ink. The truth is underneath.*
- K **Grand Forum** — Statues tarped, echoes loud; where crowds become mobs. *The tarps were a gift from a dead emperor. The statues do not thank him.*
- A **Imperial Arena** — The Marble Bowl, gates chained – for now. *The chains are warm. Something inside is breathing.*

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Torchbearer Child** — Ash-smudged hands; knows every shortcut through the ruins. *She has never been lost. The ruins speak to her in dust.*
3. **Ferrymaster** — Knows which banners pay late; collects more than coin. *His ledger is a net. The names are the catch.*
4. **Coin-House Factor** — Seals credit with three ribbons; eyes twitch at defaults. *His eyes are the color of old silver. They see through your purse.*
5. **Lanista** — Owns fighters – and their secrets; sells victory in the sand. *His grin is a brand. The brand is on his fighters’ necks.*
6. **Decumanus-Master** — Surveyor who “moves” stones; rewrites the city’s shape. *His rod is a finger bone. The bone belonged to the last surveyor who argued.*
7. **Procession Marshal** — Permits and whistle; keeps order in ceremonial chaos. *His whistle is for the living. His bell is for the dead.*
8. **Grain-Prefect** — Allots loaves; knives in the margins of every ledger. *His ledger has a stain. The stain is wine—or blood.*

9. **Censor’s Clerk** — “Misfiles” careers; knows which names to forget. *His inkwell is a skull. The skull belonged to a name he forgot.*
10. **Veteran Standard-Bearer** — Sells honor as a retainer; medals heavier than sword. *His medals are from a war that never happened. The corpses are from one that did.*
- J **Gladiatrix** — Darling of the crowds; owes no one but the sand. *Her sword has no name. The sand has many.*
- Q **Duchess-Regent** — Behind a silk screen; speaks through cousins, rules through silence. *The screen has a hole. The hole is for a dagger—hers.*
- K **High Priest of Everflame** — Smiles like law; flame judges truth and debt. *His smile is a candle. It can warm—or burn.*
- A **Grand Magistrate** — Guardian of forms, breaker of them when needed. *His gavel is a sundial. It only strikes at noon.*

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Blocked Bridge** — A procession blocks the only crossing till sundown. *The procession is for a saint who died hungry. The saint is not forgiving.*
3. **Proscribed Sigil** — A sudden edict: your mark is now forbidden. *The edict was written in the dead of night. The ink is still wet—and warm.*
4. **Bread Riots** — Grain barges are late; hunger hisses at the city’s edges. *The hunger has a face. It is the face of a baker who ran out of flour.*
5. **Arena Spill** — A riot spills into streets; shutters slam, guards draw steel. *The riot started over a point. The point was a sword.*
6. **Ducal Conflict** — Rival dukes levy the same ward; your recruits vanish. *The recruits are not dead. They are hired. They are now your enemies.*
7. **Border Dispute** — A re-plat redraws boundaries; your deed becomes “disputed.” *The surveyor’s rod is bent. He calls it “context.”*
8. **Frozen Purse** — A coin-house calls in notes; your purse freezes at the worst moment. *The notes were called by a dead man. His signature is still warm.*
9. **Inquisitorial Visit** — A relic’s authenticity is questioned; penalties are swift and public. *The relic is a nail from a cross. It has been forged seven times. It still works.*
10. **Aftershock** — Masonry and timetables fall; scaffolds groan with new cracks. *The crack has a name. It whispers it to the wind.*
- J **Counterfeit Laurel** — Your win is void unless you find the forger. *The forger is a child. The child is a slave. The slave is a senator’s son.*

- Q **Church Purge** — “Spectacles” are banned; your venue is canceled by zealots. *The zealots are paid by a rival. The rival is in the front row.*
- K **Rerouted Triumph** — The crowd follows the favored path; your moment is stolen. *The favored path is lined with archers. The archers are not there for the ceremony.*
- A **Red List** — A secret ledger; your patron’s name appears overnight. *The list is written in a dead hand. The dead are still collecting.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Bread Chit** — Ward sustenance for a week; street patience guaranteed. *The chit is a clay token. Break it to eat—or to bribe.*
 3. **Procession Permit** — Move sacred flame through a crowded quarter; law walks with you. *The permit is a torch. Carry it, and the city will part—or burn.*
 4. **Arena Purse** — Settles debts and hires mouths; blood-money in coin. *The purse is a helmet. The helmet belonged to a champion who lost.*
 5. **Survey Writ** — Reset one boundary stone; redraw the city’s shape. *The writ is a stone. Move it, and the map changes—on paper.*
 6. **Ducal Safe-Conduct** — Four guards and a trumpet; noble favor walks ahead. *The guards are paid by the duke. The trumpet is paid by you.*
 7. **Coin-House Credit** — Silent and immediate; debt becomes opportunity. *The credit is a ribbon. Cut it to spend—or to owe.*
 8. **Magistrate’s Postponement** — Buy a tenday against any suit; law delayed, not denied. *The postponement is a letter. The letter is sealed with a tear.*
 9. **Laurel-Deed** — Crowd favor follows you into court; glory as a shield. *The deed is a leaf. It was plucked from a victor’s crown. The victor is dead.*
 10. **Grain Ledger** — Name who eats this month; hunger bends to your will. *The ledger is a stomach. Feed it, or it will feed on you.*
- J **Minor Title** — A style that opens doors that bolts resist; rank as a key. *The title is a word. The word is “Patrician.” The doors do not ask questions.*
- Q **Basilica Audience** — One private hour with the High Priest; the flame speaks truth. *The hour is a candle. When it burns out, so does your favor.*
- K **Censor’s Indulgence** — One banned thing becomes permitted (for you). *The indulgence is a silence. The silence is a scream.*
- A **Golden Edict** — An exception carved in marble; precedent travels like law. *The edict is a crack. The crack in the law is now an opening.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/favor/precedence) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **marble and fire** motifs – statues that watch, flames that judge, and law that remembers every name.

Additional Features

- **Imperial Ruins:** Every district bears half-collapsed arcades, serving as markets, courts, or shelters for mercenary companies.
- **Competing Factions:** Dukes, guilds, and priests stage processions that collide at bridges and squares, each claiming legitimacy.
- **Monuments as Weapons:** Statues, obelisks, and colonnades are not only symbols – they are barricades, rallying points, and high ground when the city riots.
- **Everflame Orthodoxy:** The basilicas preach unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The High Priest plays balance while cultivating his own following.
- **Black Banner Contracts:** Foreign mercenaries fill the gaps left by a shrinking citizen levy, their loyalty secured only by steady coin.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice in the Shatterline Bazaar. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the torchbearers, trying to untie her cord from a Censor’s red tablet.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Grand Forum’s statues are Class II Anchors—the bound spirits of forgotten emperors. Saikou Ira would leave a silver coin at every pedestal.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the coin-houses. Take it, and your credit is always good—but the coin will taste of ash every time the Everflame speaks.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Ecktorian psions are called “Flame-Readers.” They taste the truth in candle flickers. The High Priest employs three—and has never trusted a confession they didn’t witness.
- **The Ninth:** In any Ecktorian court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous. The wise stop at eight and settle.

Ecktoria Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Flame:** Crumble a crust into the Everflame. Ignore the first *Bread Riots* penalty.
- **Knot the Ribbon:** Tie a single knot in a coin-house credit ribbon. Cancel *Frozen Purse* or take –1 die on your next debt roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Marble:** Whisper a dead debtor’s name into a statue’s ear. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from their heirs this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Grand Magistrate.

Patronage & Power

Ecktoria’s decline is not collapse, but transformation. Wealth bleeds into patronage webs: a senator’s indulgence, a censor’s indulgence, a noble’s purse. The city’s great houses keep mercenary captains on retainer, while priests sell ritual processions as public theater and private favor.

For the GM: Patronage should function as both opportunity and trap. Any gift (a purse, permit, or charter) binds the receiver to service, but patrons can die, fall from favor, or suddenly proscribe what they once allowed. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, ribbons, laurel crowns) that can be stolen, forged, or voided.
- Let rival patrons issue conflicting “safe-conducts,” forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use processions, funerals, or trials as arenas for social contests, where patronage debts surface and shift allegiances.

Patronage in Ecktoria is not mere background – it is the engine of politics, coin, and survival.

Thematic SB Spend Table**Minor Complications (1 SB)**

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **city guards or rival factions**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **crowds or ceremonial processions**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **patrols or inquisitors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or ceremonial opportunity**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** City authorities or noble house becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **crowd movement or procession**.
- **Foe Appears:** A rival faction member or city official arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **guards, mercenaries, or zealots** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **procession turns violent/boundary dispute erupts/patron turns**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **High Priest, Grand Magistrate, or Duchess-Regent** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **procession erupts/arena gate opens/monument collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **flame speaks/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ecktoria (Marble & Fire):** Statues turn their heads, flames burn blue, ceremonial masks appear in windows.
- **Ecktoria (Procession):** Crowds chant your name, banners block your path, trumpets announce your arrival.
- **Ecktoria (Patronage):** Seals break in your hand, favors are revoked, noble houses compete for your allegiance.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Cross-Region Hooks (optional draws):**
 - *Aeler True Masons bid* to shore a failing aqueduct; accepting stabilizes *After-shock* but grants them soft leverage in the ward.
 - *Aelinnel Green-Market broker* offers “truth-credit” on court gossip; pay later in favors or names.
 - *Black Banner retainer* parade demands back pay on the Triumph Stairs; crowd sympathy tilts your next parley.
- **Faction Entanglements During Travel (use en route or on city entry):**
 - If the party holds any *Condotta* Diamonds, begin with *Bread Riots* at +1 segment (mercenary grain trains re-routed).
 - Entering with an *Underway Pass* (Aeler) grants +1 Position on *Aqueduct Walk* scenes but ticks *Ducal Conflict* once (guild jealousy).
 - Carrying *Green Market* tags downgrades one *Censor’s Hall* action but flags *Inquisitorial Visit* at the next temple.
- **Patron Touchpoints:**
 - **Maelstraeus (Cosmic Ledger):** Coin-houses keep shadow ledgers; once/session convert one social success into a *Coin-House Credit* Diamond but start a *Karmic Debt* [6].
 - **Mykkiel (The Writ):** Any *Procession Permit* can be notarized as an *Oath Irons* lite: breaking its terms applies –1 die to legal actions for a scene.
 - **Lunara (Witchlight):** *Everflame Cloister* niches hide “silver mirrors”; on use, ask one yes/no about civic intrigue; mark Exposure +1.
 - **The Traveler (Ways):** Map the *Triumph Stairs* as a living route: spend 1 Boon to treat one crowd scene as *overland progress* for clocks.
- **Trade Good Consequences (pick 1 when a haul sells):**
 - *Arena Steel* → street duels spike → start *Arena Spill* at 1.
 - *Relic Fragments* → basilica prestige swings → tick *Church Purge* or grant *Basilica Audience*.
 - *Survey Rights* → boundary re-plot → downgrade one *Border Dispute* or upgrade a rival’s.
- **Diplomatic Favor (minor currency):**
 - Earn by resolving a public scene without bloodshed (Forum, Procession, Coin-House).
 - Spend 1 to reduce DV of a permit/audience by 1, or to ignore *Blocked Bridge* for one crossing.
 - Holding 2+ makes you “interesting”: start a *Red List* [4] that advances on snubbed patrons.
- **Reputation Echoes (soft power):**

- *Crowd-Loved (Laurel-Deed)*: first time per session you face a mob, set Position one step safer.
- *Coin-House Trusted (Credit)*: ignore the first *Frozen Purse*; next time, it returns at +1 severity.
- *Clerically Vouched (Everflame)*: downgrade one *Inquisitorial Visit*; if abused, promote *Church Purge*.

Monuments as Mechanics (opulence with teeth)

- **Processional Geometry**: When acting on the *Triumph Stairs*, choose: +1 Effect or –1 Heat; on a miss, *Rerouted Triumph* advances.
- **Aqueduct Leverage**: Securing an aqueduct span grants a one-scene *high ground* tag in any linked ward; if collateral hits, tick *Aftershock*.
- **Forum Acoustics**: Rally speeches at the *Grand Forum* grant an extra assist die if at least 20 witnesses; failure spawns *Bread Riots* at +1.

Plug-in SB Conversions (Ecktoria flavor)

- Any 1 SB may become *Crowd Drift*: shift the scene’s terrain in favor of or against you (bridges clog, stairs clear).
- Any 2 SB may become *Seal Revoked*: void one paper (Permit/Chit/Indulgence); to avert, sacrifice *Diplomatic Favor*.
- On 3+ SB offer *Patron Bargain*: accept a visible mark (ribbon, laurel brand) to halve consequences; start a *Patron Debt* [6].

Hidden Orders & Ancient Conspiracies (d12 hooks)

1. **The Ash Senate** – a ledger of “extinguished” patrician lines still voting by proxy through funerary guilds.
2. **Surveyors of the Ninth Mile** – decumanus-masters who can *move* boundaries with ritual math; a lost rod sets precedent across the city.
3. **Lantern Tetrarchy** – four basilica beadles who decide which miracles are counted; the fifth lamp was broken in a purge.
4. **The Red Marble Compact** – coin-house founders who tithe 1 in 100 coins to a secret indemnity fund used to flip coups.
5. **Archivum Umbrae** – censor clerks maintaining a *shadow index* of names that must not stand trial (yet).
6. **Peregrine Brotherhood** – ferrymasters trading in sealed confessions; blackmail that floats.
7. **The Laurel of Dust** – a gladiators’ mutual that chooses which champions live long enough to hold office.

8. **Aqueduct Collegium Obscura** – engineers who keep a second set of sluice keys; droughts become elections.
9. **Order of the Broken Obelisk** – survey-cult that believes Mile-Zero is *wrong* and can re-found the city with one stone.
10. **The Funeral Republic** – undertakers running a parallel courier state through catacombs and wakes.
11. **The Ember Vault** – a sealed reliquary under the Arena; victors’ sweat was bottled for augury.
12. **Triumphal Maskers** – procession costumers who encode heretical theses into robe pleats and torch patterns.

Cults & Mystery Rites (d10)

1. **Children of the Phoenix** (*rebirth by fire*): ash-marks grant +1 die vs. fear in crowds; mark Fatigue if you hesitate near open flame.
2. **Verdant Laurel** (*blood to marble, sap to coin*): once/session turn 1 Harm into 1 Coin-House Credit; start a *Green Debt* [4].
3. **Mask of the Thirteenth** (*forbidden procession step*): walk through a riot unmolested; next parley with clergy begins one step worse.
4. **Brotherhood of the River Tongue** (*truth ferried at night*): ask the Dolmis one yes/no; a ferryman shows up later to collect a name.
5. **Candlemakers of Ever** (*flame remembers lies*): blue flame points to falsehood; the liar dreams of you for three nights (Exposure +1).
6. **Sable Standard** (*war saint cult*): your banner ignores morale checks once; start a *Blood-Tithe* [4] owed to the saint’s chapel.
7. **The Ninth Bell** (*hour that is not kept*): skip a queue or sentence; next edict you need arrives late (Delay SB free once).
8. **Guild of Red Accountants** (*sin as ledger*): convert 2 SB into a *Magistrate’s Postponement*; add *Karmic Debt* [6].
9. **The Marble Eaters** (*mortification sect*): bite stone, gain +1 Effect resisting crowd crush; take Harm 1 (Stress) if you boast.
10. **Torch of Saint Vessa** (*saint of necessary arson*): sanctify a fire to purge a tag (Plague/Corruption); City Heat +2.

Religious Schisms & Trials

The Everflame Divide (choose a live schism)

1. **Orthodox Basilica vs. Ember Reformers**: Is miracle *counted* by law or *kindled* by need?

2. **Laurel Theologians vs. Street Saints:** Does glory flow *down* from triumphs or *up* from bread-lines?
3. **Iconoclast Ward vs. Reliquary Keepers:** Is the flame purer without images?

Schism Mechanics (table-facing)

- **Heresy Index** [0–6]: ticks when players publicize a stance, defy clergy, or wield cult rites in view. At 3: inquisitorial audits become common; at 6: *Church Purge* (Q) auto-triggers once/session until lowered.
- **Sanctuary / Anathema Tags:** locations acquire tags during arc scenes. *Sanctuary*: first harm in scene becomes Fatigue; *Anathema*: first social miss spawns “Proscribed Sigil.”
- **Trial by Fire (mini-procedure, 3 beats):**
 1. *Assembly*: set the forum/stair as arena; state thesis in one sentence (players or NPCs).
 2. *Witness*: three proofs (relic, miracle, precedent). Each proof: test Social/Arcana/Resolve vs. crowd DV; on success, reduce Index by 1 or gain *Basilica Audience*.
 3. *Judgment*: roll Crowd Mood (1d6): 1–2 mobs, 3–4 silent acceptance, 5–6 laurel toss (gain *Laurel-Deed*). If Index ≥ 4 , –1 to the roll.

Ecktoria – Marble and Fire

Starting Location: The Coin-House floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles burn beside melted icons.

“In Ecktoria, even faith must balance its ledgers, and the gods audit in ash.”

In... the Coin-House floor, a factor with smoke-singed ledgers offers a purse. “The Lame King moves,” she says. “And the Basilica burns with him.”

Regional Motifs Coin-oaths, basilica relics, marble acoustics, augury smoke.

Whispers to Offer “Bid against the city,” “Pocket the relic shard,” “Name an innocent debtor.”

External Clocks Threat: *Procession of Ash* [6]; Community: *Credit Panic* [4]; Anchor: *Basilica Choir* [4].

Complications Smoke speaks truths; coins stick to skin; a reliquary runs hot.

Anchors at Risk A choir novice; a patron account.

Escalation Beat The Basilica tolls a note only one PC hears.

Relief Return the shard; pay a city-debt in blood or ; route the procession elsewhere.

Boss Seeds (Cults & Conspiracies)

- **The Ember Prefect** (schismatic inquisitor): *Phase* [8] Citation → Censure → Auto-da-fé → Purge. Lair: Everflame Cloister. Counters: relic provenance, crowd-favor, rival sermon.
- **The Surveyor-Primus** (geomantic usurper): *Phase* [6] Re-plat → Dispossess → Erase. Lair: Mile-Zero. Counters: Aeler measure-rods, witness line, broken rod.
- **Phoenix of the Arena** (miracle or hoax?): *Phase* [10] Hype → Immolation → “Rebirth” → Riot. Lair: Imperial Arena. Counters: doused ash, Mask of the Thirteenth, Everflame test.

Diamonds: Forbidden Leverage (add to §4.16)

14. **Shadow Index Leaf** – remove one name from the Red List for a week; add *Countercoup* +1.
15. **Ember Writ** – sanction one cult rite as “orthodox” for a scene.
16. **Surveyor’s Ninth Rod** – redraw one ward line unnoticed (until dawn).

Cross-Contamination (fast ties)

- **Aeler True Masons:** backing an iconoclast audit grants shoring crews; bell-codes now gate temple entries.
- **Aelinnel Thorn Courts:** hawthorn chaplains host “mirror sermons”; a basilica gains *Sanctuary* while a rival becomes *Anathema*.
- **Black Banners:** war-chaplains monetize indulgences; clearing *Payday* risks +1 *Heresy Index*.

4.17 Linn — “Skerries & Storm-Oaths”

High Jarl (Elite): “The sea keeps better counsel than any scribe, and the storm remembers every oath sworn upon its winds. To rule these shores is to dance between their moods and never miss a step.”

Net-Wife (Commoner): “The water speaks to those who know how to listen – the way it moves tells you if the fish are running, if the weather’s turning, or if something’s coming that wasn’t invited to the feast.”

Theme & Atmosphere

North of the Aberderrin Sea, where fjords split the coast and skerries break the tide, dwell the Linn. They are traders and raiders in equal breath, their longships crowding the whale-road and river mouths. They descend the Ylolka like an axe-blade and cut into southern shores, or slip through the Thin Strip where the Valewood dares not touch salt. Yet even these storm-oath people dread the Mistlands and the Valewood, whose fog and trees have no need of ships or harbors to claim their due.

What you notice first: The smell of tar and salt fish. The creak of oars from unseen boats. The way everyone—jarl to thrall—touches a knotted cord before speaking of the sea.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never name a drowned person aloud while underway. The sea collects names, and if it hears you speaking one it doesn’t recognize, it may reach up to correct the ledger.

Regional Mood: Skerry Stormcall

Power here is spoken, not written. A jarl’s authority rests on the weight of his oath-chest and the sharpness of his skald’s tongue. Longships are not vessels; they are promises carved in timber. Every voyage is a gamble against tide, reef, and the attention of things that sleep beneath the waves. The Linn do not fear death—they fear dying without a witness, swallowed by fog where no verse will remember their name.

Starting Location: A longship house lined with storm-charms and whale-bone runes, salt wind clawing at the doors. A Net-Wife binds a storm-token into a PC’s palm. “The Whale-Road sings,” she says. “But the Mistlands whistle back. Bring us three keel-lengths of ironwood from the Valewood edge, or the tide will take our boats in the spring.”

(Fjord/Skerry/Hall) Kelp-skerry gut: a narrow channel where oars scrape weed and rock; tide-shed of longship houses with tar smoke and gulls for sentries.

Spades — Places

2. **Kelp-Skerry Gut** — Narrow channel where oars scrape weed and rock. *Kelp strands like dead men’s hair; row silently or the reef listens.*

3. **Tide-Shed** — Longship houses; tar smoke and gulls for sentries. *Each shed holds a keel’s ghost; old crews sleep under the floor planks.*
4. **Wave-Gate Reef** — Just off a raiding beach; only locals know the cut. *One wrong turn and the wave breaks over you—twice.*
5. **Runestone Causey** — Across tidal flat; names half lost to barnacle. *Touch the stone with your left hand. If it’s warm, the ancestors approve.*
6. **Herring-Stairs** — Drying racks above cliff path; knives flicker like fish. *Workers sing a counting song—eight verses, never nine.*
7. **Winter Hall** — Turf walls, smoke-eye roof, benches crowded with shields. *The fire never goes out. Feed it a story each night or it goes hungry.*
8. **Mistlands Maze** — Reed-channels braid and vanish; navigation by instinct. *The reeds whisper names you’ve forgotten. Do not answer.*
9. **Boomed Harbor** — Iron rings in whale-bone posts; controlled access. *The chain was forged from a broken oath. It rattles when liars approach.*
10. **Aberderrin Headland** — Current rips past wreck timbers in the kelp. *On foggy nights, the drowned signal with lanterns. Never follow.*
- J **Dolmis Waystation** — Low isle with fresh water and old debts. *The well is lined with copper. A single dropped coin returns as a blessing.*
- Q **Thing-Holm** — Flat islet ringed with stones for speaking and swearing. *The stones have ears; oaths spoken here echo for three tides.*
- K **High Jarl’s Seat** — Above fjord, beacon tower glaring out to sea. *The beacon oil is mixed with whale fat. It burns green when a storm is close.*
- A **Whale-Road Horizon** — Open water where storms are born and names are made. *Here, the sky meets the sea. Here, the dead meet the living.*

(Jarl/Oar-Crew/Keeper) Net-wife who reads the sea like a ledger and the sky like a mood; steersman whose tiller-hand never shakes.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Net-Wife** — Reads sea like ledger, sky like mood; weather-witch in all but name. *She ties a knot for every storm she’s survived. Her belt has thirty.*
3. **Steersman** — Tiller-hand never shakes, even when keel does. *His left ear is scarred—he listened too long to a siren’s promise.*
4. **Shipwright** — Pitch on palms, schedule in teeth; knows every plank’s story. *He names each timber after a dead relative. The keel is his grandmother.*
5. **Oar-Master** — Sets beat that decides if home is today or never. *He drums on a hollowed skull. The rhythm is a prayer to the sea.*

6. **Mist-Pilot** — Ghosts boats through marsh lanes; reed-runner with secret paths. *He never blinks in fog. Some say he traded his blink for safe passage.*
7. **Skald** — Verses buy silence, start fights, end them; law in rhyme. *Her tongue is forked—she can praise and curse in the same breath.*
8. **Shield-Band** — Cousins fine with coin, better with cattle. *They sharpen their swords on runestones. The sparks tell fortunes.*
9. **Foster-Son** — Southern coast birth; speaks both laws and subtext. *He wears two brooches—one iron, one bone. Neither is his true allegiance.*
10. **Thing-Speaker** — Makes war into lawsuit, lawsuit into lunch. *He carries a water-clock. When it runs out, so does your patience.*
- J **Sea-Queen’s Hand** — Envoy with seal-bag and sword-belt; queen’s will made manifest. *He never draws his blade. The threat is enough.*
- Q **Sea-Queen** — Crown of hammered silver, eyes for weather and law. *She lost an eye to a storm—or to a spy. She won’t say which.*
- K **High Jarl** — First among raids, last to boast; paramount over strands. *His beard is braided with silver from every ship he’s taken.*
- A **Volva of Mist** — Oath-reader whose nod stills surf; seer of tides and truth. *She speaks once a year. The rest of the time, she listens to the fog.*

(Weather/Reef/Feud) Black squall drops from clear band; oars or prayers—pick one; fogfall makes friend and reef trade places.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Black Squall** — Drops from clear band; oars or prayers—pick one. *The wind screams a name. Listen carefully—it might be yours.*
3. **Fogfall** — Sound travels, sight does not; friend and reef trade places. *You hear oars. Then you don’t. Then they’re behind you.*
4. **Boom Lift** — Harbor chain rises; schedules drown in harbor mouth. *The chain’s links are inscribed with names of debtors. Each one rattles differently.*
5. **Levy Clash** — Viterra’s wardens arrive with polite spears. *They carry a writ stamped with the queen’s seal. The seal is still wet.*
6. **Keel-Rot Rumor** — Crews beach mid-voyage; trust in timber fails. *The rot smells sweet—too sweet. Someone poisoned the tar.*
7. **Feud Token** — Raid becomes wedding... or funeral; oath-debt called due. *A bronze ring arrives on an arrow. The meaning is clear.*
8. **Oath Matured** — Verse sworn last winter comes due today. *The skald clears her throat. The room goes cold.*

9. **Mistlands Miscount** — Channels “move,” cargo vanishes without witnesses. *The fog lifts to reveal a different shore. Your charts are now lies.*
10. **Aberderrin Race** — Contrary currents split flotilla; half late, half lost. *The water churns like a dying man. Something beneath is feeding.*
- J **Southron Fire-Pots** — Night-run turns to daylight; surprise ashore. *Pots shatter on the deck. The fire burns blue—alchemical.*
- Q **Thing Injunction** — No sailing till grievance heard (hours? days?). *The Thing-Speaker smiles. He has all the time in the world.*
- K **General Muster** — Horns on every headland; all bays become spears. *The war fleet assembles. Your ship is the smallest.*
- A **Ground-Sea** — Long, blind swell rolls under; steering lies. *The swell has a rhythm—two short, one long. A signal from below.*

(Right/Token/Escort) Harbor-green mark—dock without levy in named strand; oar-share claims two benches on fast longship.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Harbor-Mark** — Dock without levy in named strand (once). *The mark is a notch cut in a bone. Match it to the harbor post.*
3. **Oar-Share** — Claim two benches on a fast longship for a season. *The oars are carved with your name. Row well, or they’ll be recarved.*
4. **Pilot’s Token** — Mist-runner guides through reed-maze safely. *The token is a dried eel skin. Keep it dry.*
5. **Wharf-Right** — Dolmis waystation loading priority; first ashore. *The harbormaster frowns but steps aside. Your name is now on a list.*
6. **Salvage Claim** — Flotsam on reef stretch becomes “inventory.” *You must name each piece before touching it. The wrong word forfeits the claim.*
7. **Thing Ruling** — Verdict in your favor that travels with you. *The verdict is carved on a whale-rib. Carry it as a shield.*
8. **Raid-Truce** — Immunity in named bay for one market day. *A white banner on your mast. No one will attack—openly.*
9. **Foster-Bond** — Guest-kin by jarl’s house; hospitality guaranteed. *You share a cup with the jarl. The cup is silver. The promise is iron.*
10. **Herring Allotment** — Priority barrels when the run hits; silver in season. *The barrels are sealed with your mark. Break one to test quality.*
- J **Escort Writ** — Eight shields and wolf-banner from cape to cape. *The shields are painted with a wolf’s head. They die before you do.*

Q Queen’s Audience — Whisper exits as policy; sea-law bends. *The Queen’s hand writes your words on vellum. The ink is her blood.*

K High Jarl’s Pennon — Levies open booms and mouths when it flies. *The pennon is torn from a captured ship. Fly it proudly—or else.*

A Storm-Oath Clause — Temporary exception to any sea-law, sealed. *The clause is whispered, never written. The sea hears and obeys—once.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (rights/tokens/escorts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **sea-omens**—horns on wind, white horses on swell, verse unfinished until landfall.

Additional Features

- **Storm-Oaths:** Every raid or voyage sealed by oath to sea and storm. Break one, invite the sea’s judgment.
- **Skald’s Burden:** Verses are law, history, curse. A poor rhyme can damn a crew as surely as a reef.
- **Mist-Dread:** The bravest Linn will not enter the Direwood’s breath or the Valewood’s shade. Even the Sea-Queen pales at the Ninth Bell of the Mistlands.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Frost Ledger:** The Linn tell tales of draugr who rise from unpaid weregild. A High Jarl’s ghost now haunts the Thing-Holm, demanding a blood-price paid in stories.
- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice on a skerry. They take no payment—but they take names. A renegade Sister hides among the herring-stairs.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** The Sea-Queen’s court whispers of a cursed coin that grants fair winds—for a year, then collects. The coin is in the hands of a rival jarl.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Linn psions are called “Tide-Readers.” They taste salt on their tongues before a squall. The Admiralty of Kahfagia pays well for their services—and disposes of those who see too far.
- **The Ninth:** In any longhouse, the ninth horn blown at a feast summons the Hollow. The wise stop at eight.

Linn Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Wake:** Toss a crust over the gunwale before a voyage. Ignore the first *Black Squall* penalty.
- **Knot the Oar:** Tie a single knot in your oar’s leather grip. Cancel *Keel-Rot Rumor* or take –1 die on your next rowing check (your choice).
- **Name to the Deep:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into the tide. Gain +1 Effect against his kin for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Sea-Queen.

Patronage & Power

Among the Linn, power flows through oaths, kinship, and the spoken word. Jarls maintain authority through successful raids and wise judgments, while skalds wield influence through their ability to immortalize deeds in verse—or damn names through satire. The Sea-Queen holds sway over the coastlands, but her rule depends on the respect of the High Jarl and the Thing-speakers who interpret ancient laws.

For the GM: Power in Linn society is fluid and performance-based. Patronage often takes the form of foster-bonds, oar-shares, or raid-truces—each binding the recipient to service and reputation. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, banners, verses) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival jarls issue conflicting claims, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the Thing-holm and harbor gatherings as arenas for social contests, where oaths are sworn and broken.

In Linn society, your word is your bond, and your reputation is your greatest treasure.

Thematic SB Spend Table**Minor Complications (1 SB)**

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **coastal guards or rival crews**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **ships or harbor watch**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or mist-pilots**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Local **jarl** or **harbor master** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **weather shift** or **reef hazard**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival crew** or **levy force** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **ships, warriors, or skalds** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **storm hits/oath invoked/feud declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Sea-Queen, High Jarl, or Volva** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **storm rises/reef shifts/mist closes in**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Linn (Storm-Oaths):** Sudden calm, breaking waves speak names, verses come unbidden to lips.
- **Linn (Mistlands):** Channels shift without sound, voices call from reed-beds, compass spins.
- **Linn (Thing-Law):** Witnesses appear, oaths are demanded, skald begins composing your saga.

Western Reach Rumors (d6, fast hooks)

1. A harbor where bells toll under water; cargo *must* be named aloud.
2. A spice that stops bleeding—until moonrise.
3. A mirror-reef that reflects storms from a week ahead.
4. A pilotage guild that uses birds, not beacons.
5. A fleet that sails by *shadow* cast on fog.
6. A court that weighs debts in *breath*, not coin.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Sail + Wits):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Wake Surge*.
- **Cut the Lane (Pilot + Tactics):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a beacon is under your color, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Sail):** On a hit in *Black Squall*, you pick who drifts; on a miss, the Keeper does.

Boss Seeds (Sea & Signal)

- **The Net-Father (Nine Nets)** — *Phases*: Harbor Favours → Orchestrated Wrecks → Thing Coup. *Cracks*: cut a cord lineage; reveal swapped verdict; survive a staged squall.
- **The Blue Cantor (Brine-Gospel)** — *Phases*: Drownings Called Mercy → Procession at Reef → Tide-Baptism of a Jarl. *Cracks*: relic earplugs, survivor testimony, storm turning against them.

4.18 Mistlands — “Bells, Salt, and Breath”

Legate of Mists (Elite): “The bells here do more than mark time – they weave the very fabric of reality, keeping the mist at bay and the dead in their proper places. Each chime is a thread in the pattern that holds the world together.”

Salt-Monk (Commoner): “Salt don’t just preserve the fish – it holds back the things that shouldn’t walk. Every grain blessed is a prayer, and every prayer keeps the mist from remembering your name.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Mistlands lie north of the Aelerian mountains, where the Aberderrin Sea laps against reed-fens and drowned shores. It is a Protectorate of the Aeler, but their iron passes only hold the southern roads—the land itself belongs to fog and bells. Every levee hums with ward-notes, every ferry takes salt as tithe, and every shadow is measured against the Direwood’s endless breath. The people here live by the weight of salt, the echo of bells, and the hope that their names will not be spoken by the mists.

What you notice first: The constant, distant chime of bells—never quite in sync. The taste of salt on your lips even inland. The way everyone holds their breath when crossing a bridge.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never answer a voice that calls your name from the fog. The mist collects names, and once it has yours, the ferryman will always know where to find you.

Regional Mood: Bells and Breath

Here, breath is currency and silence a sin. Every exhalation is counted by the ward-bells, and every stolen inhalation feeds something that should not be. The Aeler Protectorate maintains order with ledgers and patrols, but the real law is older: salt lines drawn at dusk, iron nails hammered into threshold posts, and the unspoken knowledge that the ninth bell must never ring. The Mistlands do not forgive forgetfulness. The mist has a long memory, and it shares its grudges freely.

Starting Location: A Bell-Line levee veiled in fog, where bell-ropes sway though no wind stirs, and each ring tastes like a heartbeat. A Ferryman demands a name as toll. When the party hesitates, a Bell-Warden steps forward. “The Ninth Bell rings tonight. Will you answer—or flee?”

(Fen/Levee/Bell-line) Reed-fen causey with chalked ward-runes on every milestone; Bell-Line levee with iron posts and eight bells per span.

Spades — Places

2. **Reed-Fen Causey** — Chalked ward-runes on every milestone; safe path through the mist. *Step only on the chalked stones. The mud between has no bottom.*

3. **Bell-Line Levee** — Iron posts, eight bells per span; one bracket empty, one note forbidden. *The empty bracket is for the bell that never rings. The rope is still there.*
 4. **Ghost-Ferry Slip** — Rope crosses black water; fares paid in salt and whispered names. *The ferryman never blinks. Some say he traded his eyelids for the right to collect.*
 5. **Pall Watch-Tower** — Piles above mire; mirrors face west to the Direwood’s breath. *The mirrors are silvered on both sides. The wardens watch their own reflections as much as the trees.*
 6. **Mist-Chapel** — Stilted planks; votive lanterns gutter under damp rafters. *The icon has no face. Worshippers say it lost its features to the fog, one by one.*
 7. **Dead-Cut Canal** — Old imperial ditch; patrolled by eel boats and law. *The eels have eyes like men. Fishermen throw back any that blink.*
 8. **Drowned Copse** — Root-tangles clutch tide like old hands; bones in the bark. *The trees were planted on a mass grave. They grew twisted, hungry.*
 9. **Fogmill Ridge** — Wind vanes vanish into cloud; gears hiss like prayers to fog. *The miller grinds salt, not grain. His customers pay in breath, not coin.*
 10. **Salt-Pan Terraces** — Patched with peat; ward-salt dries under nets, watched by monks. *The monks chant without ceasing. If they stop, the salt spoils—and so does the warding.*
- J **Fort-Stair** — Stacked timber and stone; flags swallowed by mist, guards by routine. *The flags are changed daily. The ones that vanish are never spoken of again.*
- Q **Witchlight Bridge** — Over black runnel; ninth plank “counted” but unseen. *The missing plank is there—you just can’t see it. Step where it should be, or don’t step at all.*
- K **High-Mist Pass** — Through Aelerians; cairns ringed in iron nails, bells in the stones. *Each cairn holds a bell that rang once at the death of a warden. They ring again when mist takes another.*
- A **Weeping Gate** — Western palisade facing Direwood; bells wired to bones of trees. *The gate weeps sap that smells of iron and old grief. Wardens collect it in silver cups.*

(Warden/Ferryman/Aeler) Bell-warden whose ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts; oath-ferryman collecting fares in salt and names.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Reed-Cutter** — Peat-black hands, precise opinion on fog; knows every safe path. *She cuts reeds in a pattern—one snip, two snips, then a pause for the ninth.*

3. **Salt-Monk** — Blesses pans, keeps ward-measure honest; salt as both shield and vow. *His tongue is white with salt. He speaks only in blessings or silence.*
 4. **Bell-Warden** — Ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts at bay. *She refuses to write down the ninth note. It lives only in her memory—and that memory is fading.*
 5. **Oath-Ferryman** — Fares in salt and names; remembers both, collects both. *His left hand is always gloved. Underneath, the names are carved into his palm.*
 6. **Lantern Acolyte** — Trims wicks and arguments; light as law in the mist. *He carries a bell on his belt. It rings once for each lie he hears.*
 7. **Mist-Pilot** — Linn refugee; ghosts ships through reed-lace—if paid in breath. *She never speaks above a whisper. Her voice is currency, and she spends it carefully.*
 8. **Protectorate Clerk** — Aeler oilskin ledgers, narrow smile; law in triplicate. *His stamp is a bell. He presses it twice—once for the crown, once for the Hollow.*
 9. **Shroud-Diver** — Harvests tokens from drowned fields before dawn’s false light. *He wears a bell around his ankle. If it rings, he’s stayed too long.*
 10. **Direwood Refugee** — Cold breath, colder stories; knows what the trees whisper. *She carved out her own tongue. The trees still speak through her—in a voice not her own.*
- J **Fog-Knight** — Cavalry rides levee crowns by bellcode; mist as their steed. *Their horses have no shadows. Some say they traded them for fog-sight.*
- Q **Legate of Mists** — Aeler governor; equal parts mercy and decree, bells at their command. *She carries a bell that has never been rung. It will ring once, at the end of her reign.*
- K **Lord Warden** — Local strong hand sworn to Legate’s seal; law walks the fens. *He lost an eye to a wight. He wears a bell in the socket.*
- A **Mist-Seer** — Bargains breath for answers; candles shorten when she speaks. *She has no shadow. The mist took it as a down payment.*

(Undead/Weather/Law) Ground-mist lifts off fen and eats tracks by the yard; witch-lights try to count you; step wrong and bridge forgets you.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Ground-Mist** — Lifts from fen; eats tracks by the yard, names by the breath. *Your footfalls vanish behind you. The mist is following, not rising.*
3. **Witchlight Count** — Trying to count you; step wrong and bridge forgets your path. *The lights flicker in a pattern—two short, two long. They’re signaling someone.*

4. **Ward-Salt Short** — Pans go green; bells ring, nothing answers from the other side. *The salt is grey, not white. Someone cut it with grave dust.*
 5. **Wrong Bell** — Cracked note opens a door the Legate can't close; mist takes the gap. *The bell's clapper is a finger bone. The original owner wants it back.*
 6. **Linn Raid** — Slips reed-maze; hearths douse, horns travel on the fog. *The raiders wear bells on their belts—stolen from the last village.*
 7. **Direwood Moan** — At dusk; Weeping Gate ropes go taut by themselves. *The moan has words. You don't want to understand them.*
 8. **Valewood Wind** — Crosses Aberderrin; voices sweet, landmarks false. *The wind smells of honey and rot. Do not follow it.*
 9. **Bell-Line Failure** — Levee breaks silence; wraith steps across like it owns the road. *The wraith carries a lantern. The light is blue—the color of drowned breath.*
 10. **Marsh-Quake** — Sod heaves, dyke slumps; proofs and bodies sink together. *The ground exhales. Your name rises from it like smoke.*
- J **Protectorate Interdiction** — All ferries sealed “until review”; routes dry up. *The seals are stamped with a bell. The wax is mixed with bone ash.*
- Q **Rite-Purge** — Inspectors call local customs heresy; tempers at a boil. *The inspectors carry blank ledgers. They fill them with names of the accused.*
- K **General Alarm** — Pall horns sound; every lantern becomes law, every shadow suspect. *The horns are made from the tusks of a sea beast. The beast's ghost is angry.*
- A **Tide-Mist** — Rolls from Aberderrin; spirits ride the white and won't be named. *The spirits have no faces—only the faces of the drowned.*

(Pass/Seal/Token) Ward-salt allotment draws safe circle once; ferry token crosses named black runnel regardless of curfew.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Ward-Salt** — Pure measure draws safe circle once; mist parts, briefly. *The salt is warm. It knows it will be used.*
3. **Ferry Token** — Cross named black runnel regardless of curfew or tide. *The token is a knuckle bone. The ferryman accepts it without comment.*
4. **Bell-Key** — Unlock and set one bell on the Line to your note; change the song. *The key is a tuning fork. Strike it once to claim your note.*
5. **Lantern Writ** — Lawful travel at night along levee crown with escort. *The writ is written on dried bladder. It crinkles when you lie.*
6. **Exorcist's Seal** — Stamped clause downgrades “haunt” to “nuisance.” *The seal is a bell without a clapper. It's silent, like the wraiths it binds.*

7. **Codeleaf** — Today’s mirror and horn sequences; fog cannot hide what you know. *The leaf is soaked in brine. Read it before it dries.*
 8. **Protectorate Mark** — Priority rations and rope from Fort-Stair stores. *The mark is a brand. It smokes when you show it.*
 9. **Wraith-Indemnity** — Legal immunity for actions taken under apparition threat. *The indemnity is signed in salt water. It will dissolve if you misuse it.*
 10. **Bone-Field License** — Salvage rights at drowned hamlet (with witnesses). *The license is a map drawn on a shroud. Follow the stitch marks.*
- J **Refuge-Right** — Move a named household through Gate unchallenged; breath as passport. *The right is a bell-rope. Tie it to your belt. Nonna will ask.*
- Q **Legate’s Audience** — One whisper exits as policy; bells ring your decree. *The Legate’s ear is a silver bell. Speak into it once.*
- K **Warden’s Commission** — Raise levee guards; local doors open, purses too. *The commission is a whistle. Blow it, and the fens answer.*
- A **Pall Indulgence** — Temporary exception to ward law, spoken and sealed by bell. *The indulgence is a single bell-note, held in a jar. Break the jar to release it.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes/seals/tokens) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **breath and boundary**—bells answering across water, salt that won’t dry, voices returning late.

Additional Features

- **Breath-Toll:** Many claim the mist remembers every breath. Travelers hold breath crossing bridges, fearing the mist will count them wrong.
- **Salt as Promise:** A handful of salt is more than warding—it is a vow. Spill it on plank or stone to swear safety; break that vow, and invite the Direwood’s claim.
- **The Ninth Bell:** Legends say a ninth bell once rang on the Line. The note is not in any ringbook; no warden speaks of it. Some nights, though, it rings—and gates open where none should be.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice on a drained pan. They ask no payment—but they take names. A renegade Sister hides among the salt-monks, trying to unbind her Hollowed.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** Bell-Lines are Saikou Ira’s preferred containment for Class II Anchors. The Weeping Gate is a Class IV Poltergeist waiting to happen.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** The fog sometimes carries silver coins. Pick one up, and you can breathe underwater—but the mist will know your face forever.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Mistlands psions are called “Breath-Readers.” They taste your last exhalation and know how you will die. The Protectorate employs them as investigators—and disposes of those who see too clearly.
- **The Ninth:** In any Mistlands scene, the ninth person to speak in a room draws the mist’s attention. The wise hold their tongues until someone else breaks the count.

Mistlands Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Fog:** Toss a crust into the mist before crossing a bridge. Ignore the first *Ground-Mist* penalty.
- **Hold the Ninth Breath:** Cross a threshold while holding your breath. Cancel *Witchlight Count* or take −1 die on your next action (your choice).
- **Name to the Salt:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into a salt pan. Gain +1 Effect against undead for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Legate.

Patronage & Power

In the Mistlands, power flows through ritual, warding, and the careful balance between the living and the dead. The Aeler Protectorate maintains nominal control through military presence and legal frameworks, but true authority lies with those who understand the bells, the salt, and the breath of the land itself. Local wardens, salt-monks, and bell-keepers hold sway over daily life, while the Legate of the Mists mediates between imperial law and ancient custom.

For the GM: Patronage in the Mistlands revolves around protection—from mist, from spirits, from the encroaching forest. Rewards often take the form of tokens, seals, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater security. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (salt, bells, lanterns) that can be challenged, depleted, or voided.
- Let rival factions issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the levees, ferries, and watchtowers as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of the old ways determines success.

In the Mistlands, your safety is your standing, and your standing depends on who remembers your name.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or fog-knights**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **spirits or patrol boats**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or mist-spirits**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Protectorate forces or local warden** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **mist shift or bell failure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **wraith, raiding party, or inspector** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **fog-knights, spirits, or Aeler forces** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **bell-line fails/ward broken/mist claims name**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Legate, Lord Warden, or Mist-Seer** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **mist thickens/bells ring/forest breathes**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Mistlands (Bells & Breath):** Bells ring without cause, breath forms visible words, mirrors reflect wrong faces.
- **Mistlands (Salt & Warding):** Salt refuses to dry, ward-runes bleed color, protection tokens crack.
- **Mistlands (Direwood Threat):** Trees whisper your name, roots shift position, forest breath grows stronger.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Ninth Bell Ringer (Direwood herald)** — *Phases:* Lost Names → Broken Lines → Open Gate. *Cracks:* restore a ringbook; trade a breath; rehang a forbidden bell with copper nails.
- **Queen of Counting Lights (fae arbiter)** — *Phases:* Courteous Tithes → Geas-Market → Ledger of Leaves. *Cracks:* return stolen way-marks; speak said and meant; gild the iron.
- **Reed-Wolf Captain (Linn raider)** — *Phases:* Smoke Signals → Night Oars → Thing Verdict. *Cracks:* name a feud-token; win a skald-duel; force harbor-truce under bell and banner.

4.19 Silkstrand — “City of Bridges & Dyewater”

The Matron (Elite): “In this city, every bridge is a ledger and every current carries coin. The dye that stains our waters never washes out, just as the bargains struck in our shadows never quite fade from memory.”

Bobbin-Runner (Commoner): “I can cross this city faster than any grown-up, and I know which planks creak and which merchants lie. The bridges remember every step, and the canals carry more secrets than fish.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Silkstrand is a city strung across canals and arches, a place where every bridge is a ledger line and every current carries rumor. The dyes that stain its waters never wash out, and neither do the bargains struck in shadow. Merchants rise and fall with the Exchange, bravos carve reputations on the planks of Three-Queens Bridge, and curses cling to the very cloth that leaves the looms. The Matron rules from her palazzo stairs with velvet and iron, but the city itself belongs to silk and tide.

What you notice first: The clash of dye-stained water against ancient stone. The constant rumble of cart wheels on bridge planks. The way every handshake lingers a heartbeat too long—as if both parties are checking for threads.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never spit into a canal while naming a rival. The water remembers, and the curse you send may come back wrapped around your own throat.

Regional Mood: Bridges and Dyewater

Here, beauty is bought with blood and color, and both wash downstream. Silkstrand is not lawless—it is **layered**. Above the tide lies the world of guild charters, notarial seals, and the Matron’s velvet justice. Below the bridges, in the weeping arches and the midnight boat lanes, a quieter economy runs on whispers, borrowed keys, and the careful omission of names. The city’s bravos duel for reputation on Three-Queens Bridge while factors bribe clerks in the Archivolt. Every alliance is a knot that can be pulled loose. Every fortune is a thread that can be cut.

Starting Location: Three-Queens Bridge, dripping with dyewater, its stones painted in a thousand forgotten shades. A Guildmistress with dyed hands offers a dye-permit. “The Redwater boils,” she says. “And something in the canals remembers your scent. Bring me three bolts of untaxed crimson before the Exchange closes, or the Archivolt will find your name in a dead notary’s ledger.”

(Bridge/Canal/Mill) Mulberry garths and wormhouses outside North Gate with steam and sweet rot; Filature hall where whispers travel faster than steam.

Spades — Places

2. **Mulberry Garths** — Wormhouses outside North Gate; steam, sweet rot, desperate pickers. *The pickers’ hands are stained black. They say the color never fades,*

even after death.

3. **Filature Hall** — Cocoon-boil chambers; whispers travel faster than steam. *The steam carries voices from last season. Some say they’re warnings.*
 4. **Redwater Dyeworks** — Along stain-canal; brick stained forever with forgotten dyes. *The dye-runners wear lead masks. The ones who don’t die young—or wrong.*
 5. **Spindle Tower** — Creaking windlass-lifts and posted rates; heights and hazards. *The lift operator has a bell. He rings it once for every passenger who didn’t pay.*
 6. **Three-Queens Bridge** — Stacked market stalls; cells under arches, reputations made and broken. *The cells are for debtors. The walls are washed with canal water so no one forgets the smell.*
 7. **Salt Gate Quay** — Rope booms, chalk tallies, tired eyes; customs and coin. *The chalk is mixed with ground bone. A false tally writes itself in a dead hand.*
 8. **Silk Exchange** — Floor with chalk circles and clappers for opening bids. *The clappers are whale ribs. The bids echo, and sometimes the echo answers.*
 9. **Ropewalk Sheds** — Arrow-straight; bruisers hired by the yard, muscle for hire. *The rope-walkers never look back. They say a rope remembers who pulled it last.*
 10. **Old Arsenal** — Free Company’s barracks now; arms and ambitions stored. *The arsenal’s bell rings at odd hours. No one admits ringing it.*
- J **The Archivolt** — Arcaded street of notaries, seals, and quiet knives. *The notaries write in lemon juice. Heat reveals the truth—or a facsimile.*
- Q **Basilica of Azerin** — Weaver-saint; confraternity rooms hum with vows. *The saint’s icon has one eye. The other was traded for the secret of red dye.*
- K **Palazzo della Matrona** — Ruling seat with private river stairs; velvet and iron. *The Matrona’s barge is rowed by debtors who have repaid in years, not coin.*
- A **Flood-Stairs** — Bronze flood marks, bell rope ready when the Strand runs wild. *The flood marks go up to nine. The ninth step is underwater—always.*

(**Guild/Factor/Crown**) Bobbin-runner child with feet sure on parapets; foreign factor seeking warehouse and friend at customs.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Bobbin-Runner** — Child with sure feet on parapets, rumors in pocket. *She ties a knot in her apron string for every secret she carries. The apron is nearly solid knots.*
3. **Mulberry Steward** — Counting leaves; desperate for pickers, quick with coin. *His left hand is missing two fingers—lost to a cocoon-rot curse. He calls it a bargain.*
4. **Foreign Factor** — Seeking warehouse and friend at customs; connections for sale. *He carries three ledgers. One for the Matron, one for the Archivolt, one for himself.*

5. **Guildmistress** — Dyers’ hands stained, permits tighter than purse strings. *She can tell your guild by the stain on your cuff. She never forgets a color.*
6. **Bridge Bailiff** — Rents stalls, sells gossip by the breath; power in position. *He rings a small bell before each announcement. The tone tells you if it’s truth or theater.*
7. **Archivolt Notary** — “Fixes” missing recitals—for a donation; law as service. *His inkwell contains a single drop of his own blood. He renews it each spring.*
8. **Watch Captain** — Condotta to three lords; passwords change with the wind. *He wears a mask on feast days. No one has seen his face in seven years.*
9. **Spinner-Matron** — Wormhouses; temper like hot copper, secrets in the steam. *She names each cocoon after a dead rival. The silk is said to carry their complaints.*
10. **Exchange Caller** — A clap can still a thousand voices; auction master. *He lost his voice to a curse. Now he claps in a language only the bids understand.*
- J **Night-Boat Smuggler** — “Ravel,” silent oar, louder favors; shadows for coin. *His boat has no name. The canal would remember it, and memory is a kind of tax.*
- Q **The Matron** — Patient, velvet, iron; the city’s thread pulled through her hands. *She has never raised her voice. The city learned to fear her silences.*
- K **Lame King’s Envoy** — Velvet boots; claims certain alleys “protected.” *His cane is hollow. Inside is a letter of marque that expired a decade ago.*
- A **Saint of Warps** — If real: sees curses braided in cloth; holy unraveler. *Her eyes are milk-white. She sees not the cloth, but the threads of obligation within.*

(**Flood/Interdict/Riot**) Flood siren with gates lowering—move crates or kiss them goodbye; quarantine flag at Redwater sealing dyers’ row.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Flood Siren** — Gates lowering; move crates or kiss them goodbye to tide. *The gate-keeper’s palm is marked with a bell. Cross it with silver to hurry.*
3. **Quarantine Flag** — Redwater dyers’ row sealed; your cargo implicated. *The flag is dyed with lamp-black and something else—something that smells of graves.*
4. **Loom Strike** — Over “bad cocoons”; streets fill with idle frames. *The striking weavers wear red threads around their wrists. They will not speak first.*
5. **Seal Counterfeit** — Discovered at Archivolt; all contracts frozen. *The forged seal is warm. The real one is cold. Touch both to know which is which.*
6. **Bridge Riot** — A dropped stall blocks lanes; tempers boil faster than vats. *The riot started over a missed bell-ring. Or a stolen bolt. Or a look.*
7. **Condottieri Flip** — Colors change; watchwords shift, escorts vanish. *The captain’s new banner is stitched with thread from his old captain’s shroud.*

8. **Blackwood Panic** — Witch-posts hammered on quay doors overnight. *The posts are from the Direwood edge. They sweat sap that smells of old fear.*
9. **Fungus Blight** — Silk-fungus; wormhouses burn, refugees flood piazzas. *The fungus glows faintly in the dark. It spells names—sometimes yours.*
10. **Salt-Tax Doubled** — At Salt Gate; boats stack three deep, bribes flow. *The tax collector wears a mask. Beneath it, his face is a salt-caked skull.*
- J **Duel Challenge** — Booked on Three-Queens Bridge; you’re named as seconds. *The challenge is written on silk. Burn it to refuse—and lose face forever.*
- Q **Exchange Corner** — Rivals hoard raw thread; prices go vertical. *The cornering merchant has a ledger bound in human skin. The names inside are his competitors.*
- K **Saint’s Procession** — Closes half the wards; ignore at peril, faith walks the streets. *The icon weeps dyewater. The faithful collect it in silver cups.*
- A **Curse Awakened** — In canals: no route reaches the address you seek. *The water is still. Your reflection is gone. You are still here—for now.*

(Permit/Seat/Escort) Bridge token for peak-hour cart crossing free; dye-permit chit to process “questionable” color this week.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Bridge Token** — One peak-hour cart crossing free; traffic as currency. *The token is a bronze coin with a hole in the center. The hole is the toll.*
3. **Dye-Permit** — Process “questionable” color this week; law bends for coin. *The permit is written on dyed vellum. The color changes with the tide.*
4. **Warehouse Seal** — From Matron’s office; rivals legally shut out. *The seal is a brass bell. Ring it once to claim the space.*
5. **Exchange Pass** — Day pass to trade without sponsor; freedom in paper. *The pass is stamped with a spider. The spider’s legs are the signatures of three guilds.*
6. **Watergate Priority** — Skip one flood closure when it matters; tide waits for none. *The priority token is a dried eel skin. Show it, and the gate-keeper spits but stands aside.*
7. **Notarial Indulgence** — Retrofit a missing recital; past deals stand. *The indulgence is written in lemon juice. Heat it to see the terms.*
8. **Wormhouse Allotment** — Claim a share of the next hatch; future in cocoons. *The allotment is a silk-worm egg. Keep it warm, or it will hatch into a debt.*
9. **Ropewalk Credit** — Hire crews before you have coin; muscle on credit. *The credit is a knotted rope. Cut a knot for each favor called.*
10. **Arsenal Key** — One night’s issue for retinue; arms in trusted hands. *The key is a finger bone. The lock is a gauntleted fist.*

- J **Condotta Rider** — City watch escorts through any ward, once. *The rider’s horse has iron shoes. The sparks tell him who to watch.*
- Q **Matron’s Audience** — Private whisper becomes policy; velvet commands. *The Matron’s ear is a bell. Speak into it, and the city listens—once.*
- K **Tax-Farm Share** — On Three-Queens stalls for a season; profit in peddlers. *The share is a tally stick. Break it in half to claim your portion.*
- A **Golden Thread** — Temporary charter to set tolls on a named canal. *The thread is real gold. It will not break—but it will stretch.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (permits/seats/escorts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **silk and water** motifs—threads that bind, currents that remember, bargains that stain canal beds.

Additional Features

- **Duel Etiquette:** Duels fought on bridges draw crowds eager to wager on blood. Refusing stains a name worse than losing.
- **Dyewater Omens:** Canals run strange colors at dawn; red foretells riots, blue brings calm, black means curses awakened.
- **Matron’s Seal:** Any contract bearing her seal is law—but the Matron is known to rescind seals without warning, leaving debts tangled.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice near the Salt Gate. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the bobbin-runners, trying to untie her own cord.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Archivolt notaries keep a secret ledger of unquiet debts—Class II Anchors bound to unpaid contracts. Saikou Ira would have a seizure here.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A cursed bolt of silk surfaces on the Exchange every decade. Anyone who wears it prospers—until the next full moon. The bolt is due to appear tonight.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Silkstrand psions are called “Weft-Readers.” They see the threads of obligation. The Matron employs three—and has never let them meet each other.

- **The Ninth:** In any Silkstrand scene, the ninth bridge crossed in a day leads somewhere unexpected. The wise stop at eight and take a boat.

Silkstrand Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Canal:** Toss a crust into the water before crossing a new bridge. Ignore the first *Bridge Riot* penalty.
- **Knot the Thread:** Tie a single knot in a scrap of silk. Cancel *Seal Counterfeit* or take −1 die on your next negotiation (your choice).
- **Name to the Dyewater:** Whisper a debtor’s name into the canal at dawn. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from them this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Archivolt.

Patronage & Power

In Silkstrand, power flows through commerce, connections, and the careful weaving of influence. The Matron maintains control through a web of guilds, factors, and condottieri, each bound by contracts and customs that shift like the tides. Merchants rise and fall with the Exchange, while the city’s bravos and smugglers operate in the spaces between law and profit.

For the GM: Patronage in Silkstrand revolves around access—to bridges, to warehouses, to the Exchange floor itself. Rewards often take the form of permits, seals, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, tokens, contracts) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival guilds issue conflicting charters, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the bridges, markets, and Exchange as arenas for social contests, where reputation and connections determine success.

In Silkstrand, your word is your weave, and your weave determines whether you rise or drown.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **city watch** or **rival merchants**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **crowds** or **bridge traffic**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers** or **customs**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Bridge bailiff or guildmaster becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **crowd movement or flood**.
- **Foe Appears:** A rival merchant or hired bravo arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **condottieri, smugglers, or guild enforcers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **flood hits/contract voided/duel declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **The Matron, Watch Captain, or Guildmistress** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **flood rises/bridge collapses/procession blocks streets**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Silkstrand (Bridges & Trade):** Bridge planks shift underfoot, bargains restructure mid-speech, coins change hands without touch.
- **Silkstrand (Dyewater):** Canal colors shift ominously, dyes stain more than cloth, water carries whispered names.
- **Silkstrand (Duel Culture):** Challenges are issued mid-conversation, seconds appear from the crowd, honor prices rise with each breath.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Corseted Ledger (cursed accounting bound in silk)** — *Phases*: Friendly Audit → Retroactive Debts → Names as Collateral. *Cracks*: burn one forged seal in public; settle a rival’s debt at cost; wash the book on Flood-Stairs at high bell.
- **Archivolt Ragman (collector of “missing recitals”)** — *Phases*: Quiet Inserts → Paper Hunts → Bridge Vetoes. *Cracks*: win a duel for precedent; expose a double-entry altar; break his pen with the Matron’s Seal.
- **Color That Walks (dyewater revenant)** — *Phases*: Stain → Spread → Drown. *Cracks*: confess on Three-Queens; bind scent-rights properly; let the Saint of Warps unpick a life’s thread (costly).

4.20 Theona — “Three Greens, No Ninth”

Matron of Wells (Elite): “The wells here hold more than water – they hold the dreams and prayers of generations. To govern is to tend these sacred spaces where the living commune with what came before.”

Peat-Cutter (Commoner): “The land here remembers everything, especially what you don’t say. Skip the ninth step, forget the ninth name, and the green earth takes note. Best keep your omissions honest.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The isles of Theona rise green and jagged from the Dolmis, their basalt cliffs wrapped in mists and moorland song. Nominally a duchy sworn to Viterra, in truth the Three Greens heed no crown but their own moots, no law but their taboos. The greatest of these is the silence of Nine: no bell tolls a ninth, no bridge counts that span, no oath dares its syllable. It is said that those who break the ban invite the Green Host, and that debts of nine can never be paid in coin.

What you notice first: The smell of wet peat and salt. The silence that follows every eighth bell-ring. The way locals count on their fingers—thumb, then fingers, then a long pause where the ninth should be.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never pour the ninth cup at a feast. Never speak the ninth name in a bargain. Never step where a step is missing. The Green Host rides for those who complete what should remain incomplete.

Regional Mood: Three Greens, No Ninth

Here, peace is a ritual, and every word sharpens the blade that seals it. Theona is claimed by Viterra but ruled by moots, well-keepers, and the old faith. Linn longships cut through the fog for raiding; Ashaani slavers hunt the coves in stolen coracles; pirates from Zakov and the Vilikari shore trade stolen goods for kelp and salt. Sidhi sailors and Aelinnel factors run cargo up the tide-stairs, and Aelaerem hedge-wives barter red thread for hawthorn passes. Through it all, the Ninth Taboo threads every handshake, every toast, every whispered prayer. To break it is to invite the Green Host—and the Host does not bargain.

Starting Location: A Moot Hill under rain, where vows are carved into stone and knives gleam beside the altar. A Bride-Peacemaker draws a blade between two bloodlines. “The ninth vow was never spoken,” she says. “But the Green Host remembers. Bring us the head of the slaver who burned the eastern strand, and the feud will end. Fail, and your name will join the uncounted.”

(Ringfort/Well/Cliff) Basalt tide-stairs cut into cove; everyone steps past a “missing” rung; Saint’s Well under hawthorn hung with ribbons.

Spades — Places

2. **Tide-Stairs** — Basalt steps into cove; everyone skips the “missing” rung. *The missing step is still there—you just can’t see it. Step where it should be, or don’t*

step at all.

3. **Saint’s Well** — Under hawthorn hung with ribbons and secrets; wishes tied in cloth. *The ribbons are knotted in eights. The ninth knot is never tied—only imagined.*
4. **Fog-Wick Tower** — Burning peat; bell plays eight notes, never nine. *The bell-ringer wears a mask. Underneath, he has no mouth—only a whisper.*
5. **Black Bog Causeway** — White stones like teeth; will-lights test your stride. *The stones were set by a king who drowned. He counts each footstep from below.*
6. **Cliff Ringfort** — Over kelp-nets; storm-ladders creak like hymns. *The ladders are hauled up at dusk. If you’re left below, you sleep with the tide.*
7. **Barrow Field** — Standing stones; birds hush at noon, the earth remembers. *The stones have ears. Do not speak a secret you cannot afford to lose.*
8. **Sea-Cave Harp** — Tide-ropes sing under headland; echoes bargain for safe passage. *The harp has no player. It plays itself when the drowned want to speak.*
9. **Uncounted Bridge** — Nine-arch causeway; locals tally “eight-and-one.” *The ninth arch is there—but the locals will deny it. Walk it at your own risk.*
10. **Ogham Grove** — Carved pillars around an absent ninth post; runes speak in silence. *The missing post was removed by a king who broke a vow. The runes still curse his line.*
- J **Coracle Harbor** — Jammed in a notch; upturned boats roof the sheds. *The coracles are made of hide and guilt. Each one has carried a secret.*
- Q **Green Moot Hill** — Three Greens’ court; benches of turf, salt wind judges. *The wind never stops. It carries the votes of the dead.*
- K **High Hall** — Whale-rib beams; storm banners sleep, kings are chosen. *The kings are chosen by lot—a knotted cord pulled from a pot. The cord has eight knots.*
- A **Lookout Cliff** — One vantage where all three isles stand in a single gaze. *From here, you can see the Green Host riding on the horizon—if it wants you to.*

(Moot/Keeper/Court) Peat-cutter with steady barrow and steadier gossip; well-keeper who ties ribbons and unknots feuds.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Peat-Cutter** — Steady barrow, steadier gossip; knows every hidden path. *Her barrow has a false bottom. She hides debts there—and bodies.*
3. **Well-Keeper** — Ties ribbons, unknots feuds; wishes and wisdom in equal measure. *She never ties a ninth ribbon. The ninth wish is always her own.*

4. **Kelp-Netter** — Reads rip lines like ledgers; tide as teacher. *His net has a torn patch. He sewed it with thread from a hanged man’s shirt.*
5. **Harp-Satirist** — A few bars can end a career or a war; music as a weapon. *Her harp is strung with catgut and grudges. Each string is a name.*
6. **Wick-Warden** — Tends fog-lamps, counts in eights; guardian of the silent count. *He counts on his fingers—thumb, finger, finger, finger—and stops. The ninth is for the fog.*
7. **Taboo-Witness** — Geas-keeper who knows which words ruin deals. *She carries a bell with no clapper. She rings it with her tongue.*
8. **Island Abbot** — Saint’s bell, tolerant smile; faith in the old ways. *His bell rings eight times. The ninth ring is the silence that follows.*
9. **Green Neighbor** — Polite emissary from under the hill; borrowed boots, strange customs. *He never steps on a crack. He says the earth has teeth.*
10. **Coracle-Captain** — Eight-boat flotilla; swift as rumor, sure as the tide. *Her boats have no names. She says naming a vessel invites the Green Host to count it.*
- J **Bride-Peacemaker** — Walks between bloodlines with a silver knife; peace in marriage. *Her knife has a wooden blade. The families cut their palms with wood—blood without iron.*
- Q **Matron of Wells** — Queen-mother in truth if not in name; wisdom in water. *She drinks only from the ninth well—the one no one admits exists.*
- K **Three-Isles King** — Elected by the moots; whale-bone throne, weathered eyes. *He lost his left hand to a Linn raid. The replacement is carved from hawthorn.*
- A **Lady Beneath** — Unseen queen who bargains in dreams; hawthorn’s whisper. *She has no face. Those who see her forget their own names for a year.*

(Fog/Feud/Taboo) Ground-mist erases tracks; horns travel, edges do not; bog-lights lure teamster off the causeway.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Ground-Mist** — Erases tracks; horns travel, edges do not; navigation by sound alone. *The mist has a voice. It whispers your name—but only once.*
3. **Bog-Lights** — Lure teamster off the causeway; recovery costs time and pride. *The lights are the souls of debtors. Follow them, and you’ll never pay your way out.*
4. **Spoken Geas** — No ninth word in parley—or the deal curdles like milk. *The word you cannot speak sits on your tongue like a stone.*
5. **Salt-Rot** — Smokehouse fails; fish spoil, tempers rise like the tide. *The salt was cut with grave dust. Someone wanted the winter to be hard.*

6. **Procession Clash** — Saint-day vs. hawthorn taboo; shutters slam, peace fractures. *The saint’s banner and the green branch cannot touch. When they do, blood follows.*
7. **Wave-Count** — Eighth swell, Nameless follows; boats tremble, sailors pray. *The ninth swell never comes. But something rides the eighth.*
8. **Ringfort Wakes** — A bone-judge is “consulted”; now you’re named in the old law. *The bone-judge’s skull is filled with peat smoke. It speaks in riddles—and judgments.*
9. **Ninth Law** — Something vital cannot be counted, measured, or named. *You try to count your crew. The number keeps changing.*
10. **Net-Surge** — Harbor stairs; kelp wraps ankles and alibis like truth. *The kelp moves against the current. Someone underneath is pulling.*
- J **Bride-Theft** — At Moot—peace flips to feud; you’re caught mid-ritual. *The stolen bride’s hand is cold. She has been dead for a year.*
- Q **Mainland Return** — Exile with papers; elders arrested “for progress.” *The papers are stamped with a Viterran seal. The seal is still warm—and wrong.*
- K **Green Host Rides** — Hooves like drums, cattle scatter, sentries sleep. *The riders have no faces—only masks of woven hawthorn.*
- A **Great Fog** — Routes loop, bells lie, every promise takes the long way. *The fog is old. It remembers promises made to the dead.*

(Blessing/Token/Right) Well-blessing for a named ford crossing; moot token with eight-knotted cord skips local queues.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Well-Blessing** — Named ford crosses you safely, once; water remembers your need. *The blessing is a ribbon. Tie it to your wrist. Do not tie a ninth knot.*
3. **Moot Token** — Eight-knotted cord; skip any local queue or judgment. *The cord is braided from horsehair and silence. Cut a knot to speak.*
4. **Harbor-Green** — Painted mark exempts your boat from the next levy; tide as ally. *The mark is a circle with an eighth cut. The missing slice is the toll.*
5. **Hawthorn Pass** — Immunity from a single local taboo (for one scene). *The pass is a hawthorn twig. Carry it in your mouth. Do not chew.*
6. **Bell-Right** — Lawful ring at a fog-wick summons the watchers; law travels on sound. *The bell has no clapper. You must ring it with your own breath.*
7. **Coracle Share** — Crew and oars pledged for one crossing; tide as a steed. *The share is a tally stick. Break it in half to claim your passage.*

8. **Ogham Ruling** — Monk’s reading settles a dispute in your favor; runes as law. *The ruling is carved on a slate. The slate is damp. The runes may change by morning.*
9. **Unnumbered Right** — Ignore the Ninth prohibition for one action (costs a favor later). *The right is a silence. Use it, and the Green Host will ask for its name.*
10. **Salt-Cure License** — Process scarce fish despite ration edicts; preservation as power. *The license is signed with a thumbprint. The thumb is not yours.*
- J **Bride-Charter** — Two feuding houses sheath knives for a season; peace in marriage. *The charter is written on a wedding veil. The bloodstains are from the dowry.*
- Q **Private Moot** — With Matron and King; whispers become policy. *The moot is held in a fog hollow. What is spoken there is never written.*
- K **Whale-Escort** — Eight-oar guards across the Dolmis reach; strength in numbers. *The crew carries your name on a scrap of vellum. If the paper gets wet, you are alone.*
- A **Green Favor** — One uncanny exception to custom, spoken beneath hawthorn. *The favor is a dream. When you wake, the hawthorn will remember—even if you don’t.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (blessings/tokens/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- The “No Ninth” custom: whenever a 9 appears in your seed, add an omission to the scene (a missing step, an unsaid name, an unseen guest). If the 9 is a Diamond, you may break the taboo once—but someone will come to collect later.
- If any A appears, echo **green and count** motifs—hawthorn that whispers, bells that miscount, promises that take the long way home.

Additional Features

- **The Silent Count:** Players and GMs are encouraged to omit a detail (a name, a step, a tally) when the Ninth appears, echoing Theona’s taboo.
- **Green Host’s Omen:** Any dream sequence or omen may be framed as the ride of the Green Host—hoofbeats across the sky, wind through the moors, sea spray tasting of salt and blood.
- **Bride-Peace Feasts:** Weddings, truces, and funerals blur; sharing a feast can end a feud for a season—or doom a guest if the ninth cup is poured.

- **Raider’s Shadow:** Theona’s coves are haunted by Linn longships, Ashaani slave barges, and Zakov pirates. Sidhi and Vilikari sailors crew the coracle fleets, while Aelinnel and Aelaerem traders bring red thread and counting stones from the far shore of the Dolmis.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice near the Sea-Cave Harp. They ask no payment—but they count breaths in eights. A renegade Sister hides among the peat-cutters, trying to forget her own cord.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Ogham Grove is a Class II Anchor site—the missing ninth post holds a spirit that cannot be named. Saikou Ira would ring every bell but the ninth.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the coracle crews. Take it, and the Green Host will not ride for you—until the ninth tide.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Theona’s “Taboo-Witnesses” are natural psions. They read omissions in the same way others read thoughts.
- **The Ninth:** In any Theona scene, the ninth person to speak in a room draws the Green Host’s attention. The wise hold their tongues until someone else breaks the count.

Theona Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Bog:** Toss a crust into the mist before crossing a causeway. Ignore the first *Ground-Mist* penalty.
- **Knot the Eighth:** Tie a single knot in a ribbon before a moot. Cancel *Spoken Geas* or take −1 die on your next oath (your choice).
- **Name to the Well:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into Saint’s Well. Gain +1 Effect against his kin for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Matron.

Patronage & Power

In Theona, power flows through ancient custom, sacred spaces, and the careful observance of taboo. The Three Greens maintain their independence through a web of moots, well-keepers, and geas-keepers who ensure the old laws are honored. The King and Matron rule by consensus and tradition, while the unseen Lady Beneath influences events through dreams and whispers.

For the GM: Patronage in Theona revolves around blessings, exemptions, and the delicate balance of keeping or breaking taboos. Rewards often take the form of tokens, rights, or divine favor that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (ribbons, tokens, blessings) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival factions issue conflicting exemptions, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the moots, wells, and causeways as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of custom determines success.

In Theona, your word is your weave, and your weave determines whether you walk the green path or invite the Host.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **moot-keepers or well-guardians**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **coracle crews or ringfort sentries**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or green neighbors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Wick-warden or moot official** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **mist shift or taboo breach**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **feuding house member or bone-judge** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **coracle crews**, **green neighbors**, or **moot enforcers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **taboo broken/green host rides/feud declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **King, Matron, or Lady Beneath** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog rises/bells ring/causeway shifts**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Theona (Silent Count):** Steps disappear mid-climb, names vanish from lips, the ninth item in a list goes unmentioned.
- **Theona (Green Host):** Hoofbeats echo without a horse, mist takes familiar shapes, dreams predict the next action.
- **Theona (Taboo Law):** Words refuse to form, actions miscount, promises require exact phrasing.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Unsung Bell (forbidden note given will)** — *Phases:* Hum in Mist → Echo Under Well-stone → Command of Fog. *Cracks:* bind its clapper with eight ribbons; let a rival speak the ninth and pay; drown the echo at the Sea-Cave Harp.
- **Bride-Thief of the Green Host (dream raider)** — *Phases:* Invitation in Sleep → Procession Across Moor → Feast Without Ninth Cup. *Cracks:* cut the dream-veil with silver; sing satire at the Green Moot Hill; trade a Bride-Charter.
- **The Missing Step (living omission)** — *Phases:* Vanished Witness → Unread Clause → Unwalkable Bridge. *Cracks:* invite a Taboo-Witness to count aloud; spill nine drops into Saint’s Well but *name only eight*; let the Lady Beneath keep a memory.